unfoldingWord® Translation Notes © 2022 unfoldingWord. Released under CC BY-SA 4.0 license. unfoldingWord® Translation Notes has been adapted in the following languages: Tok Pisin, Arabic (عربي), French (Français), Hindi (हिंदी), Indonesian (Bahasa Indonesia), Portuguese (Português), Russian (Русский), Spanish (Español), Swahili (Kiswahili), and Simplified Chinese (简体中文) from unfoldingWord® Translation Notes © 2022 unfoldingWord. Released under CC BY-SA 4.0 license by Mission Mutual

Song of Songs - Introduction

Song of Songs

Song of Songs - Introduction

Part 1: General Introduction

Outline of the Song of Songs

1. The title of the book (1:1)
2. The woman longs for the man she loves (1:2–1:7)
3. The man responds to the woman he loves (1:8–1:11)
4. The woman speaks to herself (1:12–1:14)
5. The man praises the woman he loves (1:15)
6. The woman responds to the man she loves (1:16–2:1)
7. The man responds to what the woman said in 2:1 (2:2)
8. The woman speaks to the man she loves, herself, and the women of Jerusalem (2:3–3:11)
9. The man praises the woman he loves (4:1–4:11)
10. The garden metaphor (4:12–5:1)
11. The woman and the women of Jerusalem speak to each other (5:2–6:1)
12. The woman speaks to herself (6:2–6:3)
13. The man praises the woman he loves (6:4–10)
14. The man goes to the walnut-tree orchard and imagines he is among chariots (6:11–6:12)
15. The women of Jerusalem speak to the woman, and the man replies to them (6:13)
16. The man praises the woman he loves and expresses his desire to be intimate with her (7:1–9a)
17. The woman responds to the man she loves (7:9b-8:3)
18. The woman speaks to the women of Jerusalem (8:4)
19. The women of Jerusalem see the woman and man coming from the wilderness (8:5a)
20. The woman expresses her thoughts on their love to the man she loves (8:5b–7)
21. The woman's brothers speak about their sister (8:8–9)
22. The woman responds to her brothers (8:10–12)
23. The man and the woman speak their concluding thoughts to each other (8:13–14)

There are different views among biblical scholars regarding how this book is structured and, therefore, how it should be outlined. The outline above offers one possible way of outlining this book.

What is the Song of Songs about?

The Song of Songs is a poem or a series of poems that celebrate love and intimacy between a man and a woman. Jews traditionally have interpreted the book as a picture of God's love for his people Israel. Until the 1800's the main view among Christians was that this book is primarily a picture of the love between Christ and his bride, the Church. Since the 1800's the more common view has been that it is a poem or a series of poems that give a beautiful picture of love between a man and a woman. Many Christians also think that, even though the main meaning of this poem is to give a beautiful portrayal of romantic love between a man and a woman, this book also contains lessons about God's love for his bride, the Church.

Who wrote the Song of Songs?

The first verse of the book ("The Song of Songs, which is of Solomon") gives the idea that King Solomon of Israel wrote it. However, there are several possible ways to interpret the meaning of this title. A translation note for this verse discusses the possible meanings.

How should the title of this book be translated?

This book is traditionally titled "Song of Songs," which means the very best song, or "Song of Solomon." It may also be called "Songs of Love," "Great Poems of Love," or "The Love Songs of Solomon." (See: How to Translate Names)

Part 2: Important Religious and Cultural Concepts

What place do the descriptions of sexual behavior have in the Song of Songs?

The Song of Songs approves of sexual behavior which expresses love between a husband and his wife.

Part 3: Important Translation Issues

How many characters are in the Song of Songs?

The two main characters in this book are the man and the woman, two people who love each other. In 8:8–9 the woman's brothers speak among themselves. In different places throughout the book, a group of women called the "daughters of Jerusalem" speak or are spoken to. However, it is possible that the group of women is not real but imagined. They may have been written into the poem for poetic effect.

Some interpreters believe there may be more characters than these, but this is not certain. The ULT and UST versions recognize only the man, the woman, the group of women (and possibly a group of friends in some parts), and the woman's brothers.

What are the lines in the UST about people speaking?
The Song of Songs is a poem that shows the words and thoughts of a man, a woman, the woman's friends, and the woman's brothers. Throughout the poem, the author does not identify the speakers and their audience. To help readers understand the poem, some translations attempt to identify the speaker and the audience. Since it is not always certain who is speaking, translations sometimes disagree about the identity of the speaker.

The UST places a header before each speech to identify the speaker and the audience. For example: "The woman speaking to the women of Jerusalem," "The woman speaking to the man," "The man speaking to the woman," or "The woman speaking to herself." Translators are encouraged to include these ways of identifying the speaker and the audience. Be careful to format them differently from the scripture text. The translators should also include an initial note to their readers indicating that these explanations are not part of the scripture text.

There are different views among Bible scholars about who the man is—a shepherd boy or King Solomon. Some think that both speak at various times in this book and compete for the woman's love. The headers in the UST indicate when a man is speaking or being spoken to, as in "The man speaking to the woman he loves" and "The woman speaking to the man she loves." The headers do not indicate the identity of the man.

How should one translate the Song of Songs if the readers would view certain terms as coarse, vulgar, or improper?
Readers might consider many images or forms in the Song of Songs as socially improper when translated. Whenever possible, the translator should try to avoid offensive language by using expressions that will not cause offense. (See: Euphemism)

How do I translate metaphors and similes in this book?
Because the author uses images throughout this book to express things in a beautiful and captivating way, it is recommended that you maintain these images or select images from your culture and language that communicate the same concepts.

The many metaphors and similes in this book are used to add poetic beauty and emotional effect; however, their meaning is sometimes unclear. Sometimes the reader does not know whether a sexual meaning is intended. At times the wording carries both a literal and a sexual meaning. However, though meanings are often unclear, it is not always necessary to clarify the meaning; often ambiguity in translation is best. You could translate the words as they are written to avoid committing to a specific meaning. (See: Metaphor)

Translating terms of endearment
The word which the ULT translates as "my beloved" occurs 26 times in this book. Each time it occurs the woman uses it to refer to the man she loves. You should translate this term consistently throughout this book. The word which the ULT translates as "my darling" appears nine times in this book. Each time it occurs the man uses it to refer to the woman he loves. Be sure to translate this term consistently throughout the book.

Song of Songs - Chapter 1 Introduction

Translation Issues in This Chapter

Metaphors
In the ancient Near East, it was common to describe a woman by using metaphors involving animals. In many cultures today, such metaphors could be considered offensive. Cultures vary in the metaphors of beauty they use to describe women. (See: Metaphor)

The lines indicating who is speaking and who is being spoken to
Throughout the poem, the author does not identify the speakers or their audience. To help readers understand the poem, some translations attempt to identify the speaker and the audience. It is not always certain who the speaker is, so sometimes translations disagree about the identity of the speaker. Before each speech, the UST places a header to identify the speaker and the audience. You may wish to do the same in your translation.

"I am black"
In the ancient Near East, wealthy people usually had lighter skin because they did not need to work outside, where the sun darkened their skin. Because this young woman had to work outside in the sun, her skin became dark. This is why she says "I am black" in 1:5–6.

Song of Songs 1:1 (#1)

שִׁ֣יר הַשִּׁירִ֔ים אֲשֶׁ֖ר לִשְׁלֹמֹֽה

"The Song of Songs, which {is} of Solomon"

This verse is the title of this book. Use whatever formatting convention is most natural in your language for indicating the title of a poem or song. The ULT places this line further to the left than the other lines in this book to indicate that this verse is the title.

See: Poetry

Song of Songs 1:1 (#2)

שִׁ֣יר הַשִּׁירִ֔ים

“The Song of Songs”

The possessive form in **Song of Songs** is used here to indicate a comparison with other **Songs** and to show that this **Song** is the best or greatest of all songs. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use another form to indicate this. Alternate translation: [The best song] or [The most excellent song] or [The greatest song]

See: Possession

Song of Songs 1:1 (#3)

לִשְׁלֹמֹ֖ה

“is} of Solomon”

The phrase **of Solomon** could mean: (1) Solomon wrote this song. Alternate translation: [Solomon wrote]; (2) this song was dedicated to Solomon. Alternate translation: [is dedicated to Solomon]; (3) this song was about Solomon. Alternate translation: [is about Solomon]

See: Possession

Song of Songs 1:2 (#1)

יִשָּׁקֵ֥נִי מִנְּשִׁיקׇ֖ות פִּ֑יהוּ

“Let him kiss me with the kisses of his mouth”

Here, **kiss me with the kisses of his mouth** is an emphatic construction that uses a verb and its object that come from the same root. You may be able to use the same construction in your language to express the meaning here. Alternatively, your language may have another way of showing the emphasis. Alternate translation: [Let him kiss me again and again with the kisses of his mouth] or [Let him cover my face with the kisses of his mouth] or [I wish he would kiss me passionately with his mouth]

See: Poetry

Song of Songs 1:2 (#2)

דֹּדֶ֔יךָ

“your love”

In this book every occurrence of the words **you** and **your** is singular. Your language may require you to mark these forms.

See: Forms of ‘You’ — Singular

Song of Songs 1:2 (#3)

טֹובִ֥ים דֹּדֶ֖יךָ מִיָּֽיִן

“better {is} your love than wine”

If your language does not use an abstract noun for the idea of **love**, you could express the same idea in another way. Alternate translation: [the way you love me is better than wine] or [your loving is better than wine]

See: Abstract Nouns

Song of Songs 1:2 (#4)

טֹובִ֥ים דֹּדֶ֖יךָ מִיָּֽיִן

“better {is} your love than wine”

Alternate translation: [I enjoy your love more than I enjoy drinking wine] or [your love is more pleasant than wine]

Song of Songs 1:2–4 (#1)

יִשָּׁקֵ֥נִי מִנְּשִׁיקׇ֖ות פִּ֑יהוּ כִּֽי־טֹובִ֥ים דֹּדֶ֖יךָ מִיָּֽיִן׃ לְרֵ֣יחַ שְׁמָנֶ֔יךָ טֹובִ֥ים שֶׁ֖שֶׁן תּוּרַ֣ק שְׁמֶ֑ךָ עַל־כֵּ֥ן עֲלָמֹ֖ות אֲהֵבֽוּךָ׃ מָשְׁכֵ֖נִי אַחֲרֶ֑יךָ נָּרֻ֣צָה הֱבִיאַ֤נִי הַמֶּ֙לֶךְ֙ חֲדָרָ֔יו

“Let him kiss me with the kisses of his mouth, for better {is} your love than wine.As for the scent of your oils—{they are} good; oil poured out {is} your name. Therefore, marriageable women love you.Draw me after you; let us run. The king has brought me {to} his bedroom”

These lines of poetry most likely indicate internal words or thoughts, things that the woman is thinking while she is alone. Your language may have a way of indicating speech that is expressed toward a person who is not present to hear what is being said. If your language has a way to indicate that, you could use it here.

See: Poetry

Song of Songs 1:3 (#6)

עֲלָמֹ֖ות

“marriageable women”

Here, **marriageable women** refers to young women who are old enough to be married or who have been recently married but not yet given birth to a child. Your language may have a term for women during this stage of life that you could use here, or you could use a more general term.

See: Translate Unknowns

Song of Songs 1:3 (#4)

שֶׁמֶן תּוּרַק שְׁמֶךָ

“oil poured out {is} your name”

The woman makes a comparison between the man’s reputation (which she refers to as his **name**) and scented oil that is poured out, after which the good smell of the oil spreads as the air moves. If it would be helpful in your language, you could explain the comparison. Alternate translation: [your reputation spreads like the fragrance of scented oil spreads after it has been poured out] or [your reputation spreads like the scent of perfumed oil after it has been poured out]

See: Metaphor

Song of Songs 1:3 (#1)

לְרֵיחַ

“As for the scent of”

The Hebrew word which the ULT translates as **As for** could: (1) indicate reference, in which case it should be translated with an equivalent phrase or as the ULT translates it. Alternate translation: [In reference to the scent of]; (2) indicate emphasis or be making an assertion. Alternate translation: [Truly, the scent of] or [Indeed, the scent of]

Song of Songs 1:3 (#3)

שֶׁמֶן תּוּרַק שְׁמֶךָ

“oil poured out {is} your name”

Here, **your name** represents her beloved’s reputation. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use an equivalent expression or state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [oil poured out is your reputation] or [your name is pleasant like good perfume is pleasant]

See: Metonymy

Song of Songs 1:3 (#5)

עַל־כֵּן

“Therefore”

The Hebrew words translated as **Therefore** indicate that what follows is a result of what came before. Use a connector in your language that makes it clear that what follows is a result of what came before. Alternate translation: [As a result]

See: Connect — Reason-and-Result Relationship

Song of Songs 1:3 (#2)

שְׁמָנֶיךָ טוֹבִים

“your oils—{they are} good”

Here, **oils** refers to colognes or perfumes. The author is assuming the reader knows that pleasant-smelling spices were mixed into olive oil in order to make a pleasant-smelling perfume, which was then applied to the skin. You could include this information if that would be helpful to your readers. If men do not put pleasant-smelling things on their skin in your culture, you could say that the scent of the man being spoken of here is pleasant. Alternate translation: [your colognes—they are good] or [your scented oils—they are good] or [your skin—it is good] or [your body—it is good]

See: Assumed Knowledge and Implicit Information

Song of Songs 1:4 (#4)

הַמֶּלֶךְ

“The king”

Here the woman is speaking affectionately of the man she loves as if he were **The king**. She is not speaking of an actual king but using the word as a term of endearment. She is still speaking of the same man that she was speaking of in 1:2–3. If it would be helpful in your language, you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [He whom I love is like a king to me and] or [He who is like a king to me]

See: Metaphor

Song of Songs 1:4 (#7)

נָגִילָה וְנִשְׂמְחָה בָּךְ נַזְכִּירָה דֹדֶיךָ מִיַּיִן

“Let us be glad and rejoice in you. Let us profess your love more than wine”

The **us** in these two lines could be: (1) a group of young women speaking about the man. Alternate translation: [We will be glad and rejoice in you. We will profess your love more than wine]; (2) the woman continuing to speak to the man she loves and using **us** to refer

to herself. Alternate translation: [May I be glad and rejoice in you. May I profess your love more than wine]

See: Exclusive and Inclusive ‘We’

Song of Songs 1:4 (#8)

נָרֻוצָה & נָגִ֣ילָה & נַזְכִּ֣ירָה

“let us run & Let us be glad & Let us profess”

The word **us** is inclusive all three times that it occurs in this verse. Use the inclusive form of this word if your language marks that distinction.

See: Exclusive and Inclusive ‘We’

Song of Songs 1:4 (#2)

נָרֻוצָה

“let us run”

The word **us** refers to the young woman and the man that she is addressing, so use the inclusive form of that word if your language marks that distinction. Alternate translation: [let you and me run]

See: Exclusive and Inclusive ‘We’

Song of Songs 1:4 (#6)

הֱבִיאַ֨נִי

“has brought me”

Your language may say “taken” rather than **brought** in a context such as this. Use whichever is more natural. Alternate translation: [has taken me]

See: Go and Come

Song of Songs 1:4 (#12)

דֹּדֶ֖יךָ מִיָּֽיִן

“your love more than wine”

If your language does not use an abstract noun for the idea of **love**, you could express the same idea in another way. Alternate translation: [that the way you love is better than wine] or [that the way you love me is better than wine]

See: Abstract Nouns

Song of Songs 1:4 (#10)

נַזְכִּ֣ירָה

“Let us profess”

Alternate translation: [Let us proclaim]

Song of Songs 1:4 (#11)

מִיָּֽיִן

“more than wine”

The phrase **more than wine** could mean: (1) that the women would profess that the man’s love was more delightful than wine. Alternate translation: [as being more delightful than wine]; (2) that the women would profess the delightfulness of the man’s love more often than they would profess the delightfulness of wine. Alternate translation: [more often than we profess wine]

Song of Songs 1:4 (#3)

נָרֻוצָה

“let us run”

Here the woman uses **run** as a poetic way of expressing her desire that she and the man she loves should quickly go away together. You could include this information if that would be helpful to your readers. Alternate translation: [let us hurry]

See: Assumed Knowledge and Implicit Information

Song of Songs 1:4 (#5)

הֱבִיאַ֨נִי הַמֶּ֜לֶךְ

“The king has brought me”

The original language word which the ULT translates as **The king has brought me** could be describing: (1) a request or wish that the woman has. Alternate translation: [May the king bring me]; (2) an action that has already happened. Alternate translation: [The king brought me]

See: Statements — Other Uses

Song of Songs 1:4 (#9)

נָגִ֣ילָה וְנִשְׂמְחָ֔ה

“Let us be glad and rejoice”

The terms **be glad** and **rejoice** mean similar things. The author is using the two terms together for emphasis. If it would be clearer for your readers, you could express the emphasis with a single phrase. Alternate translation: [Let us greatly rejoice] or [Let us rejoice greatly]

See: Doublet

Song of Songs 1:4 (#13)

מֵישָׁרִ֖ים אֲהֵבֽוּךָ

“rightly do they love you”

Here the speaker could be: (1) the woman speaking to the man about the young women who admire him. Alternate translation: [rightly do the young women love you]; (2) the young women speaking of other women who admire the man. Alternate translation: [rightly do the other young women love you]. You may wish to indicate who the presumed speaker is here by placing a heading above this section, as modeled by the UST.

Song of Songs 1:4 (#1)

מָשְׁכֵ֣נִי

“Draw me”

Alternate translation: [Lead me]

Song of Songs 1:4 (#14)

מֵישָׁרִ֖ים אֲהֵבֽוּךְ

“rightly do they love you”

Alternate translation: [it is right that other young women adore you] or [no wonder other young women adore you]

Song of Songs 1:5 (#1)

שְׁחוֹרָ֣ה אֲנִ֔י

“I {am} black”

Solomon assumes that his readers will understand that here, **I am black** means “my skin is black” or “my skin is very dark.” If it would be helpful to your readers, you could include this information. Alternate translation: [My skin is black] or [My skin is very dark]

See: Assumed Knowledge and Implicit Information

Song of Songs 1:5 (#2)

וְנָאוָ֑ה

“but lovely”

Here the word **but** is introducing a contrast between what was expected and what follows. In the author’s culture, it was not considered attractive for a woman to have skin darkened by the sun. Use a natural form in your language for introducing a contrast. Alternate translation: [yet lovely] or [but still lovely]

See: Connect — Contrast Relationship

Song of Songs 1:5 (#3)

בְּנ֥וֹת יְרוּשָׁלָֽ͏ִם

“daughters of Jerusalem”

The woman is using the possessive form to poetically describe where the young women (**daughters of Jerusalem**) live. The phrase refers to the young women from Jerusalem; probably the same women as the “marriageable women” in 1:3 and “they” in 1:4. If your language would not use the possessive form for this, you could indicate the association between them in a way that is natural in your language. Alternate translation: [daughters from Jerusalem] or [young women from Jerusalem]

See: Possession

Song of Songs 1:5 (#4)

כְּאָהֳלֵ֣י קֵדָ֔ר כִּירִיעֹ֖ות שְׁלֹמֹֽה

“like the tents of Kedar, like the curtains of Solomon”

The **Kedar** people group used black goat skins to make their **tents**. The woman is comparing her skin to these tents. The phrase **the curtains of Solomon** refers to the beautiful curtains in Solomon’s palace. The point of the first comparison is that the woman’s skin was **black**. The second indicates that the woman was also **lovely**. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use equivalent comparisons from your culture, or you could state that explicitly. Alternate translation: [like the dark tents of the Kedar people, like the curtains of Solomon’s palace] or [as dark as the tents of Kedar, as beautiful as the curtains in Solomon’s palace]

See: Simile

Song of Songs 1:6 (#3)

שֶׁאֲנִ֥י שְׁחַרְחֹ֖רֶת

“that I {am} black”

Solomon assumes that his readers will understand that here, **I am black** means “my skin is black” or “my skin is very dark,” as it did in 1:5. If it would be helpful to your readers, you could include this information. Alternate translation: [that my skin is black] or [that my skin is very dark]

See: Assumed Knowledge and Implicit Information

Song of Songs 1:6 (#5)

שֶׁשְּׁזָפַ֥תְנִי הַשָּׁ֖מֶשׁ

“that the sun scorched me”

The author assumes that his readers will understand that **the sun scorched me** means “the sun made my skin color turn very dark.” You could include this

information if that would be helpful to your readers. Alternate translation: [that the sun darkened my skin]

See: Assumed Knowledge and Implicit Information

Song of Songs 1:6 (#1)

אַל־תִּרְאוּנִי שֶׁאֲנֲנִי שְׁחַרְחֹרֶת

“Do not look at me, that I {am} black”

The phrase **Do not look at me** could mean: (1) the woman does not want people to look at her with contempt. Alternate translation: [Do not look at me with contempt, that I am black] or [Do not look at me disapprovingly, that I am black]; (2) the woman does not want people to stare at her in admiration of her beauty. Alternate translation: [Do not stare at my beauty, that I am black]

Song of Songs 1:6 (#7)

כַּרְמִי שֶׁלִּי לֹא נָטָרְתִּי

“my vineyard that {is} mine I have not kept”

The woman is probably using the phrase **my vineyard** to refer to her skin. If it would be helpful in your language, you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [my skin I have not protected from the sun] or [I have not protected my complexion from the sun]

See: Metaphor

Song of Songs 1:6 (#4)

שֶׁשְּׁזָפַתְנִי הַשָּׁמֶשׁ

“that the sun scorched me”

The word **that** indicates that what follows is a reason for what came before. Use a connector in your language that makes it clear that what follows is a reason for what came before. Alternate translation: [because the sun scorched me]

See: Connect — Reason-and-Result Relationship

Song of Songs 1:6 (#2)

שֶׁאֲנֲנִי

“that I”

The word **that** indicates that what follows is a reason for what came before. Use a connector in your language that makes it clear that what follows is a reason for what came before. Alternate translation: [because I]

See: Connect — Reason-and-Result Relationship

Song of Songs 1:6 (#6)

נֹטֵרָה אֶת־הַכְּרָמִים כַּרְמִי שֶׁלִּי לֹא נָטָרְתִּי

“as} keeper of the vineyards— my vineyard that {is} mine I have not kept”

Alternate translation: [as caretaker of the vineyards— I have not taken care of my own vineyard]

Song of Songs 1:7 (#3)

שַׁלָּמָּה אֶהְיֶה כְּעֹטִיָּה עַל עֶדְרֵי חֲבֵרֶיךָ

“For why should I be like a woman who covers herself beside the flocks of your companions”

Here the woman is not asking for information but is using the question form for emphasis. If you would not use a rhetorical question for this purpose in your language, you could translate her words as a statement or an exclamation and communicate the emphasis in another way. Alternate translation: [I do not want to be like a woman who covers herself beside the flocks of your companions] or [Tell me so that I will not be like a woman who covers herself beside the flocks of your companions]

See: Rhetorical Question

Song of Songs 1:7 (#5)

שַׁלָּמָּה אֶהְיֶה כְּעֹטִיָּה עַל עֶדְרֵי חֲבֵרֶיךָ

“For why should I be like a woman who covers herself beside the flocks of your companions”

The woman does not want to look **like a woman who covers herself** because in her culture, prostitutes often covered their faces with a veil so that people would not recognize them. She did not want to be mistaken for a prostitute while attempting to find him. If it would be helpful in your language, you could state that explicitly. Alternate translation: [For why should I be like a prostitute who covers herself with a veil and wanders around among the flocks of your companions]

See: Simile

Song of Songs 1:7 (#4)

כְּעֹטִיָּה עַל עֶדְרֵי חֲבֵרֶיךָ

“like a woman who covers herself beside the flocks of your companions”

The author assumes that his readers will understand that **covers herself** means “covers herself with a veil.” The phrase **your companions** refers to the other shepherds who pastured their animals near the flocks

of the man; they were probably his friends. You could include this information if that would be helpful to your readers. Alternate translation: [like a woman who covers herself with a veil beside the flocks of the other shepherds]

See: Assumed Knowledge and Implicit Information

Song of Songs 1:7 (#1)

שֶׁשָּׁאֲהֵבָה֙ נַפְשִׁ֔י

“you} whom my soul loves”

The woman is using one part of herself, her **soul**, to represent all of her. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use an equivalent expression from your culture or state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [you, the man whom I love]

See: Synecdoche

Song of Songs 1:7 (#2)

אֵיכָ֤ה תִרְעֶה֙

“where do you graze”

The woman is leaving out some of the words that in many languages a sentence would need to be complete. You could supply these words from the context if it would be clearer in your language. Alternate translation: [where do you graze your flock] or [where do you graze your sheep]

See: Ellipsis

Song of Songs 1:8 (#1)

אִם־לֹ֣א תֵדְעִי֮ לָךְ֒ הַיָּפָ֣ה בַּנָּשִׁ֔ים צְאִי־לָ֖ךְ

“If you do not know, most beautiful among women, go out”

If it would help your readers to see that this is a conditional statement, you could supply a word like “then” in your translation. Alternate translation: [If you do not know, most beautiful among women, then go out]

See: Connect — Hypothetical Conditions

Song of Songs 1:8 (#2)

אִם־לֹ֣א תֵדְעִי֮ לָךְ֒ הַיָּפָ֣ה בַּנָּשִׁ֔ים

“If you do not know, most beautiful among women”

If it would be more natural in your language, you could begin this verse with the phrase **most beautiful among women**. Alternate translation: [Most beautiful among women, if you do not know]

See: Information Structure

Song of Songs 1:8 (#3)

צְאִי־לָ֖ךְ

“go out”

Your language may say “come” rather than **go** in contexts such as these. Use whichever is more natural. Alternate translation: [come out]

See: Go and Come

Song of Songs 1:8 (#4)

וּרְעִ֕י אֶת־גְּדִיֹּתַ֖יִךְ

“and pasture your young goats”

Alternate translation: [and let your young goats graze] or [and let your young goats eat]

Song of Songs 1:9 (#2)

לְסֻסָתִ֤י בְּרִכְבֵי֙ פַּרְעֹ֔ה דִּמִּיתִ֖יךְ

“To a mare among the chariots of Pharaoh I liken you”

The comparison **To a mare among the chariots of Pharaoh I liken you** could be: (1) the man saying that the excitement caused by a mare (a female horse) among Pharaoh’s male chariot horses is like the excitement that the woman caused him to feel. (2) the man saying that the beauty of the woman is like the beauty of one of Pharaoh’s mares. The horses of the king of Egypt, the Pharaoh, were known to be the best in the world and very beautiful. This is the second option because, normally, only stallions, not mares, pulled the chariots. Alternate translation: [Your beauty is like the beauty of Pharaoh’s chariot horses] or [I compare your beauty to the beauty of Pharaoh’s chariot horses]

See: Simile

Song of Songs 1:9 (#3)

בְּרִכְבֵי֙ פַּרְעֹ֔ה

“among the chariots of Pharaoh”

Here, **the chariots** represents “the horses that pull the chariots.” Chariots were normally drawn by pairs of male horses (stallions). If it would be helpful in your language, you could use an equivalent expression from your language or state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [among the stallions that pull Pharaoh’s chariots] or [among the stallions that pull the chariots of Pharaoh]

See: Metonymy

Song of Songs 1:9 (#1)

לְסֵסָתִי בְּרִכְבֵי פַרְעֹה דִּמִּיתִיךְ רַעְיָתִי

“To a mare among the chariots of Pharaoh I liken you, my darling”

If it would be more natural in your language, you could begin this verse with the phrase **my darling**. Alternate translation: [My darling, I liken you to a mare among the chariots of Pharaoh]

See: Information Structure

Song of Songs 1:9 (#4)

פַּרְעֹה

“Pharaoh”

The word **Pharaoh** is a title and represents kings of Egypt in general, not one particular king of Egypt. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use a more natural expression. Alternate translation: [the king of Egypt]

See: Generic Noun Phrases

Song of Songs 1:10 (#2)

בַּחֲרוּזִים

“with necklaces”

Here, **necklaces** are a type of jewelry worn around the neck to make a person look more attractive. If your readers would not be familiar with necklaces, you could use the name of something similar in your area, or you could use a more general term and make a footnote to explain what a necklace is. Alternate translation: [with neck ornaments] or [with strings of jewels]

See: Translate Unknowns

Song of Songs 1:10 (#1)

בַּתֹּרִים

“with earrings”

The term which the ULT translates as **earrings** refers to strings of small ornaments or jewels which hung down the side of one’s face from the ears. If your readers would not be familiar with this type of jewelry, you could use the name of something similar in your area, or you could use a more general term and put an explanation in a footnote. Alternate translation: [with neck ornaments] or [with strings of jewels]

See: Translate Unknowns

Song of Songs 1:11 (#2)

תּוֹרֵי זָהָב נַעֲשֶׂה־לָּךְ

“Earrings of gold we will make for you”

By **we**, the writer could mean: (1) that the man will have someone make the **Earrings of gold** for her. The man is not including the woman, so use the exclusive form of this word if your language marks that distinction. Alternate translation: [Earrings of gold I will have someone make for you] or [I will pay someone to make earrings of gold for you]; (2) that though the man is using a plural form, he expects the woman to understand that he means “I.” Alternate translation: [Earrings of gold I will make for you]; (3) that a group of people, and not the man, speak here. If you are using section headers, you can place a header above this section to indicate who you think is speaking.

See: Exclusive and Inclusive ‘We’

Song of Songs 1:11 (#1)

תּוֹרֵי

“Earrings of”

See how you translated the term **Earrings** in the previous verse.

See: Translate Unknowns

Song of Songs 1:11 (#3)

עִם נְקֻדּוֹת הַכָּסֶף

“with studs of silver”

Alternate translation: [with beads of silver] or [that are decorated with silver]

Song of Songs 1:12 (#4)

נָתַן רֵיחוֹ

“gave off its scent”

Alternate translation: [gave off its good odor] or [spread its pleasant aroma]

Song of Songs 1:12 (#3)

נִרְדִּי

“my nard”

The term **nard** refers to pleasant-smelling, perfumed oil that was made from the roots of the nard plant. If your readers would not be familiar with nard plants, you could use a general expression or describe what nard is. Alternate translation: [my perfumed oil] or [my pleasant-smelling perfume made from the nard plant]

See: Translate Unknowns

Song of Songs 1:12 (#1)

שֶׁשֶׁהַמֶּלֶךְ

“the king”

See how you translated the phrase **the king** in 1:4 where it is used with the same meaning.

See: Metaphor

Song of Songs 1:12 (#2)

בְּמְסִבּוֹ

“was} on his couch”

The word which the ULT translates as **couch** could: (1) refer to a couch, which is a long upholstered piece of furniture. (2) refer to a table. Alternate translation: [was at his table]

See: Translate Unknowns

Song of Songs 1:13 (#1)

צְרוֹר הַמֹּר ׀ דּוֹדִי לִי בֵּין שָׁדַי יָלִין

“A bundle of myrrh {is} my beloved to me; between my breasts it stays”

In the author’s culture, women sometimes wore a small bag or pouch of myrrh on a necklace so they could enjoy its pleasant fragrance. The woman makes a comparison between that enjoyable experience and that of having the man she loves near her. If it would be helpful in your language, you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [I enjoy having my beloved near me throughout the night just like I enjoy the fragrance of a bag of myrrh]

See: Metaphor

Song of Songs 1:13 (#2)

הַמֹּר

“myrrh”

Here, **myrrh** is a pleasant-smelling incense made from resin obtained from the bark of a certain kind of tree. If your readers would not be familiar with myrrh, you could use the name of something similar in your area, or you could use a more general term. Alternate translation: [pleasant-smelling perfume]

See: Translate Unknowns

Song of Songs 1:13 (#5)

יָלִין

“it stays”

Here the original language word that the ULT translates **it stays** is ambiguous regarding what it is that stays. This word could: (1) indicate that the **bundle of myrrh** is what stays. Alternate translation: [the bundle of myrrh stays]; (2) mean that the man does not leave that location throughout the night. Alternate translation: [he lingers]

See: Pronouns — When to Use Them

Song of Songs 1:13 (#3)

דּוֹדִי

“is} my beloved”

Alternate translation: [is my lover]

Song of Songs 1:13 (#4)

צְרוֹר הַמֹּר ׀ דּוֹדִי לִי בֵּין שָׁדַי יָלִין

“A bundle of myrrh {is} my beloved to me; between my breasts it stays”

If it would be helpful in your language, you could use a polite way of referring to **breasts**, or state the meaning of the phrase **between my breasts it stays** by using a more general expression. Alternate translation: [My beloved stays very close to me during the night, like a bundle of myrrh around my neck]

See: Euphemism

Song of Songs 1:14 (#1)

הַכֹּפֶר

“henna blossoms”

The phrase **henna blossoms** refers to pleasant-smelling blossoms from the henna plant. If your readers would not be familiar with this plant, you could use the name of a fragrant plant in your area, you could describe the henna plant, or you could use a more general term. Alternate translation: [fragrant flowers] or [fragrant blossoms from the henna plant]

See: Translate Unknowns

Song of Songs 1:14 (#2)

אֶשְׁכֹּל הַכֹּפֶר ׀ דּוֹדִי לִי בְּכַרְמֵי עֵין גֶּדִי

“A cluster of henna blossoms {is} my beloved to me, in the vineyards of Engedi”

Here the phrase **the vineyards of Engedi** refers to one of the most beautiful places in Israel, and the henna blossoms there were famous for their exquisite fragrance. In this verse, the woman makes a comparison

between the pleasurable experience of the vineyards and her enjoyment of having the man she loves near to her. If it would be helpful in your language, you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [The presence of my lover gives me feelings of pleasure] or [I delight in my beloved being near me like I delight in the smell of the henna flowers in the vineyards of En Gedi]

See: Metaphor

Song of Songs 1:15 (#2)

הִנְּךָ יָפָה רַעְיָתִי הִנְּךָ יָפָה עֵינַיִךְ יוֹנִים

“Behold you, beautiful, my darling! Behold you, beautiful! Your eyes {are} doves”

The man uses the phrase **Behold you, beautiful** two times for emphasis. If it would be helpful to your readers, you could combine the phrases and express emphasis in a way that is natural in your language. Alternate translation: [Behold you, beautiful, my darling! Your eyes are doves]

See: Parallelism

Song of Songs 1:15 (#4)

עֵינַיִךְ יוֹנִים

“Your eyes {are} doves”

Here the man is speaking of the woman’s **eyes** as if they were **doves**. If it would be helpful in your language, you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [Your eyes are like doves] or [Your eyes are gentle and beautiful]

See: Metaphor

Song of Songs 1:15 (#3)

רַעְיָתִי

“my darling”

See how you translated the phrase **my darling** in 1:9

Song of Songs 1:15 (#1)

הִנְּךָ & הִנְּךָ

“Behold you & Behold you”

The man is using the term **Behold** to focus the woman’s attention on what he is about to say. Your language may have a comparable expression that you can use in your translation. Alternate translation: [Look at you! ... Look at you!]

See: Metaphor

Song of Songs 1:16 (#2)

הִנְּךָ יָפָה דוֹדִי אַף־נָעִים אַף־עַרְשֵׂנוּ רַעֲנָנָה

“Behold you! {You are} handsome, my beloved, truly pleasant. Indeed, our couch is leafy”

If it would be more natural in your language, you could either begin or end this verse with the phrase **my beloved**. Alternate translation: [My beloved, behold you! You are handsome, truly pleasant. Indeed, our couch is leafy]

See: Information Structure

Song of Songs 1:16 (#1)

הִנְּךָ

“Behold you”

The woman is using the term **Behold** to focus the man’s attention on what she is about to say. Your language may have a comparable expression that you could use in your translation. Alternate translation: [Look at you]

See: Metaphor

Song of Songs 1:16 (#5)

עַרְשֵׂנוּ

“our couch is”

Here, **couch** refers to the place where the couple would lie down in the forest. If it would be helpful in your language, you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [the place where we lie down is] or [the place on which we lie down like a bed is]

See: Metaphor

Song of Songs 1:16 (#6)

רַעֲנָנָה

“leafy”

Here the word that the ULT translates as **leafy** could be translated in a general way such as “green,” or you could indicate a more specific meaning. Here, **leafy** could refer to: (1) the grass that the couple lay down on. Alternate translation: [grass]; (2) the branches above their meeting place in the forest. Alternate translation: [under the cover of branches] or [shaded by branches]. The author assumes that readers will understand that it is not a literal couch. You could include this information if it would be helpful to your readers.

See: Assumed Knowledge and Implicit Information

Song of Songs 1:16 (#4)

דוֹדִי֙ אַ֣ף נָעִ֔ים

“my beloved, truly pleasant”

The woman is leaving out some of the words that in many languages a sentence would need to be complete. You could supply these words from the context if it would be clearer in your language. Alternate translation: [my beloved. You are truly pleasant]

See: Ellipsis

Song of Songs 1:16 (#3)

דוֹדִי֙

“my beloved”

See how you translated the phrase **my beloved** in 1:13. Alternate translation: [my lover]

Song of Songs 1:17 (#2)

בְּרוֹתֵ֑ים

“are} pine”

The Hebrew word that the ULT translates as **pine** refers to a tall evergreen tree that is either a fir or a pine. This tree would provide a dense covering that would act like the **rafters** of a roof. If your readers would not be familiar with this type of tree, you could use the name of a similar tree in your area, or you could use a more general term. Alternate translation: [are tall leafy trees]

See: Translate Unknowns

Song of Songs 1:17 (#1)

קֹרוֹת֙ בָּתֵּ֣ינוּ אֲרָזִ֔ים רהיטנו בְּרוֹתִֽים

“The beams of our house {are} cedars; our rafters {are} pine”

Here the woman is speaking of the forest as if it were a **house**, the cedar trees as if they were the **beams** of the house, and the **pine** trees as if they were the **rafters** of the house. If it would be helpful in your language, you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [Our meeting place is shaded by cedar and pine trees] or [Branches of cedar and pine trees will be a canopy over our meeting place]

See: Metaphor

Song of Songs - Chapter 2 Introduction

Translation Issues in This Chapter

The woman and man compliment each other by using metaphors and similes

In 2:1 the woman uses a metaphor to tell the man she loves that she thinks she is common, like a flower that grows on the plains or a lily that grows in the valleys. The man responds in 2:2 by using a simile to tell her how special she is when compared to other women. She then uses a simile in 2:3 to tell him how special he is compared to other men. When translating these verses, pay close attention to the translation notes and the UST in order to understand the meaning.

Chiasm

Hebrew poetry sometimes uses a literary device called a “chiasm” (sometimes called “chiasmus”). A chiasm is when words or phrases are ordered in an AB-BA sequence. In Song of Songs 2:14 the author uses a chiasm. The ULT follows the Hebrew order and translates this verse as “show me your appearance, make me hear your voice, for your voice {is} sweet, and your appearance {is} lovely.” Notice that the phrases “your appearance” and “your voice” are repeated in an AB-BA sequence: “your appearance ... your voice ... your voice ... your appearance.”

Song of Songs 2:1 (#1)

אֲנִי֙ חֲבַצֶּ֣לֶת הַשָּׁרוֹ֔ן שׁוֹשַׁנַּ֖ת הָעֲמָקִֽים

“I {am} a wildflower of Sharon, a lily of the valleys”

Here the woman is speaking of herself as if she is a type of wildflower. She compares herself to these common wildflowers to express that she thinks she is no more attractive than other young women. If it would be helpful in your language, you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [I am as common as a wildflower of Sharon or a lily of the valleys] or [My beauty is as common as a wildflower of Sharon or a lily of the valleys]

See: Metaphor

Song of Songs 2:1 (#3)

אֲנִי֙ חֲבַצֶּ֣לֶת הַשָּׁרוֹ֔ן

“I {am} a wildflower of Sharon”

The writer assumes that the reader will know that **Sharon** was the name of a specific plain (a flat area) and that the word itself refers to a flat, wide area. Here the woman is probably referring to “plains” in general and expressing that she is like a wildflower that grows on the plains. You could include this infor-

mation if it would be helpful to your readers. Alternate translation: [I am a flower that grows on the plain of Sharon] or [I am a flower that grows on the plains]

See: Assumed Knowledge and Implicit Information

Song of Songs 2:1 (#6)

שׁוֹשַׁנַּת

“a lily of”

The Hebrew word that the ULT translates as **lily** is a type of flower which grows as a wildflower. If your readers would not be familiar with this type of flower, you could use the name of something similar in your area, or you could use a more general term. Alternate translation: [a wildflower of]

See: Translate Unknowns

Song of Songs 2:1 (#4)

אֲנִיׄ חֲבַצֶּלֶת הַשָּׁרׄוֹן שׁוֹשַׁנַּת הָעֲמָקִים

“I {am} a wildflower of Sharon, a lily of the valleys”

These two phrases **a flower of Sharon** and **a lily of the valleys** mean basically the same thing. The second phrase emphasizes the meaning of the first by repeating the same idea with different words. Hebrew poetry was based on this kind of repetition, and it would be good to show this to your readers by including both phrases in your translation rather than combining them. However, if it would be helpful to your readers, you could combine the phrases into one. Alternate translation: [I am a wildflower that grows in the plains and the valleys]

See: Parallelism

Song of Songs 2:1 (#5)

שׁוֹשַׁנַּת

“a lily of”

The woman is leaving out some of the words that in many languages a sentence would need in order to be complete. If it would be clearer in your language, you could supply these words from the context. Alternate translation: [I am a lily of]

See: Ellipsis

Song of Songs 2:1 (#2)

חֲבַצֶּלֶת

“am} a wildflower of”

The original word which the ULT translates as **wildflower** refers to a specific type of flower which grows on the ground. The exact type of flower that the original word refers to cannot be known with certainty, so you could use the name of a pretty wildflower in your area, or you could use a more general term.

See: Translate Unknowns

Song of Songs 2:2 (#3)

רַעְיָתִׄי

“is} my darling”

See how you translated the phrase **my darling** in 1:9.

Song of Songs 2:2 (#2)

כְּשׁוֹשַׁנָּהׄ

“Like a lily”

See how you translated the word **lily** in 2:1.

See: Translate Unknowns

Song of Songs 2:2 (#1)

כְּשׁוֹשַׁנָּהׄ בֵּ֣ין הַחוֹחִ֔ים כֵּ֖ן רַעְיָתִׄי בֵּ֥ין הַבָּנֽוֹת

“Like a lily among thorns, so {is} my darling among the daughters”

The man is saying that the woman he loves is **like a lily among thorns**. The idea is that just as a lily is much more beautiful than thorns, so the woman he loves is much more beautiful than the other young women. If it would be helpful in your language, you could state this explicitly. Alternate translation: [You, my darling, are much more beautiful than all other women]

See: Simile

Song of Songs 2:2 (#4)

הַבָּנוֹת

“the daughters”

The writer assumes that the readers will understand that **the daughters** refers to the “daughters of Jerusalem” mentioned in 1:5. The phrase probably also refers to all women. You could include this information if it would be helpful to your readers. Alternate translation: [the young women of Jerusalem] or [the other young women]

See: Assumed Knowledge and Implicit Information

Song of Songs 2:3 (#1)

כְּתַפּ֣וּחַ֩ בַּעֲצֵ֨י הַיַּ֜עַר כֵּ֣ן דוֹדִ֗י בֵּ֚ין הַבָּנִ֔ים

“Like an apple tree among the trees of the forest, so {is} my beloved among the sons”

The woman is saying that the man is like an **apple tree** because, in the same way that **an apple tree** is more pleasant than the other **trees of the forest**, so the man she loves is more pleasant than other men. If it would be helpful in your language, you could state that explicitly. Alternate translation: [As apple trees are more pleasant than other trees, so you, my beloved, are more pleasant than other men] or [As apple trees are more delightful than other trees, so you, my beloved, are more delightful than other men]

See: Simile

Song of Songs 2:3 (#3)

כְּתַפּוּחַ

“Like an apple tree”

An **apple tree** is a tree that produces apples, a round, pleasant-tasting fruit. Bible scholars are not certain that the word the ULT translates as **apple** refers to what we now call an apple. It could refer to an apricot or another type of fruit. If your readers would not be familiar with these types of trees, you could use the name of something similar in your area, or you could use a more general term. Alternate translation: [Like a tree that produces pleasant tasting fruit] or [Like an apricot tree]

See: Translate Unknowns

Song of Songs 2:3 (#4)

בַּעֲצֵי הַיָּעַר

“among the trees of the forest”

The writer assumes that the reader will understand that **the trees of the forest** refers to the other trees of the forest, those which were considered common when compared to the beautiful, fruit-bearing **apple tree**. If it would be helpful to your readers, you could include this information. Alternate translation: [among the other trees of the forest] or [compared to the common trees of the forest]

See: Assumed Knowledge and Implicit Information

Song of Songs 2:3 (#5)

דּוֹדִי

“is} my beloved”

See how you translated the phrase **my beloved** in 1:13.

Song of Songs 2:3 (#2)

כְּתַפּוּחַ בַּעֲצֵי הַיָּעַר כֵּן דּוֹדִי בֵּין הַבָּנִים

“Like an apple tree among the trees of the forest, so {is} my beloved among the sons”

If it would be more natural in your language, you could reverse the order of these phrases. Alternate translation: [Among the other young men, my beloved is like an apple tree among the trees of the forest] or [Compared to other men, my beloved is like an apple tree among the trees of the forest]

See: Information Structure

Song of Songs 2:3 (#6)

בֵּין הַבָּנִים

“among the sons”

Here the writer assumes that the reader will know that **the sons** refers to the other young men. In the previous verse the man compared the woman to the other “daughters”. Here the woman compares the man she loves to the other young men, whom she calls **sons**. You could include this information if it would be helpful to your readers. Alternate translation: [among the other young men] or [when compared to all the other men]

See: Assumed Knowledge and Implicit Information

Song of Songs 2:3 (#7)

בְּצִלּוֹ חִמַּדְתִּי וְיָשַׁבְתִּי וּפִרְיוֹ מָתוֹק לְחִכִּי

“In his shadow I greatly delighted, and I sat, and his fruit {is} sweet to my palate”

Here the woman continues speaking of the man as if he were **an apple tree**. The word **shadow** refers to the shade of the apple tree which gives protection from the sun. **I sat** represents being near or in the presence of the man. Here the woman speaks of her pleasurable feelings as if they were **his fruit** which is **sweet to my palate**. If it is possible in your language, you should try to retain the images used here or substitute a comparable image. However, if it would be helpful in your language, you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [He provides me with refreshment and protection when I am in his presence; he gives me great pleasure] or [I sit in his presence, and he refreshes and protects me. Like sweet fruit, he is delightful to me]

See: Metaphor

Song of Songs 2:3 (#8)

בְּצִלּוֹ חִמַּדְתִּי וְיָשַׁבְתִּי

“In his shadow I greatly delighted, and I sat”

Alternate translation: [In his shade I took delight, and I sat]

Song of Songs 2:4 (#2)

הֱבִיאַנִי

“He brought me”

Your language might say “took” rather than **brought** in a context such as this. Alternate translation: [He took me]

See: Go and Come

Song of Songs 2:4 (#3)

בֵּיתַ הַיָּיִן

“the house of wine”

The writer assumes that the reader will understand that the phrase **house of wine** refers to a location to which people went to drink wine. The phrase does not necessarily mean a house, so here it could be referring to the private location that the couple used as their meeting place, (described in 1:17). You could include this information if it would be helpful to your readers. Alternate translation: [the place where wine is drunk] or [the place where wine is served] or [our meeting place]

See: Assumed Knowledge and Implicit Information

Song of Songs 2:4 (#4)

בֵּיתַ הַיָּיִן

“the house of wine”

The woman is referring to a private meeting place, one in which they could enjoy expressing their love for each other. She speaks of it in a polite way by using the phrase **house of wine**, an image that was meaningful in her culture. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use a polite way of referring to this in your language, or you could state this plainly. Alternate translation: [our meeting place so that we could enjoy our love] or [the place where we could celebrate our love for each other] or [the place where we could consummate our love]

See: Euphemism

Song of Songs 2:4 (#7)

וְדִגְלֹו עָלַי אַהֲבָה

“and his banner over me {is} love”

If your language does not use an abstract noun for the idea of **love**, you could express the same idea in another way. Alternate translation: [and his banner shows that I belong to him, and he loves me]

See: Abstract Nouns

Song of Songs 2:4 (#5)

וְדִגְלֹו עָלַי אַהֲבָה

“and his banner over me {is} love”

The woman is speaking of the man’s **love** for her as if it were a **banner**. If it would be helpful in your language, you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [and he publicly displays his love for me, and his intention is to protect me] or [and he covers me with his love]

See: Metaphor

Song of Songs 2:4 (#1)

הֱבִיאַנִי

“He brought me”

See how you translated the phrase “has brought me” in 1:4. The original language word which the ULT translates here as **He brought me** could be describing: (1) a request or wish that the woman has and not something that has already happened. Alternate translation: [May he bring me] or [I desire him to bring me]; (2) an action that has already happened. Alternate translation: [He has brought me]

See: Statements — Other Uses

Song of Songs 2:4 (#6)

וְדִגְלֹו

“and his banner”

A **banner** is a flag made from a large piece of cloth that is attached to a long pole. People, groups, and kings had their own unique banners by which they identified themselves. If your readers would not be familiar with this type of flag, you could use the name of something similar in your area, or you could use a more general term. Alternate translation: [and his flag]

See: Translate Unknowns

Song of Songs 2:5 (#5)

בַּתַּפּוּחִים

“with apples”

See how you translated the word “apple” in 2:3.

See: Translate Unknowns

Song of Songs 2:5 (#7)

אַהֲבָֽה

“love”

If your language does not use an abstract noun for the idea of **love**, you could express the same idea in another way. Alternate translation: [longing for you]

See: Abstract Nouns

Song of Songs 2:5 (#4)

בָּאֲשִׁישׁוֹת

“with raisin cakes”

Here, **raisin cakes** were cakes made of dried grapes pressed together. If your readers would not be familiar with this type of fruit, you could use the name of something similar in your area, or you could use a more general term. Alternate translation: [with cakes made of dried fruit]

See: Translate Unknowns

Song of Songs 2:5 (#3)

סַמְּכוּנִי֙ בָּאֲשִׁישׁוֹת רַפְּדוּנִי בַּתַּפּוּחִ֔ים כִּי־חוֹלַ֖ת אַהֲבָ֥ה אָֽנִי

“Sustain me with raisin cakes; refresh me with apples, for sick with love {am} I”

If it would be more natural in your language, you could reverse the order of these phrases, since the second phrase gives the reason for the result that the first phrase describes. Alternate translation: [Because I am sick with love, sustain me with raisin cakes and refresh me with apples]

See: Connect — Reason-and-Result Relationship

Song of Songs 2:5 (#1)

סַמְּכוּנִי֙ בָּאֲשִׁישׁוֹת רַפְּדוּנִי בַּתַּפּוּחִ֔ים

“Sustain me with raisin cakes; refresh me with apples”

These two clauses mean basically the same thing. In the author’s culture both raisins and **apples** were believed to give people strength for love. The second clause emphasizes the meaning of the first by repeating the same idea with different words. Hebrew poetry was based on this kind of repetition. If it would be helpful to your readers, you could connect the clauses with a word that shows that the second clause is repeating the first one, not saying something additional, or you could combine these two clauses into one. Alternate translation: [Sustain me with raisin cakes; yes, refresh me with apples] or [strengthen me with fruit] or [strengthen me for love with fruit]

See: Parallelism

Song of Songs 2:5 (#2)

סַמְּכוּנִי֙ & רַפְּדוּנִי

“Sustain me & refresh me”

The phrases **Sustain me** and **refresh me** are plural imperative forms in the original language. The woman is addressing the man using plural forms to show the intensity of her feelings. The ULT indicates this intensity by placing an exclamation point at the end of this verse. Your language may allow you to use a plural form for this purpose, or you could use the singular form and show the intensity of emotion in another way.

See: Unusual Uses of the Plural

Song of Songs 2:5 (#6)

כִּי־חוֹלַ֖ת אַהֲבָ֥ה אָֽנִי

“for sick with love {am} I”

The woman speaks of feeling **sick with love** as an exaggeration to emphasize the strength of her feelings for the man. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use a different way to express the emphasis. Alternate translation: [for my love for you is so strong that I feel as if I were sick with love] or [because my love for you overwhelms me like a sickness]

See: Hyperbole

Song of Songs 2:6 (#2)

שְׂמֹאלוֹ֙ תַּ֣חַת לְרֹאשִׁ֔י

“His left hand {is} under my head”

Alternate translation: [The man I love cradles my head on his left arm]

Song of Songs 2:6 (#1)

שְׂמֹאלוֹ֙ תַּ֣חַת לְרֹאשִׁ֔י וִימִינ֖וֹ תְּחַבְּקֵֽנִי

“His left hand {is} under my head, and his right hand embraces me”

This verse could be describing: (1) an action that the man was doing, in which case it should be translated in a similar way to the ULT. (2) a request or wish that the woman has, and not something which has already happened. Alternate translation: [I hope he puts his left arm under my head and holds me close with his

right arm] or [I want him to put his left arm under my head and hold me close with his right arm]

Song of Songs 2:7 (#1)

הִשְׁבַּעְתִּי אֶתְכֶם בְּנוֹת יְרוּשָׁלִָם

“I adjure you, daughters of Jerusalem”

Here the woman is speaking to the **daughters of Jerusalem**, but most likely they are not present. The woman is doing this as a poetic way of giving voice to her strong feelings. Because the author does this intentionally for poetic effect, it is suggested that you do the same. If it would be helpful in your language, you could indicate this in a footnote.

See: Apostrophe

Song of Songs 2:7 (#5)

בִּצְבָאוֹת

“by the female gazelles”

A gazelle is a small type of antelope, that looks and moves like a deer and is similar in size. If your readers would not be familiar with this type of animal, you could use the name of a similar animal in your area, or you could use a more general term. Alternate translation: [by the female antelopes]

See: Translate Unknowns

Song of Songs 2:7 (#6)

בְּאַיְלוֹת

“the does of”

The writer assumes that the reader will understand that **does** refers to female deer. You could include this information if it would be helpful to your readers. Alternate translation: [the female deer of]

See: Assumed Knowledge and Implicit Information

Song of Songs 2:7 (#9)

אֶת־הָאַהֲבָה

“love”

If your language does not use an abstract noun for the idea of **love**, you could express the same idea in another way.

See: Abstract Nouns

Song of Songs 2:7 (#3)

בְּנוֹת יְרוּשָׁלִָם

“daughters of Jerusalem”

See how you translated the phrase **daughters of Jerusalem** in 1:5.

See: Possession

Song of Songs 2:7 (#2)

הִשְׁבַּעְתִּי אֶתְכֶם & בִּצְבָאוֹת אוֹ בְּאַיְלוֹת הַשָּׂדֶה

“I adjure you & by the female gazelles or the does of the field”

The phrase **I adjure you** and the word **by** are both parts of a Hebrew oath formula. Use a natural way in your language to express an oath. Alternate translation: [I urge you to promise me ... with the female gazelles or the does of the field as our witnesses] or [Please promise me ... with the female gazelles or the does of the field as our witnesses] or [I want you to make an oath ... with the female gazelles or the does of the field listening]

See: Oath Formulas

Song of Songs 2:7 (#7)

אִם־תָּעִירוּ ׀ וְאִם־תְּעֹרְרוּ אֶת־הָאַהֲבָה עַד שֶׁתֶּחְפָּץ

“do not awaken nor stir love until it desires”

Here the woman speaks of **love** as if it were a person who could sleep, **awaken**, and have **desires**. If it would be helpful in your language, you could express the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [do not encourage people to love romantically until the appropriate time] or [do not encourage people to have romantic feelings until the appropriate time]

See: Personification

Song of Songs 2:7 (#4)

בִּצְבָאוֹת אוֹ בְּאַיְלוֹת הַשָּׂדֶה

“by the female gazelles or the does of the field”

Here the woman is using the possessive form to describe the **female gazelles** and **does** that are characterized as being **of the field** and therefore are wild animals. If your language would not use the possessive form for this, you could explain the meaning of the phrase **of the field** in your translation. Alternate translation: [by the wild female gazelles and does] or [by the wild female gazelles or the wild does] or [by the female gazelles or the does that live in the wild]

See: Possession

Song of Songs 2:7 (#8)

אִם־תָּעִירוּ ׀ וְאִם־תְּעֹרְרוּ

“do not awaken nor stir”

Here the words **awaken** and **stir** mean similar things. The repetition is used for emphasis. If it would be clearer for your readers, you could express the emphasis with a single phrase. Alternate translation: [do not awaken] or [do not stir up feelings of]

See: Doublet

Song of Songs 2:8 (#1)

קוֹל דּוֹדִי

“The voice of my beloved”

Here the word **voice** either refers to: (1) the man’s words that he is speaking or (2) the sound of his voice which indicates he is approaching. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use an equivalent expression or state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [Listen, I hear my beloved speaking] or [Listen, I hear my beloved approaching]

See: Metonymy

Song of Songs 2:8 (#2)

הִנֵּה

“Behold”

Behold is an exclamation word that is used to bring attention to the man’s approach. Use an exclamation that would communicate that meaning in your language. See how you translated **Behold** in 1:15. Alternate translation: [See]

See: Exclamations

Song of Songs 2:8 (#4)

מְדַלֵּג עַל־הֶהָרִים מְקַפֵּץ עַל־הַגְּבָעוֹת

“leaping over the mountains, jumping over the hills”

These two phrases mean the same thing. The second emphasizes the meaning of the first by repeating the same idea with different words. If it would be helpful to your readers, you could combine these two phrases and provide emphasis in another way. Alternate translation: [leaping over the mountains!] or [leaping and jumping over the mountains and hills!]

See: Parallelism

Song of Songs 2:8 (#3)

בָּא

“is coming”

Your language may say “going” rather than **coming** in contexts such as this. Use whichever is more natural. Alternate translation: [is going]

See: Go and Come

Song of Songs 2:8–9 (#1)

מְדַלֵּג עַל־הֶהָרִים מְקַפֵּץ עַל־הַגְּבָעוֹת׃ דּוֹמֶה דוֹדִי לִצְבִי אוֹ לְעֹפֶר הָאַיָּלִים

“leaping over the mountains, jumping over the hills.My beloved is being like a gazelle or a young stag”

The woman is saying that the man she loves **is like a gazelle or a young stag** because he appears strong and exuberant as he approaches her. If it would be helpful to your readers, you could state this explicitly. Alternate translation: [leaping over the mountains, jumping over the hills. My beloved is agile and exuberant, and he exudes freedom and strength as does a gazelle or young stag]

See: Simile

Song of Songs 2:8–9 (#2)

מְדַלֵּג עַל־הֶהָרִים מְקַפֵּץ עַל־הַגְּבָעוֹת׃ דּוֹמֶה דוֹדִי לִצְבִי אוֹ לְעֹפֶר הָאַיָּלִים

“leaping over the mountains, jumping over the hills.My beloved is being like a gazelle or a young stag”

If it would be more natural in your language, you could reverse the order of these phrases. Alternate translation: [My beloved is being like a gazelle or a young stag, leaping over the mountains, jumping over the hills]

See: Information Structure

Song of Songs 2:9 (#2)

הָאַיָּלִים

“stag”

The writer assumes that the readers will understand that a **stag** is an adult male deer. You could include this information if it would be helpful to your readers. Alternate translation: [adult male deer]

See: Assumed Knowledge and Implicit Information

Song of Songs 2:9 (#3)

הִנֵּה

“Behold”

See how you translated the word **Behold** in 1:15 where it occurs with the same meaning.

See: Metaphor

Song of Songs 2:9 (#5)

אַחַנָּ֖ר כָּתְלֵ֑ינוּ

“behind our wall”

Here the word **our** refers to the woman and her family and does not include the man, so use the exclusive form of that word in your translation if your language marks that distinction. Alternate translation: [behind the wall of my house] or [on the other side of the wall of my family’s house]

See: Exclusive and Inclusive ‘We’

Song of Songs 2:9 (#4)

זֶ֣ה

“this one”

Here the phrase **this one** refers to the man whom the woman calls **My beloved** in the first part of this verse. If this is not clear for your readers, you could specify the person here. Alternate translation: [this man] or [my beloved]

See: Pronouns — When to Use Them

Song of Songs 2:9 (#8)

הַחַרַכִּֽים

“the lattices”

The **lattices** are vertical and horizontal strips found inside a window frame. They have spaces between them through which a person could look. If your readers would not be familiar with lattices, you could use the name of something similar in your area, or you could use the wording of the UST. Alternate translation: [the screen]

See: Translate Unknowns

Song of Songs 2:9 (#1)

לִצְבִ֔י

“a gazelle”

See how you translated the plural form, “gazelles,” in 2:7; then translate this word as the singular form of “gazelles.”

See: Translate Unknowns

Song of Songs 2:9 (#7)

הַחַלֹּנֹ֖ות & הַחַרַכִּֽים

“the windows & the lattices”

Here the words **windows** and **lattices** are plural forms and could: (1) have a plural meaning here, indicating that the man was walking around the house and looking into the house through different windows and lattices. (2) be used with singular meanings here, indicating the multiple openings of a single window and lattice. Alternate translation: [the window ... the lattice]

See: Unusual Uses of the Plural

Song of Songs 2:9 (#6)

מַשְׁגִּ֣יחַ מִן־הַחַלֹּנֹ֔ות מֵצִ֖יץ מִן־הַחֲרַכִּֽים

“gazing through the windows, looking through the lattices”

These two phrases mean basically the same thing. The second emphasizes the meaning of the first by repeating the same idea with different words. Hebrew poetry was based on this kind of repetition, and it would be good to show this to your readers by including both phrases in your translation rather than combining them. However, if it would be helpful to your readers, you could connect the phrases with a word other than “and” in order to show that the second phrase is repeating the first one, not saying something additional. Alternate translation: [gazing through the windows, yes, looking through the lattices]

See: Parallelism

Song of Songs 2:10 (#1)

וּלְכִי־לָ֖ךְ

“and come”

Your language may say “go” rather than **come** in a context such as this. Use whichever is more natural. Alternate translation: [and go]

See: Go and Come

Song of Songs 2:11 (#1)

הִנֵּ֥ה

“behold”

The man is using the term **behold** to focus the woman’s attention on what he is about to say. Your language may have a comparable expression that you could use in your translation. Alternate translation: [see]

See: Metaphor

Song of Songs 2:11 (#6)

הָלַ֥ךְ לוֹ

“it went away”

Alternate translation: [it has ended] or [it has departed]

Song of Songs 2:11 (#7)

חָלַ֖ף הָלַ֥ךְ לוֹ

“has passed; it went away”

The terms **passed** and **went away** mean similar things. The author is using the two terms together for emphasis. If it would be clearer for your readers, you could express the emphasis with a single phrase. Alternate translation: [is over and gone] or [has gone away]

See: Doublet

Song of Songs 2:11 (#2)

כִּ֤י־הִנֵּה

“for, behold”

Here the word **for** indicates that what follows is a reason for what came before. Use a connector in your language that makes it clear that what follows is a reason for what came before. Alternate translation: [behold, this is because]

See: Connect — Reason-and-Result Relationship

Song of Songs 2:11 (#4)

הסתו עָבָ֣ר הַגֶּ֔שֶׁם חָלַ֖ף

“the winter has gone; the rain has passed”

These two phrases mean basically the same thing. The second emphasizes the meaning of the first by repeating the same idea with different words. Hebrew poetry was based on this kind of repetition, and it would be good to show this to your readers by including both phrases in your translation rather than combining them. However, if it would be helpful to your readers, you could connect the phrases with a word other than “and” in order to show that the second phrase is repeating the first one, not saying something additional. Alternate translation: [the winter has gone; yes, the rain has passed]

See: Parallelism

Song of Songs 2:11 (#5)

עָבָֽר

“has gone”

Your language might not say **has gone** in a context such as this. Alternate translation: [is finished] or [is over]

See: Go and Come

Song of Songs 2:11 (#3)

הסתו

“the winter”

In Israel, **winter** is the time of year when it is cold and rains more heavily than during other seasons. If the seasons do not vary much in your location, you could explain this with a general expression such as “the cold season.” Alternate translation: [the cold, rainy season] or [the cold, wet season]

See: Translate Unknowns

Song of Songs 2:12 (#2)

וְקוֹל֙ הַתֹּ֣ר נִשְׁמָ֔ע

“and the voice of the turtledove is heard”

If your language does not use a passive form like **the turtledove is heard**, you could express the idea in active form or in another way that is natural in your language. If you need to say who did the action, it is clear from the context that it is people. Alternate translation: [and people hear the voice of the turtledove] or [and people hear the turtledove cooing]

See: Active or Passive

Song of Songs 2:12 (#1)

בָּאָ֑רֶץ

“in the land”

Alternate translation: [throughout the land]

Song of Songs 2:13 (#2)

וְהַגְּפָנִ֣ים ׀ סְמָדַ֗ר

“and the vines {are in} blossom”

Alternate translation: [and the grapevines are flowering] or [and the grapevines are blossoming]

Song of Songs 2:13 (#3)

נָ֚תְנוּ רֵ֣ריחַ

“they give off a smell”

Here the pronoun **they** refers to the blossoms on the grapevines. If it would be helpful to your readers, you could indicate that explicitly. Alternate translation: [their flowers give off a pleasant smell] or [their blossoms have a sweet smell]

See: Pronouns — When to Use Them

Song of Songs 2:13 (#4)

קוּמִי לֵכִי רַעְיָתִי יָפָתִי וּלְכִי־לָךְ

“Get up, come, my darling, my beauty, and come”

See how you translated the similar phrase in 2:10. Alternate translation: [Get up, go, my darling, my beauty, and go]

See: Go and Come

Song of Songs 2:13 (#1)

הַתְאֵנָה חָנְטָה פַגֶּיהָ

“The fig tree ripens its green figs”

In this verse, the word **fig tree** is in singular form but refers to all the fig trees as a group. If it would be helpful in your language, you could say this plainly. Alternate translation: [The fig trees are ripening their green figs] or [The figs on the trees are becoming ripe]

See: Collective Nouns

Song of Songs 2:14 (#4)

בְּחַגְוֵי הַסֶּלַע

“in the clefts of the rock”

Alternate translation: [in the cracks of the rock]

Song of Songs 2:14 (#2)

יוֹנָתִי בְּחַגְוֵי הַסֶּלַע בְּסֵתֶר הַמַּדְרֵגָה

“My dove, in the clefts of the rock, in the hiding places of the cliff”

Here the man speaks to the woman he loves as if she were his **dove**. He then tells her the way in which she is like a dove. If it would be helpful in your language, you could state this meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [O my one who is like a dove. You are like a gentle and timid dove which hides in the clefts of the rock and in the hiding places of the cliff] or [You are like a dove, like a gentle and shy dove which hides in the clefts of the rock and in the hiding places of the cliff] or [You are like a dove, far away in the clefts of the rock, in the hiding places of the cliff]

See: Metaphor

Song of Songs 2:14 (#5)

הַרְאִינִי אֶת־מַרְאַיִךְ הַשְׁמִיעֵנִי אֶת־קוֹלֵךְ כִּי־קוֹלֵךְ עָרֵב וּמַרְאֵיִךְ נָאוֶה

“show me your appearance, make me hear your voice, for your voice {is} sweet, and your appearance {is} lovely”

Here two ideas are presented and then they are further explained in reverse order. This is called a chiasm. Biblical Hebrew sometimes uses this literary device. If possible, try to follow this AB-BA sequence of presenting the information here. See the chapter introduction for more information regarding chiasms.

See: Poetry

Song of Songs 2:14 (#6)

הַרְאִינִי אֶת־מַרְאַיִךְ הַשְׁמִיעֵנִי

“show me your appearance, make me hear”

The phrases **show me** and **make me hear** are imperatives, but they communicate a polite request rather than a command. Use a form in your language that communicates a polite request. It may be helpful to add an expression such as “please” or “let” to make this clear. Alternate translation: [please let me see your appearance, please let me hear] or [let me see you, let me hear]

See: Imperatives — Other Uses

Song of Songs 2:14 (#3)

בְּחַגְוֵי הַסֶּלַע בְּסֵתֶר הַמַּדְרֵגָה

“in the clefts of the rock, in the hiding places of the cliff”

These two phrases mean basically the same thing. The second emphasizes the meaning of the first by repeating the same idea with different words. Hebrew poetry was based on this kind of repetition, and it would be good to show this to your readers by including both phrases in your translation rather than combining them. However, if it would be helpful to your readers, you could connect the phrases with a word such as “yes” in order to show that the second phrase is repeating a similar idea to the first one, not saying something additional. You could also combine the two lines as modeled by the UST. Alternate translation: [in the clefts of the rock, yes, in the hiding places of the cliff]

See: Parallelism

Song of Songs 2:14 (#1)

יוֹנָתִ֔י

“My dove”

Here the phrase **My dove** could be: (1) the man speaking directly to the woman. Alternate translation: [O my dove]; (2) the man speaking about the woman rather than speaking to her directly. Alternate translation: [The woman I love is a dove]

See: Direct and Indirect Quotations

Song of Songs 2:14 (#7)

קוֹלֵ֥ךְ עָרֵ֖ב

“your voice {is} sweet”

Alternate translation: [your voice is sweet-sounding] or [your voice sounds beautiful]

Song of Songs 2:15 (#2)

לָ֣נוּ׀ שֻׁועָלִ֣ים שֻׁועָלִ֗ים קְטַנִּים֙

“the foxes for us, the little foxes”

It is possible that the word that the ULT translates as **foxes** could, instead, refer to jackals. Jackals are wild dogs that resemble wolves and coyotes. Alternate translation: [the jackals for us, the little jackals]

See: Translate Unknowns

Song of Songs 2:15 (#3)

לָ֣נוּ׀ שֻׁועָלִ֣ים שֻׁועָלִ֗ים קְטַנִּים֙

“the foxes for us, the little foxes”

Both **foxes** and jackals are land animals that are similar to small dogs and would ruin vineyards by digging up roots and eating the budding blossoms. If your readers would not be familiar with these animals and their habits, you could use the name of something similar in your area, or you could use a more general term. Alternate translation: [the dog-like animals for us, the little dog-like animals]

See: Translate Unknowns

Song of Songs 2:15 (#1)

אֶחֱזוּ־לָ֣נוּ׀ שֻׁועָלִ֣ים שֻׁועָלִ֗ים קְטַנִּים֙ מְחַבְּלִ֣ים כְּרָמִ֔ים וּכְרָמֵ֖ינוּ סְמָדַֽר

“Catch the foxes for us, the little foxes that destroy the vineyards, and our vineyards {are in} blossom”

Here the writer is speaking of **the foxes** as if they represent things, perhaps even other men, who could harm the man and woman’s developing relationship with each other. Catching **the foxes** represents removing or protecting against them. The **vineyards** represent the love the man and woman have for each other. The phrase **our vineyards {are in} blossom** means that their love is growing, like a plant blossoms and grows. If it would be helpful in your language, you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [Get rid of the harmful things that hinder and damage our relationship, for our relationship is blossoming] or [Remove the little things that threaten our growing relationship] or [There are other men who are like little foxes that ruin vineyards; do not allow those men to attack me]

See: Metaphor

Song of Songs 2:15 (#4)

לָ֣נוּ׀ & וּכְרָמֵ֖ינוּ

“for us & and our vineyards”

Here the words **us** and **our** refer to the woman and the man, so use the inclusive forms of these words if your language marks that distinction.

See: Exclusive and Inclusive ‘We’

Song of Songs 2:15 (#5)

וּכְרָמֵ֖ינוּ סְמָדַֽר

“and our vineyards {are in} blossom”

Alternate translation: [because the grapevines in our vineyards are blooming] or [because our grapevines are in bloom]

Song of Songs 2:16 (#2)

הָרֹעֶ֖ה בַּשּׁוֹשַׁנִּֽים

“the man grazing among the lilies”

The phrase **the man grazing among the lilies** could mean: (1) that the man himself is grazing among the lilies. (2) that the man grazes his flock of animals among the lilies. Alternate translation: [the man grazing his flock among the lilies]

Song of Songs 2:16 (#3)

הָרֹעֶ֖ה בַּשּׁוֹשַׁנִּֽים

“the man grazing among the lilies”

Here the woman is speaking of the man as if he were “a gazelle or a young stag” (2:9) that eats **among the lilies**. She is using **lilies** to represent herself as she did in 2:1. Here, **the lilies** probably represent the woman’s lips. The meaning here is that the man finds suste-

nance and enjoyment through being with the woman and kissing her lips. If it would be helpful in your language, you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [my beloved gets pleasure grazing among the lilies] or [my beloved gets pleasure as he grazes among the lilies]

See: Metaphor

Song of Songs 2:16 (#4)

בַּשּׁוֹשַׁנִּים

“among the lilies”

See how you translated “lily” (the singular form of **lilies**) in 2:1.

See: Translate Unknowns

Song of Songs 2:16 (#1)

דּוֹדִי לִי֙ וַאֲנִ֣י לֽוֹ

“My beloved {belongs} to me and I {belong} to him”

The woman is speaking about the man in the third person even though she is most likely speaking directly to the man. This is common in Hebrew poetry. If this would not be natural in your language, you can translate this in a way that indicates that the woman is speaking directly to the man. Alternate translation: [My beloved, you belong to me, and I belong to you]

See: First, Second or Third Person

Song of Songs 2:17 (#1)

שֶׁיָּפ֣וּחַ הַיּ֔וֹם וְנָ֖סוּ הַצְּלָלִ֑ים

“the day breathes and the shadows flee”

The phrases **the day breathes** and **the shadows flee** mean basically the same thing. The second emphasizes the meaning of the first by repeating the same idea with different words. Hebrew poetry was based on this type of repetition, and it would be good to show this to your readers by including both phrases in your translation rather than combining them. Together, they both either refer to: (1) the evening time, when the evening breeze blows (**breathes**) and the shadows cast by the sun disappear (**flee**). Alternate translation: [the evening time when the breeze blows and the shadows cast by the sun disappear] or (2) the morning time, when the light from the sun dawns and the morning breeze blows (**breathes**). Alternate translation: [dawn tomorrow morning, when the darkness disappears]

See: Parallelism

Song of Songs 2:17 (#5)

הָרֵ֥י בָֽתֶר

“the mountains of Bether”

The word **Bether** is a word borrowed from the Hebrew that means “cleft” or “divided.” You will need to decide if you will borrow it into your language or if you will translate the meaning. Either approach has broad support. Here it could: (1) be a proper name that refers to a specific place in Israel. If you choose this option, then in your translation you could spell it the way that it sounds in your language and then put the meaning in a footnote. (2) be a description of **the mountains**. Alternate translation: [the cleft mountains] or [the rugged mountains] or [the mountain gorges]

See: Copy or Borrow Words

Song of Songs 2:17 (#4)

לְצְבִ֣י

“a gazelle”

See how you translated the plural form “gazelles” in 2:7, and translate this word as the singular form of “gazelles.”

See: Translate Unknowns

Song of Songs 2:17 (#2)

וְנָ֖סוּ הַצְּלָלִ֑ים

“and the shadows flee”

Here the author is leaving out the word **Until** that in many languages this sentence would need in order to be complete. You could supply this word from earlier in the sentence if it would be clearer in your language. Alternate translation: [and until the shadows flee]

See: Ellipsis

Song of Songs 2:17 (#3)

סֹ֣בְבָ֗ דְּמֵה־לְךָ֤ דוֹדִי֙

“turn; resemble, my beloved”

Alternate translation: [turn; my beloved, and be like]

Song of Songs - Chapter 3 Introduction

Religious and Cultural Concepts in This Chapter

Longing

Verses 3:1–3 describe the feeling of longing that the woman has for the man she loves, and it describes her diligently seeking him. Verse 3:4 describes the

woman finding the man she loves, holding onto him, and bringing him to her mother's house.

Translation Issues in This Chapter

Whether verses 3:1–4 describe a dream, a real event, or something imagined
Bible scholars do not know for certain whether the events described in 3:1–4 are real events or something that the woman dreamed or imagined. Many Bible scholars think that verses 3:1–4 describe a dream. You may wish to explain this in a footnote, or you could indicate in a section header whether you think this is a dream, a real event, or something she imagined. You could also use a general section header such as "The woman searches for the man she loves and finds him," which does not indicate whether this was a dream, a real event, or something imagined.

Song of Songs 3:1 (#1)

עַל־מִשְׁכָּבִי֙ בַּלֵּילוֹת

"On my bed in the night"

Because Bible scholars do not know if the events described in 3:1–4 describe real events, dreams, or things imagined, you should not expand on or explain the phrase **On my bed in the night** in the text. However, you may wish to make reference to these possibilities in a header or footnote. See the section "Translation Issues in This Chapter" in the chapter introduction for more information.

See: When to Keep Information Implicit

Song of Songs 3:1 (#2)

בַּלֵּילוֹת

"in the night"

In the original language, the phrase **in the night** uses a plural form of **night** and could mean that the woman: (1) sought the man during the night. Alternate translation: [during the night]; (2) sought the man throughout the night. Alternate translation: [throughout the night] or [all night long]; (3) sought the man on many nights. Alternate translation: [night after night]

See: Unusual Uses of the Plural

Song of Songs 3:1 (#4)

אֵת֙ שֶׁאָהֲבָ֣ה נַפְשִׁ֔י

"him whom my soul loves"

See how you translated the similar phrase "you whom my soul loves" in 1:7. Alternate translation: [him whom I love]

See: Synecdoche

Song of Songs 3:1 (#3)

בִּקַּ֖שְׁתִּי אֵ֥ת שֶׁאָהֲבָ֣ה נַפְשִׁ֑י בִּקַּ֖שְׁתִּ֥יו

"I sought him whom my soul loves; I sought him"

The phrase **I sought him** is repeated for emphasis. Hebrew poetry often uses repetition for emphasis. You may be able to use the same construction in your language to show the emphasis here. Alternatively, your language may have another way of showing the emphasis. Alternate translation: [I desperately sought him whom my soul loves] or [I earnestly sought him whom my soul loves]

See: Poetry

Song of Songs 3:2 (#1)

אָקוּמָ֣ה נָּ֔א

"I will get up now"

The writer assumes that the reader will understand that the woman is thinking or saying this to herself. You could include this information if that would be helpful to your readers. Alternate translation: [I thought to myself, 'I will get up now]

See: Assumed Knowledge and Implicit Information

Song of Songs 3:2 (#4)

אֲבַקְשָׁ֑ה & בִּקַּ֖שְׁתִּ֥יו

"I will seek & I sought him"

Alternate translation: [I will look for ... I looked for him]

Song of Songs 3:2 (#5)

אֵ֥ת שֶׁאָהֲבָ֣ה נַפְשִׁ֑י

"him whom my soul loves"

See how you translated the similar phrase "you whom my soul loves" in 1:7. Alternate translation: [him whom I love]

See: Synecdoche

Song of Songs 3:2 (#3)

וּבָֽרְחֹבֹ֔ות

"and in the squares"

The word **squares** refers to spacious open places where people gather to sell things and conduct business and legal matters. If your readers would not be familiar with this type of place, you could use the name of something similar in your area, or you could

use a more general term. Alternate translation: [and in the open plazas] or [and in the wide-open places]

See: Translate Unknowns

Song of Songs 3:2 (#2)

וַאֲסוֹבְבָה בָעִיר

“and go about in the city”

Alternate translation: [and walk through the city]

Song of Songs 3:3 (#2)

אֵת שֶׁאָהֲבָה נַפְשִׁי רְאִיתֶם

“Have} you seen him whom my soul loves”

The woman is leaving out some of the words that a sentence would need in many languages to be complete. If it would be helpful in your language, you could supply these words from the context. Alternate translation: [I said to them, “Have you seen him whom my soul loves]

See: Ellipsis

Song of Songs 3:3 (#3)

אֵת שֶׁאָהֲבָה נַפְשִׁי

“him whom my soul loves”

See how you translated the similar phrase “you whom my soul loves” in 1:7. Alternate translation: [him whom I love]

See: Synecdoche

Song of Songs 3:3 (#1)

הַשֹּׁמְרִים

“The guards”

The word **guards** refers to men who had the job of walking about the city during the night for the purpose of keeping the people safe. If your readers would not be familiar with this term, you could use the name of something similar in your area, or you could use a more general term.

See: Translate Unknowns

Song of Songs 3:3 (#4)

אֵת שֶׁאָהֲבָה נַפְשִׁי רְאִיתֶם

“Have} you seen him whom my soul loves”

Alternate translation: [Do you know where the man whom I love is?]

Song of Songs 3:4 (#3)

שֶׁשֶּׁהֲבֵיאתִיו

“I had brought him”

Your language may say “taken” rather than **brought** in a context such as this. Use whichever is more natural in your language. Alternate translation: [I had taken him]

See: Go and Come

Song of Songs 3:4 (#2)

אֵת שֶׁאָהֲבָה נַפְשִׁי

“him whom my soul loves”

See how you translated the similar phrase “you whom my soul loves” in 1:7. Alternate translation: [him whom I love]

See: Synecdoche

Song of Songs 3:4 (#4)

שֶׁשֶּׁהֲבֵיאתִיו אֶל־בֵּית אִמִּי וְאֶל־חֶדֶר הוֹרָתִי

“I had brought him to the house of my mother and to the room of the woman who conceived me”

These two phrases mean basically the same thing. The second emphasizes the meaning of the first by repeating the same idea with different words. Hebrew poetry was based on this kind of repetition, and it would be good to show this to your readers by including both phrases in your translation rather than combining them. However, if it would be helpful to your readers, you could connect the phrases with a word other than “and” in order to show that the second phrase is repeating the first one, not saying something additional. Alternate translation: [I had brought him to the house of my mother; yes, to the room of the woman who had conceived me]

See: Parallelism

Song of Songs 3:4 (#1)

כִּמְעַטטְ

“Hardly”

Alternate translation: [Scarcely]

Song of Songs 3:5 (#1)

הִשְׁבַּעְתִּי אֶתְכֶם בְּנוֹת יְרוּשָׁלִַם בִּצְבָאוֹת אוֹ בְּאַיְלוֹת הַשָּׂדֶה
אִם־תָּעִירוּ ׀ וְאִם־תְּעוֹרְרוּ אֶת־הָאַהֲבָה עַד שֶׁתֶּחְפָּץ

“I adjure you, daughters of Jerusalem, by the female gazelles or the does of the field, do not awaken nor stir love until it desires”

This verse is identical to Song of Songs 2:7. Translate this verse exactly as you translated that verse. This verse is a refrain (a repeated phrase). Refrains are a common feature of poetry. This refrain closes section 2:8–3:5.

See: Poetry

Song of Songs 3:6 (#3)

עֹלָה

“coming up”

The writer assumes that the readers will understand that the phrase **coming up** describes the group of people traveling from the wilderness to Jerusalem because the wilderness is in the valley and Jerusalem is built on high hills. Use a word or phrase that expresses moving upward in elevation. Alternate translation: [moving upward] or [arising]

See: Assumed Knowledge and Implicit Information

Song of Songs 3:6 (#2)

זֹאת עֹלָה מִן־הַמִּדְבָּר

“is} that coming up from the wilderness”

The word translated as **that** here could refer to: (1) Solomon’s “litter,” which is named in the following verse. Alternate translation: [is that group of people arising from the wilderness]; (2) the woman. Alternate translation: [is this woman arising from the wilderness]

Song of Songs 3:6 (#9)

מִכֹּל אַבְקַת רוֹכֵל

“from all the powders of the merchant”

The word translated as **from all** could: (1) be introducing **the powders of the merchant** as additional information about myrrh and frankincense. Alternate translation: [which are among the powders of the merchant]; (2) indicate that **the powders of the merchant** are being introduced as additional things the merchant sells. Alternate translation: [and other powders of the merchants]

See: Connecting Words and Phrases

Song of Songs 3:6 (#4)

עֹלָה

“coming up”

Your language may say “going” rather than **coming** in a context such as this. Use whichever is more natural in your language. Alternate translation: [going up]

See: Go and Come

Song of Songs 3:6 (#6)

כְּתִימֲרוֹת עָשָׁן מְקֻטֶּרֶת מוֹר וּלְבוֹנָה

“like columns of smoke, fragrant smoke of myrrh and frankincense”

Here the phrase **fragrant smoke of myrrh and frankincense** could be: (1) further describing the words **coming up**. Alternate translation: [creating dust clouds that resemble rising columns of smoke; Yes, creating dust clouds that resemble the fragrant smoke of myrrh and frankincense]; (2) describing the phrase **columns of smoke**. Alternate translation: [like a column of smoke, incensed with myrrh and frankincense]

See: Parallelism

Song of Songs 3:6 (#1)

מִמִּי זֹּאת עֹלָה מִן־הַמִּדְבָּר כְּתִימֲרוֹת עָשָׁן מְקֻטֶּרֶת מוֹר וּלְבוֹנָה מִכֹּל אַבְקַת רוֹכֵל

“Who {is} that coming up from the wilderness like columns of smoke, fragrant smoke of myrrh and frankincense, from all the powders of the merchant”

The phrase **Who is that** could: (1) be a rhetorical question used to create a sense of expectation and interest. If you would not use a question for this purpose in your language, you could translate this as a statement or an exclamation. Alternate translation: [Look who is coming up from the wilderness like columns of smoke, fragrant smoke of myrrh and frankincense, from all the powders of the merchant]; (2) be a request for information. Alternate translation: [Who is it that I see arising from the wilderness like columns of smoke, fragrant smoke of myrrh and frankincense from all the powders of the merchant]

See: Rhetorical Question

Song of Songs 3:6 (#8)

מוֹר

“myrrh”

Alternate translation: [the sweet-smelling incense made from the resin of a myrrh tree]

Song of Songs 3:6 (#7)

מְקֻטֶּרֶת

“fragrant smoke of”

The writer is leaving out a word that in many languages a sentence would need to be complete. You could supply this word from earlier in the sentence if it would be clearer in your language. Alternate translation: [like fragrant smoke of]

See: Ellipsis

Song of Songs 3:6 (#5)

כְּתִימְרוֹת עָשָׁן מְקֻטֶּרֶת מוֹר֙ וּלְבוֹנָ֔ה

“like columns of smoke, fragrant smoke of myrrh and frankincense”

The writer is saying that the dust clouds created by a group of people traveling in a dry area are **like columns of smoke, fragrant smoke of myrrh and frankincense**. If it would be helpful in your language, you could state that explicitly. Alternate translation: [creating a dust cloud that resembles a column of smoke, which resembles the fragrant smoke of myrrh and frankincense]

See: Simile

Song of Songs 3:7 (#1)

הִנֵּ֥ה

“Behold”

See how you translated the word **Behold** in 1:15 where it occurs with the same meaning.

See: Metaphor

Song of Songs 3:7 (#3)

מִטָּתוֹ֙ שֶׁלִּשְׁלֹמֹ֔ה

“his litter, which {belongs} to Solomon”

The phrase **his litter, which belongs to Solomon** could mean: (1) that the woman was riding on the litter which belonged to Solomon and which he had sent for her. The UST models this interpretation. (2) that Solomon himself was riding in the litter. Alternate translation: [Solomon riding in his royal portable chair]

Song of Songs 3:7 (#2)

מִטָּתוֹ֙

“his litter”

A **litter** was a portable bed or couch used to carry important people from place to place. It was carried by wooden poles that were attached to it. This litter probably had a canopy on top that functioned as a roof and curtains around it that could be opened and closed. If your readers would not be familiar with this term, you could use the name of something similar in your area, or you could use a more general term. Alternate translation: [his portable couch]

See: Translate Unknowns

Song of Songs 3:8 (#3)

מִפַּחַ֖ד בַּלֵּילֽוֹת

“against the terrors in the nights”

The woman is leaving out some of the words that a sentence would need in many languages to be complete. If it would be helpful in your language, you could supply these words from the context. Alternate translation: [ready to guard against dangers that happen during the night] or [ready to defend against the dangers of the night]

See: Ellipsis

Song of Songs 3:8 (#1)

מְלֻמְּדֵ֥י מִלְחָמָ֑ה

“studied {in} war”

Alternate translation: [trained in warfare] or [and all of them have been trained to use their swords]

Song of Songs 3:8 (#2)

אִ֣ישׁ חַרְבּ֔וֹ עַל־יְרֵכ֖וֹ מִפַּחַ֖ד בַּלֵּילֽוֹת

“Each one {has} his sword at his thigh, against the terrors in the nights”

The implication is that **Each one has his sword at his thigh** means that his sword is strapped to his thigh so that it is ready to use to defend **against the terrors in the nights**. You could include this information if it would be helpful to your readers. Alternate translation: [Each warrior has his sword strapped to his thigh so that it is ready to use against the terrors in the nights] or [Each warrior has his sword ready to use to defend against the terrors in the nights]

See: Assumed Knowledge and Implicit Information

Song of Songs 3:9 (#1)

אַפִּרְיֹ֖ון

“a palanquin”

A **palanquin** is a sedan chair. Here it refers to the same object that the term “litter” referred to in 3:7 only in

more descriptive terms. You could translate the term **palanquin** the same way you translated "litter" in 3:7 or you could use the name of something similar in your area. Alternate translation: [a portable couch] or [a sedan chair]

See: Translate Unknowns

Song of Songs 3:9 (#2)

אַפִּרְיֹ֥ון עָ֙שָׂה֙ לֹ֣ו הַמֶּ֔לֶךְ שְׁלֹמֹ֖ה מֵעֲצֵ֥י הַלְּבָנֹֽון

"He made for himself a palanquin, King Solomon, from the trees of Lebanon"

Alternate translation: [King Solomon had a palanquin made from the trees in Lebanon]

Song of Songs 3:9–10 (#1)

אַפִּרְיֹ֥ון עָ֙שָׂה֙ לֹ֣ו הַמֶּ֔לֶךְ שְׁלֹמֹ֖ה מֵעֲצֵ֥י הַלְּבָנֹֽון׃ עַמּוּדָ֖יו עָ֣שָׂה כֶ֑סֶף
רִפִּידָתֹ֥ו זָהָ֛ב מֶרְכָּבֹ֖ו אַרְגָּמָ֑ן תֹּוכֹ֖ו רָצ֥וּף אַהֲבָ֛ה מִבְּנ֥וֹת יְרוּשָׁלָֽם

"He made for himself a palanquin, King Solomon, from the trees of Lebanon.He made its posts {out of} silver; its back, gold; its seat, purple cloth. Its interior was fitted {with} love from the daughters of Jerusalem"

These two verses give background information about the **palanquin** to help readers understand the description more completely. In your translation, present this information in a way that makes it clear that this is background information.

See: Background Information

Song of Songs 3:9–10 (#2)

אַפִּרְיֹ֥ון עָ֙שָׂה֙ לֹ֣ו & עַמּוּדָ֖יו עָ֣שָׂה כֶ֑סֶף

"He made for himself a palanquin & He made its posts {out of} silver"

The implication is that Solomon had people make **a palanquin** for him, not that he made it himself. You could include this information if it would be helpful to your readers. Alternate translation: [He had craftsmen make him a palanquin…He had craftsmen make its post with silver] or [He had a palanquin made for him… He had its posts made with silver]

See: Assumed Knowledge and Implicit Information

Song of Songs 3:10 (#1)

עַמּוּדָ֖יו עָ֣שָׂה כֶ֑סֶף

"He made its posts {out of} silver"

The writer assumes that the readers will know that the **posts** were made of wood and overlaid with **silver**. You could include this information if it would be helpful to your readers. Alternate translation: [He made its posts of wood that was overlaid with silver] or [He made its posts of wood covered in silver]

See: Assumed Knowledge and Implicit Information

Song of Songs 3:10 (#2)

רִפִּידָתֹ֥ו זָהָ֛ב

"its back, gold"

The writer is leaving out some of the words that in many languages a sentence would need to be complete. You could supply these words from the context if it would be clearer in your language. The phrase **its back, gold** could mean: (1) that the base or foundation of the palanquin was covered in gold. Alternate translation: [its foundation was covered in gold] or [its base of gold]; (2) the back of the chair was covered in gold. Alternate translation: [its back is made from gold]

See: Ellipsis

Song of Songs 3:10 (#5)

תֹּוכֹ֖ו רָצ֥וּף אַהֲבָ֛ה מִבְּנ֥וֹת יְרוּשָׁלָֽם

"Its interior was fitted {with} love from the daughters of Jerusalem"

If your language does not use an abstract noun for the idea of **love**, you could express the same idea in another way that is natural in your language.

See: Abstract Nouns

Song of Songs 3:10 (#4)

תֹּוכֹ֖ו רָצ֥וּף אַהֲבָ֛ה מִבְּנ֥וֹת יְרוּשָׁלָֽם

"Its interior was fitted {with} love from the daughters of Jerusalem"

If your language does not use this passive form, you could express this idea in active form or in another way that is natural in your language. Alternate translation: [The daughters of Jerusalem fitted its interior with love]

See: Active or Passive

Song of Songs 3:10 (#7)

מִבְּנ֥וֹת יְרוּשָׁלָֽם

"from the daughters of Jerusalem"

See how you translated the phrase **daughters of Jerusalem** in 1:5.

See: Possession

Song of Songs 3:10 (#6)

תּוֹכוֹ֙ רָצ֣וּף אַהֲבָ֔ה מִבְּנ֖וֹת יְרוּשָׁלָֽם

“Its interior was fitted {with} love from the daughters of Jerusalem”

Alternate translation: [The inside of it was lovingly inlaid with decorations by the women of Jerusalem]

Song of Songs 3:10 (#3)

מֶרְכָּבֹ֖ו אַרְגָּמָ֑ן

“its seat, purple cloth”

Alternate translation: [and covered the cushion with purple cloth]

Song of Songs 3:11 (#5)

וּבְי֖וֹם שִׂמְחַ֥ת לִבּֽוֹ

“on the day of the joy of his heart”

Here, **heart** represents Solomon’s inner being which the Jews viewed as the center of a person’s mind and feelings. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use an equivalent expression from your language or state the meaning plainly.

See: Metonymy

Song of Songs 3:11 (#4)

וּבְי֖וֹם שִׂמְחַ֥ת לִבּֽוֹ

“on the day of the joy of his heart”

If your language does not use an abstract noun for the idea of **joy**, you could express the same idea in another way that is natural in your language. Alternate translation: [on the day his heart was exceedingly joyful] or [on the day when his heart was very joyful]

See: Abstract Nouns

Song of Songs 3:11 (#2)

בְּנ֥וֹת צִיּ֑וֹן

“daughters of Zion”

Here the possessive form **daughters of Zion** is a poetic way of describing the young women who were from the city of Jerusalem (These are probably the same women as the “marriageable women” in 1:3 and the women referred to as “daughters of Jerusalem” in 2:7 and 3:5). If your language would not use the possessive form for this, you could indicate the association between these young women and Zion in a way that is natural in your language. Alternate translation: [young women from Zion] or [young women from the city of Zion] or [you young women who live in Zion]

See: Possession

Song of Songs 3:11 (#1)

צֶ֣אֶינָה

“Go out”

Your language may say “Come out” rather than **Go out** in a context such as this. Use whichever is more natural in your language. Alternate translation: [Come out]

See: Go and Come

Song of Songs 3:11 (#3)

בְּי֥וֹם חֲתֻנָּתֹ֖ו וּבְי֣וֹם שִׂמְחַ֥ת לִבּֽוֹ

“on the day of his wedding, on the day of the joy of his heart”

These two phrases mean basically the same thing. The second emphasizes the meaning of the first by repeating the same idea with different words. Hebrew poetry was based on this kind of repetition, and it would be good to show this to your readers by including both phrases in your translation rather than combining them. However, if it would be helpful to your readers, you could connect the phrases with a word other than “and” in order to show that the second phrase is repeating the first one, not saying something additional. Alternate translation: [on the day of his wedding, yes, on the day of the joy of his heart]

See: Parallelism

Song of Songs - Chapter 4 Introduction

Religious and Cultural Concepts in This Chapter

Beauty
The man describes the woman he loves as the epitome of beauty and attractiveness in 4:1–5 and in 4:7.

Feelings of longing to be with one’s lover who seems distant and temporarily inaccessible
In 4:8 the man speaks of the woman he loves as if she were far away from him, and he invites her to “come with” him and “descend from” the height of three high places and be with him. The woman is not actually dwelling in these places, but rather the man is using imaginative and poetic language to describe how he feels about being separated from her and to describe his desire to be with her. In 4:12 the man uses poetic language to describe the fact that the woman he loves is temporarily inaccessible.

Translation Issues in This Chapter

The garden metaphor
In this chapter, 4:12–5:1 is an extended metaphor. This metaphor is a conversation between the man and the woman he loves in which he first compares her to "a locked garden" (4:12–4:15) where many delightful things grow. She responds by inviting him to come to her garden in 4:16. The man then responds to her invitation in 5:1. The term "garden" is used as a metaphor for the woman in 4:12, 4:16 (two times), and 5:1. You should be consistent in how you translate the term "garden." In 4:13, the man speaks of the woman's body as "an orchard of pomegranate trees with delicious fruits," and then in 4:16 she invites the man to "come to his garden and eat its delicious fruit." (See: Biblical Imagery — Extended Metaphors)

The "sister" metaphor
The phrase "my sister" is used in 4:9, 4:10, 4:12, 5:1, and 5:2. The man uses this phrase as a term of endearment for the woman he loves. She is not actually his sister. You should translate this phrase the same way each time it occurs here, because the author uses it with the same meaning each time. See the note at the first occurrence of this phrase in 4:9 for more information.

Song of Songs 4:1 (#3)

שַׂעְרֵךְ כְּעֵדֶר הָעִזִּים שֶׁגָּלְשׁוּ מֵהַר גִּלְעָד

"Your hair {is} like a flock of goats that hop down from {the} slopes of Gilead"

The writer is saying that both the color and the motion of the woman's hair is **like a flock of goats that hop down from the slopes of Gilead**. The original readers would have understood this to mean that the woman's hair was black since goats in Israel were also black. Seen from a distance, a flock of black goats descending from the heights of Mount Gilead would have created a majestic visual effect because the goats would have looked like one long flowing mass of black. If it would be helpful in your language, you could state that explicitly. Alternate translation: [Your black hair moves in graceful waves like a flock of black goats moving down the slopes of Mount Gilead] or [Your long black hair flows in graceful waves like a flock of black goats coming down the slopes of Mount Gilead]

See: Simile

Song of Songs 4:1 (#1)

הִנָּךְ יָפָה רַעְיָתִי הִנָּךְ יָפָה

"Behold you! {You are} beautiful, my darling. Behold you! {You are} beautiful"

See how you translated these two parallel phrases in 1:15.

See: Parallelism

Song of Songs 4:1 (#2)

עֵינַיִךְ יוֹנִים מִבַּעַד לְצַמָּתֵךְ

"Your eyes {are} doves from behind your veil"

See how you translated the phrase **Your eyes are doves** in 1:15.

See: Metaphor

Song of Songs 4:2 (#1)

שִׁנַּיִךְ כְּעֵדֶר הַקְּצוּבּוֹת שֶׁעָלוּ מִן־הָרַחְצָה

"Your teeth {are} like a flock of shorn {sheep} that have come up from the washing"

The writer is saying that the white color of the woman's **teeth** is being compared to the white color of sheep after they have been **shorn** and washed. If it would be helpful in your language, you could state that explicitly.

See: Simile

Song of Songs 4:2 (#4)

שֶׁכֻּלָּם מַתְאִימוֹת וְשַׁכֻּלָּה אֵין בָּהֶם

"all of which bear twins, and there is not among them one which is bereaved"

The writer is stating that the woman's **teeth are like a flock of** female sheep which have all given birth to twin lambs because each of the woman's teeth has a matching tooth on the other side of her mouth. She has not lost any of her teeth. If it would be helpful to your readers, you could state that explicitly. Alternate translation: [As a flock of female sheep that has born twin lambs without losing any, so your mouth has its teeth, each with a match, and none of them are missing]

See: Simile

Song of Songs 4:2 (#3)

מַתְאִימוֹת

"bear twins"

Alternate translation: [give birth to twins]

Song of Songs 4:2 (#5)

וְשַׁכֻּלָּה אֵין בָּהֶם

“and there is not among them one which is bereaved”

Alternate translation: [and there is not one among them which has died]

Song of Songs 4:2 (#2)

הַקְּצוּבֹּות

“shorn {sheep”

If your language does not use this passive form, you could express the idea in active form or in another way that is natural in your language. If you must state who did the action, it is implied that “shepherds” did it. Alternate translation: [sheep whose wool shepherds have cut off] or [sheep whose wool people have cut off]

See: Active or Passive

Song of Songs 4:3 (#1)

כְּחוּט הַשָּׁנִי שִׂפְתֹתַיִךְ

“Like a thread of scarlet {are} your lips”

The writer is stating that the woman’s lips are **Like a thread of scarlet** because they are a bright red color. If it would be helpful in your language, you could state that explicitly. You could also use a term for a material that is thicker than thread such as ribbon. Alternate translation: [Your lips are a beautiful red like scarlet thread] or [Your lips are a beautiful red like scarlet ribbon]

See: Simile

Song of Songs 4:3 (#4)

מִבַּעַד לְצַמָּתֵךְ

“from behind your veil”

See how you translated the phrase **from behind your veil** in 4:1.

Song of Songs 4:3 (#2)

כְּפֶלַח הָרִמּוֹן רַקָּתֵךְ

“Like a slice of pomegranate {are} your cheeks”

The term translated as **cheeks** could: (1) refer to the woman’s two cheeks on the side of her mouth. (2) be translated as “temples” and refer to the woman’s two temples on the side of her forehead. Alternate translation: [Like a slice of pomegranate are your temples]; (3) be translated as “forehead.” Alternate translation: [Like a slice of pomegranate is your forehead]

Song of Songs 4:3 (#3)

כְּפֶלַח הָרִמּוֹן רַקָּתֵךְ

“Like a slice of pomegranate {are} your cheeks”

The writer could be comparing: (1) the shape of the woman’s **cheeks** to the shape of a **pomegranate** which has been sliced in half and to the red outside color of a pomegranate. Alternate translation: [Your cheeks are red and rounded like a slice of pomegranate] or [Your cheeks resemble the color and shape of a slice of pomegranate] or (if you decided that the term **cheeks** refers to the woman’s temples) [Your temples are red like a slice of pomegranate]; (2) the way the woman’s cheeks looked through the inside of the veil to the color and pattern of a **pomegranate** which has been sliced in half. Alternate translation: [Your cheeks resemble the color and pattern of the inside of a slice of pomegranate] or (if you decided that the term **cheeks** refers to the woman’s temples) [Your temples are the color of the inside of a slice of pomegranate]

See: Simile

Song of Songs 4:4 (#6)

אֶלֶף

“a thousand”

In the writer’s culture, the number **a thousand** was often used to represent a very large, but not precise, amount. This is how the number is being used here. Alternate translation: [with many]

See: Numbers

Song of Songs 4:4 (#1)

כְּמִגְדַּל דָּוִיד צַוָּארֵךְ בָּנוּי לְתַלְפִּיּוֹת

“Like the tower of David {is} your neck, built of layers”

The writer is saying that the woman’s **neck** is **Like the tower of David** which was a tall fortress **built of layers** or rows. A long neck was considered beautiful in the writer’s culture. King David built some of his towers of beautiful marble rock. It is probable that this tower was made from marble since it is compared to the beauty of the woman’s neck. If it would be helpful in your language, you could state that explicitly. Alternate translation: [Your neck is long and beautiful like the tower of David] or [Your neck is beautiful like the tower of David]

See: Simile

Song of Songs 4:4 (#5)

אֶ֣לֶף הַמָּגֵ֔ן תָּל֖וּי עָלָ֑יו כֹּ֖ל שִׁלְטֵ֥י הַגִּבּוֹרִֽים

“a thousand shields hanging on it, all the shields of the warriors”

In the writer’s culture it was a common practice to hang shields on walls as decorations. Here the man compares the beauty of the woman’s neck with **shields hanging on** the **tower of David**. This comparison probably included the decorations of the woman’s necklaces which probably went around her neck many times. If it would be helpful in your language, you could state that explicitly. Alternate translation: [The beauty of your neck jeweled in necklaces is like a thousand warriors’ shields hanging from a tower]

See: Simile

Song of Songs 4:4 (#7)

אֶ֣לֶף הַמָּגֵ֔ן תָּל֖וּי עָלָ֑יו כֹּ֖ל שִׁלְטֵ֥י הַגִּבּוֹרִֽים

“a thousand shields hanging on it, all the shields of the warriors”

The phrase **all the shields of the warriors** is parallel to the statement **a thousand shields hanging on it** and adds the additional information that the **shields** belonged to **the warriors**. Hebrew poetry often used this kind of parallel statement, in which the second line gives additional information, so it would be good to show this to your readers by including both phrases in your translation rather than combining them. If it would be helpful to your readers, you could connect these two parallel phrases with “each of which” or “each one” in order to show that the second phrase is not repeating the first one but rather saying something additional. Alternate translation: [a thousand shields hanging on it, each of which belongs to the warriors] or [a thousand shields hanging on it, each one belonging to the warriors]

See: Parallelism

Song of Songs 4:4 (#2)

כְּמִגְדַּ֤ל דָּוִיד֙

“Like the tower of David {is”

The **tower of David** was a tall building built for defense. Towers were significantly taller than other buildings and often were not wide. If your readers would not be familiar with this type of structure, you could use the name of something similar in your area, or you could use a more general term. Alternate translation: [Like the tall, narrow defense structure of David is] or [Like David’s tall, thin rock defense building is]

See: Translate Unknowns

Song of Songs 4:4 (#3)

כְּמִגְדַּ֤ל דָּוִיד֙ צַוָּארֵ֔ךְ בָּנ֖וּי לְתַלְפִּיּ֑וֹת

“Like the tower of David {is} your neck, built of layers”

If your language does not use a passive form like **built of layers**, you could express the idea in active form or in another way that is natural in your language. If you must state who did the action, the context implies that David instructed men to build it. Alternate translation: [Your neck is like the tower of David that men built in layers] or [Your neck is like the tower of David that David had men build of layers]

See: Active or Passive

Song of Songs 4:4 (#4)

בָּנ֖וּי לְתַלְפִּיּ֑וֹת

“built of layers”

Alternate translation: [built using rows of stones]

Song of Songs 4:5 (#1)

שְׁנֵ֣י שָׁדַ֔יִךְ כִּשְׁנֵ֥י עֳפָרְרִ֖ים תְּאוֹמֵ֣י צְבִיָּ֑ה הָרוֹעִ֖ים בַּשּׁוֹשַׁנִּֽים

“Your two breasts {are} like two fawns, twins of a female gazelle, the ones pasturing among the lilies”

Here the man compares the woman’s **two breasts** to young twin gazelles. The context does not explicitly indicate how exactly the woman’s breasts are like young gazelles so it would be best if you leave the point of comparison unstated and simply express the simile as the author of this book has done.

See: Simile

Song of Songs 4:5 (#2)

צְבִיָּ֑ה

“a female gazelle”

See how you translated the plural form “gazelles” in 2:7.

See: Translate Unknowns

Song of Songs 4:5 (#3)

בַּשּׁוֹשַׁנִּֽים

“among the lilies”

See how you translated the singular form “lily” in 2:1.

See: Translate Unknowns

Song of Songs 4:6 (#4)

אֵלֵךְ לִי אֶל־הַהַר הַמֹּר וְאֶל־גִּבְעַעַת הַלְּבוֹנָה

“I myself will go to the mountain of myrrh and to the hill of frankincense”

Here the writer is speaking of the woman’s breasts as if they are **the mountain of myrrh** and **the hill of frankincense**. The man is discreetly indicating that his bride’s breasts are pleasant smelling and that he wants to enjoy them. It would be good to retain this discreet and beautiful poetic imagery if possible. If it would be helpful in your language, you could state the meaning plainly or use a comparison. Alternate translation: [I myself will go to your breasts, which are like two sweet-smelling mountains] or [I myself will be close to your breasts, which are like two pleasant-smelling hills]

See: Metaphor

Song of Songs 4:6 (#2)

אֵלֵךְ לִי

“I myself will go”

Your language may say “come” rather than **go** in a context such as this. Use whichever is more natural. Alternate translation: [I myself will come]

See: Go and Come

Song of Songs 4:6 (#3)

הַמֹּר

“myrrh”

See how you translated **myrrh** in 1:13.

See: Translate Unknowns

Song of Songs 4:6 (#1)

עַד שֶׁיָּפוּחַ הַיּוֹם וְנָסוּ הַצְּלָלִים

“Until the day breathes and the shadows flee”

See how you translated the phrase **Until the day breathes and the shadows flee** in 2:17.

See: Personification

Song of Songs 4:7 (#1)

כֻּלָּךְ יָפָה

“All of you {is} beautiful”

Alternate translation: [Every part of you is beautiful]

Song of Songs 4:8 (#1)

אִתִּי מִלְּבָנוֹן כַּלָּה אִתִּי מִלְּבָנוֹן תָּבִיאִי תָּשׁוּרִי ׀ מֵרֹאשׁ אֲמָנָה מֵרֹאשׁ שְׂנִיר וְחֶרְמוֹן מִמְּעֹנְנוֹת אֲרָיוֹת מֵהַרְרֵי נְמֵרִים

“Come} with me from Lebanon, {my} bride; come with me from Lebanon. Descend from the top of Amana, from the top of Senir and Hermon, from the hiding places of lions, from the mountains of leopards”

This entire verse is a metaphor. This is poetry and the writer is not literally indicating that the woman is in the mountains and in danger. Rather, he is using this metaphor to express his feelings regarding the distance between them and his strong desire to have her near him. If it would be helpful in your language, you could state the meaning plainly.

See: Metaphor

Song of Songs 4:8 (#3)

תָּשׁוּרִי

“Descend”

The word translated as **Descend** here could mean: (1) to come down from a height. Alternate translation: [Climb down]; (2) to bend down and look. Alternate translation: [Bend down and look]

Song of Songs 4:8 (#4)

מֵרֹאשׁ אֲמָנָה מֵרֹאשׁ שְׂנִיר וְחֶרְמוֹן

“from the top of Amana, from the top of Senir and Hermon”

The word **Hermon** is the name of a mountain range in northern Israel, and **Amana** and **Senir** are both the names of mountain peaks.

See: How to Translate Names

Song of Songs 4:8 (#5)

מִמְּעֹנְנוֹת אֲרָיוֹת מֵהַרְרֵי נְמֵרִים

“from the hiding places of lions, from the mountains of leopards”

These two phrases mean very similar things. The second emphasizes the meaning of the first by repeating the same idea with different words. Hebrew poetry was based on this kind of repetition, and it would be good to show this to your readers by including both phrases in your translation rather than combining them. However, if it would be helpful for your readers, you could combine these two phrases into one as modeled by the UST.

See: Parallelism

Song of Songs 4:8 (#2)

אִתִּ֥י תָבֹ֖אִי & תָּבֹ֖אִי

“Come} with me & come”

Your language may say “go” rather than **come** in a context such as this. Use whichever is more natural. Alternate translation: [Go with me ... go]

See: Go and Come

Song of Songs 4:9 (#3)

אֲחֹתִ֔י

“my sister”

Here the man is speaking of the woman as if she were his **sister**. This is a term of endearment which expresses affection, close companionship, and a deep emotional bond between the lovers. The woman is not actually his sister. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use a different term of endearment or state the meaning plainly.

See: Metaphor

Song of Songs 4:9 (#2)

לִבַּבְתִּ֣נִי & לִבַּבְתִּ֣ינִי

“You have enchanted my heart & you have enchanted my heart”

The phrase translated as **You have enchanted my heart** is an idiom which could mean: (1) to steal or capture a person’s heart. In Jewish thinking, the heart was the center of a person’s thinking. This phrase probably also meant that he was so in love that he could not think clearly. If this phrase does not have that meaning in your language, you could use a comparable phrase from your language that does have that meaning, or you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [You have captured my heart ... you have captured my heart] or [It is as though you have captured my heart ... it is as though you have captured my heart] or [You have made me feel so in love with you that it is as if I have lost my mind ... you have made me feel so in love with you that it is as if I have lost my mind]; (2) the woman had made the man’s heart beat faster. Alternate translation: [You have caused my heart to beat fast ... you have caused my heart to beat fast]; (3) that the woman had encouraged the man’s heart. Alternate translation: [You have encouraged my heart ... you have encouraged my heart] or [You have given me heart ... you have given me heart]

See: Idiom

Song of Songs 4:9 (#1)

לִבַּבְתִּ֣נִי אֲחֹתִ֔י כַּלָּ֖ה לִבַּבְתִּ֣ינִי

“You have enchanted my heart, my sister, {my} bride; you have enchanted my heart”

If it would be more natural in your language, you could change the order of these phrases. If it would be helpful to your readers, you could also add the word “yes” to show that the phrase **You have enchanted my heart** is repeated in order to add emphasis. Alternate translation: [My sister, my bride; you have enchanted my heart. Yes, you have enchanted my heart]

See: Information Structure

Song of Songs 4:10 (#4)

מַה־יָּפ֥וּ דֹדַ֖יִךְ & מַה־טֹּ֣בוּ דֹדַ֑יִךְ מִיָּ֔יִן

“How your love is beautiful & How your love {is} better than wine”

If your language does not use an abstract noun for the idea of **love**, you could express the same idea in another way.

See: Abstract Nouns

Song of Songs 4:10 (#6)

שְׁמָנַ֖יִךְ

“your oils {is better”

The writer is leaving out some of the words that in many languages a sentence would need in order to be complete. You could supply the words **is better** from earlier in the sentence if it would be clearer in your language.

See: Ellipsis

Song of Songs 4:10 (#3)

מַה־יָּפ֥וּ דֹדַ֖יִךְ אֲחֹתִ֔י כַּלָּ֑ה מַה־טֹּ֣בוּ דֹדַ֔יִךְ מִיַּ֔יִן

“How your love is beautiful, my sister, {my} bride! How your love {is} better than wine”

If it would be more natural in your language, you could change the order of these phrases. Alternate translation: [My sister, my bride; how your love is beautiful! How your love is better than wine]

See: Information Structure

Song of Songs 4:10 (#2)

אֲחֹתִ֔י

“my sister”

See how you translated the phrase **my sister** in 4:9.

See: Metaphor

Song of Songs 4:10 (#1)

מַה & מַה

“How & How”

Here the word **How** is used as an exclamation to emphasize two statements about how wonderful the woman’s love is. Use an exclamation that would communicate that meaning in your language.

See: Exclamations

Song of Songs 4:10 (#5)

שְׁמָנַיִךְ

“your oils {is better”

Here, **oils** refers to perfumes. In the author’s culture, pleasant-smelling spices were mixed into olive oil in order to make perfume which was put on the skin. You could include this information if it would be helpful to your readers. Alternate translation: [your scented oils are better] or [the perfumed oils on your skin are better]

See: Assumed Knowledge and Implicit Information

Song of Songs 4:11 (#2)

נֹפֶת

“nectar”

The word translated as **nectar** refers specifically to honey which drips or flows from a honeycomb. If it would be helpful to your readers, you could indicate that explicitly by translating it as “honey”.

See: Assumed Knowledge and Implicit Information

Song of Songs 4:11 (#1)

נֹפֶת תִּטֹּפְנָה שִׂפְתוֹתַיִךְ

“Your lips drip {with} nectar”

Here the woman’s **lips** refer to the kisses from her lips. The man says that her **lips drip with nectar** to indicate the pleasantness of her kisses. If it would be helpful in your language, you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [Your kisses are so pleasant that it is as if your lips drip with nectar] or [Your kisses are delightfully sweet] or [Being kissed by you is as enjoyable as eating honey]

See: Metaphor

Song of Songs 4:11 (#4)

וְרֵיחַ שַׂלְמֹתַיִךְ כְּרֵיחַ לְבָנוֹן

“and the smell of your garments {is} like the smell of Lebanon”

Lebanon is known for its forests of cedar trees. Cedar trees have a very pleasant smell. The phrase **the smell of your garments is like the smell of Lebanon** probably means that the woman’s clothes smelled like cedar wood. If it would be helpful to your readers, you could include this information. Alternate translation: [and the smell of your garments is like the smell of Lebanon’s pleasant-smelling cedar]

See: Assumed Knowledge and Implicit Information

Song of Songs 4:11 (#3)

דְּבַשׁ וְחָלָב תַּחַת לְשׁוֹנֵךְ

“honey and milk {are} under your tongue”

The phrase **honey and milk are under your tongue** could mean: (1) that the taste of the woman’s kisses were as pleasant as milk and honey. Alternate translation: [your kisses are like milk and honey to me] or [your kisses are as pleasant and delightful as milk and honey]; (2) that the woman’s words were as pleasant as milk and honey. Alternate translation: [your words are as pleasant as milk and honey]; (3) that both the woman’s kisses and her words were as pleasant as milk and honey. Alternate translation: [the kisses from your mouth and your words are as pleasant as milk and honey to me]

See: Metaphor

Song of Songs 4:12 (#3)

גַּן ׀ נָעוּל אֲחֹתִי כַלָּה

“A locked garden {is} my sister, {my} bride”

The word translated as **garden** refers to a large, enclosed area where bushes, flowers, plants, and trees grow. If your readers would not be familiar with this type of garden, you could use the name of something similar in your area, or you could use a more general term. Alternate translation: [A locked park where many trees and plants grow is my sister, my bride]

See: Translate Unknowns

Song of Songs 4:12 (#1)

גַּן ׀ נָעוּל אֲחֹתִי כַלָּה גַּל נָעוּל מַעְיָן חָתוּם

“A locked garden {is} my sister, {my} bride, a locked spring, a sealed fountain”

If it would be more natural in your language, you could change the order of these phrases. Alternate translation: [My sister, my bride; you are a locked garden, a locked spring, a sealed fountain]

See: Information Structure

Song of Songs 4:12 (#2)

גַּ֣ן ׀ נָעוּל֮ אֲחֹתִ֣י כַלָּה֒

“A locked garden {is} my sister, {my} bride”

The man is speaking of the woman as if she were a **locked garden**. He uses **garden** as a poetic way of referring to the woman herself, and by saying she is a **locked garden** he means that the woman is both beautiful and seemingly inaccessible like a locked garden. If it would be helpful in your language, you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [You are like a locked garden, my sister, my bride]

See: Metaphor

Song of Songs 4:12 (#4)

אֲחֹתִ֣י

“my sister”

See how you translated the phrase **my sister** in 4:9.

See: Metaphor

Song of Songs 4:12 (#5)

גַּ֥ל נָעוּל֙ מַעְיָ֣ן חָת֔וּם

“a locked spring, a sealed fountain”

The man continues to draw an extended comparison between the woman he loves and a garden by speaking of her as if she were **a locked spring** and **a sealed fountain** within a locked garden. The man means that the woman’s body is beautiful and inaccessible like a locked spring or a sealed fountain. You could explain this comparison if it would be helpful to your readers. If you used the alternate translation, “You are like a locked garden, my sister, my bride”, then you should use the alternate translation which follows. Alternate translation: [you are like a locked spring; you are like a sealed fountain]

See: Biblical Imagery — Extended Metaphors

Song of Songs 4:12 (#6)

גַּ֥ל נָעוּל֙ מַעְיָ֣ן חָת֔וּם

“a locked spring, a sealed fountain”

The phrases **a locked spring** and **a sealed fountain** mean basically the same thing. The second phrase emphasizes the meaning of the first by repeating the same idea using different words. If it would be helpful to your readers, you could combine the phrases and show the emphasis in some other way.

See: Parallelism

Song of Songs 4:13 (#1)

שְׁלָחַ֖יִךְ

“Your shoots {are”

The word translated as **shoots** refers to the stems and roots that come out (shoot out) from trees and plants. The word **shoots** is used here to refer to the woman so if it would be helpful to your readers, you could translate the phrase **Your shoots** as “You”. Alternately, you could translate it with a more general term that your language uses to speak of what grows out of plants and trees. Alternate translation: [Your sprouts are]

See: Biblical Imagery — Extended Metaphors

Song of Songs 4:13–14 (#3)

כְּפָרִ֔ים עִם־נְרָדִ֖ים נֵרְדְּ

“henna with nard,nard”

See how you translated the word **nard** in 1:12 and the word **henna** in 1:14.

See: Translate Unknowns

Song of Songs 4:13–14 (#1)

שְׁלָחַ֖יִךְ פַּרְדֵּ֑ס רִמּוֹנִ֗ים עִ֚ם פְּרִ֣י מְגָדִ֔ים כְּפָרִ֖ים עִם־נְרָדִֽים׃ נֵרְדְּ ׀ וְכַרְכֹּ֗ם קָנֶ֥ה וְקִנָּמוֹן֮ עִ֣ם כָּל־עֲצֵ֣י לְבוֹנָה֒ מֹ֤ר וַאֲהָלוֹת֙ עִ֣ם כָּל־רָאשֵׁ֔י בְּשָׂמִֽים

“Your shoots {are} an orchard of pomegranate trees with delicious fruits, henna with nard,nard and saffron, calamus and cinnamon, with all trees of frankincense, myrrh and aloes, with all the best spices”

The man continues to draw an extended comparison between these plants and the woman by speaking of her as if she were **an orchard of pomegranate trees** and various other spices, pleasant-smelling plants, and trees in the “locked garden” (4:12). If you translated 4:12 using the words “You are like,” then you should also do that here. Alternate translation: [You are like an orchard of pomegranate trees with delicious fruits; henna with nard, nard and saffron; calamus and cinnamon with all trees of frankincense; myrrh and aloes with all the best spices]

See: Biblical Imagery — Extended Metaphors

Song of Songs 4:13–14 (#2)

שְׁלָחַיִךְ פַּרְדֵּס רִמּוֹנִים עִם פְּרִי מְגָדִים כְּפָרִים עִם־נְרָדִים׃ נֵרְדְּ ׀ וְכַרְכֹּם קָנֶה וְקִנָּמוֹן עִם כָּל־עֲצֵי לְבוֹנָה מֹר וַאֲהָלוֹת עִם כָּל־רָאשֵׁי בְשָׂמִים

“Your shoots {are} an orchard of pomegranate trees with delicious fruits, henna with nard,nard and saffron, calamus and cinnamon, with all trees of frankincense, myrrh and aloes, with all the best spices”

Here the man uses poetic language to describe the woman as if she is a garden where all types of pleasant plants and trees grow. These plants and trees would not normally grow in the same garden because they have different growing requirements, but because this is poetry the author places these plants in one garden to create a poetic comparison for how wonderful the woman is. If it would be helpful to your readers, you could indicate in a footnote that the author is using plants and trees from different areas to create an image of how wonderful the woman is.

See: Poetry

Song of Songs 4:14 (#1)

וְכַרְכֹּם קָנֶה וְקִנָּמוֹן & וַאֲהָלוֹת

“and saffron, calamus and cinnamon & and aloes”

Both **saffron**, a beautiful flowering plant that produces purple flowers, and **calamus**, a cane, were used to make a pleasant-smelling oil. The term **cinnamon** refers to a spice made from the bark of the cinnamon tree. The term **aloes** refers to the pleasant-smelling resin that comes from specific trees in Asia. If your readers would not be familiar with these types of plants, you could use the names of similar plants in your area, or you could use more general terms. Alternate translation: [and saffron flowers, calamus canes and cinnamon trees … and pleasant-smelling resins called aloes]

See: Translate Unknowns

Song of Songs 4:15 (#1)

מַעְיַן גַּנִּים בְּאֵר מַיִם חַיִּים וְנֹזְלִים מִן־לְבָנוֹן

“a fountain of gardens, a well of living waters, and flowing streams from Lebanon”

Here the man continues the metaphor that he began in 4:12 and speaks of the woman he loves as if she were **a fountain** in a garden, **a well of living waters**, and **flowing streams from Lebanon**. If you translated 4:12–14 using the words “You are like”, you should do that here also. See how you translated the word “garden” in 4:12. Alternate translation: [you are like a fountain of gardens, like a well of living waters, and like flowing streams from Lebanon]

See: Biblical Imagery — Extended Metaphors

Song of Songs 4:15 (#3)

מַעְיַן גַּנִּים

“a fountain of gardens”

Here the author could be using the plural form **gardens** to: (1) designate the kind of fountain that would be found in gardens. Alternate translation: [a garden fountain]; (2) designate a large garden. Alternate translation: [a fountain in a large garden]

See: Unusual Uses of the Plural

Song of Songs 4:15 (#4)

מַיִם חַיִּים

“living waters”

Here the term **living** means that the water is fresh and flowing. If it would be helpful to your readers, you could include this information. Alternate translation: [fresh water] or [flowing water]

See: Assumed Knowledge and Implicit Information

Song of Songs 4:15 (#2)

מַעְיַן גַּנִּים

“a fountain of gardens”

The writer assumes that the readers will understand that a **fountain** refers to a spring or underground well that is dug in order to be used as a water source. If it would be helpful to your readers, you could include this information. Alternate translation: [a garden spring] or [a garden well]

See: Assumed Knowledge and Implicit Information

Song of Songs 4:16 (#2)

וּבְוֹאִי & יָבֹא דוֹדִי

“and come & Let my beloved come”

Your language may say “go” rather than **come** in a context such as this. Use whichever is more natural. Alternate translation: [and go … Let my beloved go]

See: Go and Come

Song of Songs 4:16 (#3)

עוּרִי צָפוֹן וּבוֹאִי תֵימָן הָפִיחִי גַּנִּי יִזְּלוּ בְשָׂמָיו יָבֹא דוֹדִי לְגַנּוֹ וְיֹאכַל פְּרִי מְגָדָיו

“Awake, north wind, and come, south wind; blow on my garden and let its spices flow. Let my beloved come to his garden and eat its delicious fruit”

Here the woman continues the “garden” metaphor (from 4:12) by referring to her body as **my garden** and then **his garden**. The woman calls to the wind to blow on her **garden** so that **its spices flow** into the air and attract the man she loves. She invites him to **come to his garden** (a poetic way of inviting him to come and enjoy her body). You should translate the term **garden** here the same way you did in 4:12 because both uses refer to the woman’s body. In 4:13 the man spoke of her body as “an orchard of pomegranate trees with delicious fruits,” and here the woman invites the man to **come to his garden and eat its delicious fruit**. If you translated 4:12–15 as a comparison, you should also translate the sentence **Let my beloved come to his garden and eat its delicious fruit** as a comparison.

See: Biblical Imagery — Extended Metaphors

Song of Songs 4:16 (#1)

עֹרִי צָפוֹן וּבוֹאִי תֵימָן הָפִיחִי גַנִּי יִזְּלְלוּ בְשָׂמָיו

“Awake, north wind, and come, south wind; blow on my garden and let its spices flow”

The woman is speaking to the **wind** which she knows cannot hear her. She is doing this to communicate her strong desire that the pleasant smell of her body will flow through the air and attract the man she loves so that he will come to her. If it would be helpful in your language, you could translate these words as a wish or desire. Alternate translation: [I wish that the north wind and south wind would come and blow on my garden and let its spices flow]

See: Apostrophe

Song of Songs 4:16 (#4)

יִזְּלְלוּ בְשָׂמָיו

“and let its spices flow”

Alternate translation: [and carry the pleasant smell of its spices through the air] or [and make the pleasant smell of its spices flow through the air]

Song of Songs - Chapter 5 Introduction

Structure and Formatting

5:1 The conclusion of the garden metaphor

5:2–8 The theme of longing and searching

5:9 The women of Jerusalem ask the young woman why she thinks the man she loves is special

5:10–16 The woman responds to the question the young women of Jerusalem asked her

Religious and Cultural Concepts in This Chapter

The attractiveness of the man
The woman describes the man as the epitome of male attractiveness in 5:10–16.

Translation Issues in This Chapter

Metaphors
As the author has done throughout this book so far, he continues to use metaphors to describe feelings and events that are common to romantic relationships. (See: Metaphor)

Order of events
5:2–8 seems to describe events that would have chronologically and logically occurred before the events described in 3:6–5:1. The solution to this seeming problem is to understand that this book is poetry and because the author is using poetry to describe the couple’s romantic relationship and its associated feelings, he does not need to follow the conventions of chronological story telling.

Whether 5:2–8 describes events that really happened or that happened in a dream.
There are two main views among Bible scholars regarding the events described in 5:2–8. One view is that the events which 5:2–8 describe happened in a dream. The other view is that the events that 5:2–8 describe happened after the man awakened the women from sleeping or from being nearly asleep. The vast majority of Bible scholars think that the first view is correct and that the events described in 5:2–8 happened in a dream.

The “sister” metaphor
The phrase “my sister” is used in 4:9, 4:10, 4:12, 5:1, and 5:2. The man uses this phrase as a term of endearment for the woman he loves. The woman is not actually his sister. You should translate this phrase in 5:1 and 5:2 the same way you translated it in 4:9, 4:10, and 4:12, because the author uses it with the same meaning here. See the note at the first occurrence of this phrase in 4:9 for more information.

An alternate translation possibility for the word the ULT translates as “towers of” in 5:13
In verse 13, the ULT follows the standard Hebrew text by saying “towers of.” However, as a footnote in the ULT indicates, many biblical scholars believe that the original reading was more likely “yielding.” Consider using that reading in your translation. If “yielding” is used in place of “towers of” then the first portion of

5:13 in the ULT would read "His cheeks {are} like a bed of spices, yielding herbal spices" (and The UST would read "His cheeks are like a garden where spices grow that produce sweet-smelling perfume"). The phrase "yielding herbal spices" would then be further describing the phrase "a bed of spices." The point of the comparison would be that the man's cheeks smell like a garden bed of spices which yields herbal spices. If you choose to use the word "yielding" in your translation, you could explain the comparison if it would be helpful to your readers. Alternate translation: [His cheeks smell like a bed of spices that produce herbal spices] or [His cheeks smell like a bed of spices that yield herbal spices]

Song of Songs 5:1 (#7)

אִכְלוּ֙ רֵעִ֔ים שְׁתּ֥וּ וְשִׁכְר֖וּ דּוֹדִֽים

"Eat, friends; drink, and be drunk, beloved ones"

Here the speaker is speaking of "eating and drinking" as metaphors to represent the couple enjoying their sexual union. The phrase **be drunk** is an encouragement to fully enjoy the delights of their sexual union. If it would be helpful to your readers, you could express the meaning plainly, or you could use a phrase such as "drink deeply" or "drink abundantly" instead of "be drunk." Alternate translation: [Enjoy your marital intimacy and make love until you are fully satisfied as if you are eating food until full and drinking wine freely] or [Eat, friends; Drink, and be drunk with love] or [Eat, friends; Drink, and drink abundantly of love]

See: Metaphor

Song of Songs 5:1 (#2)

בָּ֤אתִי לְגַנִּי֙ אֲחֹתִ֣י כַלָּ֔ה אָרִ֖יתִי מוֹרִ֣י עִם־בְּשָׂמִ֑י אָכַ֤לְתִּי יַעְרִי֙ עִם־דִּבְשִׁ֔י שָׁתִ֥יתִי יֵינִ֖י עִם־חֲלָבִ֑י

"I have come to my garden, my sister, {my} bride; I have plucked my myrrh with my spice. I have eaten my honeycomb with my honey; I have drunk my wine with my milk"

Though the man is speaking as if he has already done these things, he is actually getting ready to do them. If it would be helpful to your readers, you could include this information. Alternate translation: [I am getting ready to come to my garden, my sister, my bride; I will pluck my myrrh with my spice. I will eat my honeycomb with my honey; I will drink my wine with my milk]

See: Assumed Knowledge and Implicit Information

Song of Songs 5:1 (#6)

אִכְלוּ֙ רֵעִ֔ים שְׁתּ֥וּ וְשִׁכְר֖וּ דּוֹדִֽים

"Eat, friends; drink, and be drunk, beloved ones"

Since the author does not say who is speaking to the couple here, you should not indicate who is speaking in the text of your translation. However, if you are using section headers to indicate who is speaking, the speakers could be: (1) the "daughters of Jerusalem" who spoke earlier in the book. They are speaking to the couple at the couple's wedding. You can use a phrase such as "The young women of Jerusalem speak to the couple" or "The young women of Jerusalem speak to the couple at their wedding" (2) a group of people who are the couple's friends and wedding guests. You can use a phrase such as "The couple's friends speak" or "The couple's wedding guests speak"

See: When to Keep Information Implicit

Song of Songs 5:1 (#3)

בָּ֤אתִי

"I have come"

Your language may say "gone" rather than **come** in a context such as this. Use whichever is more natural. Alternate translation: [I have gone]

See: Go and Come

Song of Songs 5:1 (#1)

בָּ֤אתִי לְגַנִּי֙ אֲחֹתִ֣י כַלָּ֔ה אָרִ֖יתִי מוֹרִ֣י עִם־בְּשָׂמִ֑י אָכַ֤לְתִּי יַעְרִי֙ עִם־דִּבְשִׁ֔י שָׁתִ֥יתִי יֵינִ֖י עִם־חֲלָבִ֑י

"I have come to my garden, my sister, {my} bride; I have plucked my myrrh with my spice. I have eaten my honeycomb with my honey; I have drunk my wine with my milk"

Here the man continues to draw an extended comparison between the woman's body and the **garden** that he began in 4:12. He accepts the woman's invitation (that she gave in the previous verse) to enjoy her body. The lines **I have plucked my myrrh with my spice** and **I have eaten my honeycomb with my honey** and **I have drunk my wine with my milk** are all metaphors for the man enjoying the woman's body. If you used the alternate translation in verses 4:12–16, you should do so here also. Alternate translation: [You who are as dear to me as a sister, my bride, I am ready to go with you and enjoy the delights of your body; it will be as though I am gathering myrrh with my other spices, eating my honey and honeycomb, and drinking my wine and my milk]

See: Biblical Imagery — Extended Metaphors

Song of Songs 5:1 (#5)

אֲחֹתִי

“my sister”

See how you translated the phrase **my sister** in 4:9.

See: Metaphor

Song of Songs 5:1 (#4)

בָּבָאתִי לְגַנִּי אֲחֹתִי כַלָּה

“I have come to my garden, my sister, {my} bride”

If it would be more natural in your language, you could change the order of these phrases. Alternate translation: [My sister, my bride, I have come to my garden]

See: Information Structure

Song of Songs 5:2 (#6)

שֶׁרֹּאשִׁי נִמְלָא־טָל

“because my head {is} full of dew”

Here the phrase **full of** is a Hebrew expression which means “wet with.” If this phrase does not have that meaning in your language, you could use a comparable expression from your language that does have that meaning or you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [because my head is wet with dew]

See: Idiom

Song of Songs 5:2 (#7)

קְוֻצּוֹתַי

“my hair {is full of”

The writer is leaving out some of the words that in many languages a sentence would need to be complete. You could supply the words **is full of** from the previous phrase if it would be clearer to your readers.

See: Ellipsis

Song of Songs 5:2 (#4)

אֲחֹתִי רַעְיָתִי

“my sister, my darling”

See how you translated the phrase **my sister** in 4:9 and the phrase **my darling** in 1:9.

See: Metaphor

Song of Songs 5:2 (#2)

קוֹל ׀ דּוֹדִי דוֹפֵק

“A sound—my beloved is knocking”

Alternate translation: [I hear a sound; it is my beloved knocking] or [I hear a sound; it is the sound of my beloved knocking on my door]

Song of Songs 5:2 (#5)

יוֹנָתִי

“my dove”

See how you translated the phrase **my dove** in 2:14.

See: Metaphor

Song of Songs 5:2 (#1)

אֲנִי יְשֵׁנָה וְלִבִּי עֵר

“I {am} asleep, but my heart {is} awake”

Here the term **heart** could represent: (1) the woman’s thoughts and mental awareness which would make the phrase **my heart is awake** mean that her mind is alert and dreaming while she is sleeping. Alternate translation: [I am asleep, but my mind is dreaming] or [I am asleep, but my mind is alert and dreaming]; (2) the woman’s entire person which would make the phrase **my heart is awake** mean that she had been awakened after falling asleep or awakened after she was almost asleep. Alternate translation: [I was almost asleep, now I am awakened] or [I was asleep, but now I have been awakened]

See: Metonymy

Song of Songs 5:2 (#3)

דּוֹדִי

“my beloved”

See how you translated the phrase **my beloved** in 1:13. Alternate translation: [my lover]

Song of Songs 5:3 (#2)

אֵיכָכָה אֶלְבָּשֶׁנָּה רָחַצְתִּי אֶת־רַגְלַי אֵיכָכָה אֲטַנְּפֵם

“how will I put it on? I have washed my feet; how could I get them dirty”

The woman is using the question form for emphasis. If you would not use the question form for this purpose in your language, you could translate this as a statement or an exclamation and express the emphasis in a way that is natural in your language. Alternate translation: [I do not want to put it back on! I have already washed my feet so I do not want to get them dirty again!]

See: Rhetorical Question

Song of Songs 5:3 (#1)

פָּשַׁטְתִּי֙ אֶת־כֻּתָּנְתִּ֔י אֵיכָ֖כָה אֶלְבָּשֶׁ֑נָּה רָחַ֙צְתִּי֙ אֶת־רַגְלַ֔י אֵיכָ֖כָה אֲטַנְּפֵֽם

“I have taken off my robe; how will I put it on? I have washed my feet; how could I get them dirty”

This verse is a quotation of: (1) what the woman thought to herself. Alternate translation: [I thought to myself; I have taken off my robe; how will I put it on? I have washed my feet; how could I get them dirty?]; (2) the woman speaking directly to the man. Alternate translation: [I said to the man I love; I have taken off my robe; how will I put it on? I have washed my feet; how could I get them dirty?]

See: Quote Markings

Song of Songs 5:4 (#3)

וּמֵעַ֥י הָמְי֖וּ עָלָֽיו

“and my belly roared concerning him”

Here the term **belly** represents the woman’s feelings and the woman saying that her **belly roared** is a poetic way of saying that her feelings were aroused. If it would be helpful in your language, you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [and my feelings for him were aroused]

See: Metaphor

Song of Songs 5:4 (#1)

דּוֹדִ֔י

“My beloved”

See how you translated the phrase **my beloved** in 1:13.

Song of Songs 5:4 (#2)

וּמֵעַ֥י הָמְי֖וּ עָלָֽיו

“and my belly roared concerning him”

Here, **belly** represents the center of a person’s emotions. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use an equivalent expression from your language or state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [and my feelings for him roared]

See: Metonymy

Song of Songs 5:5 (#3)

וְאֶצְבְּעֹתַ֖י

“and my fingers {dripped with”

The woman is leaving out some of the words that in many languages a sentence would need to be complete. If it would be helpful to your readers, you could supply the words “dripped with.”

See: Ellipsis

Song of Songs 5:5 (#2)

מָ֣ר עֹבֵ֔ר

“flowing myrrh”

The phrase translated as **flowing myrrh** refers to liquid myrrh. If it would be helpful to your readers, you could indicate that explicitly. Alternate translation: [liquid myrrh]

See: Assumed Knowledge and Implicit Information

Song of Songs 5:5 (#1)

וְיָדַ֤י נָטְפ֙וּ־מ֔וֹר וְאֶצְבְּעֹתַ֖י מָ֣ר עֹבֵ֑ר

“and my hands dripped {with} myrrh and my fingers {dripped with} flowing myrrh”

The two phrases **my hands dripped with myrrh** and **my fingers dripped with flowing myrrh** mean basically the same thing. The second emphasizes the meaning of the first by repeating the same idea with different words. Hebrew poetry was based on this kind of repetition, and it would be good to show this to your readers by including both phrases in your translation rather than combining them. However, if it would be helpful to your readers, you could connect the phrases with a word other than “and” in order to show that the second phrase is repeating the first one, not saying something additional. Alternate translation: [and my hands dripped with myrrh, yes, my fingers dripped with flowing myrrh]

See: Parallelism

Song of Songs 5:6 (#6)

וְלֹ֥א עָנָֽנִי

“but he did not answer me”

The implication is that the man did not answer because he was not there. She is not saying that he was present but not answering. You could include this information if it would be helpful to your readers. Alternate translation: [but he did not answer me, since he was not there]

See: Assumed Knowledge and Implicit Information

Song of Songs 5:6 (#2)

עָבָֽר

“and gone”

Your language may say “went” rather than **gone** in a context such as this. Use whichever is more natural. Alternate translation: [and went away]

See: Go and Come

Song of Songs 5:6 (#1)

לְדוֹדִי וְדוֹדִי

“to my beloved, but my beloved”

See how you translated the phrase **my beloved** in 1:13.

Song of Songs 5:6 (#4)

נַפְשִׁי יָצְאָה

“My soul went out”

Here, **soul** represents the entire person, and the phrase **My soul went out** is a Hebrew idiom that means to feel extreme despair. If this phrase does not have that meaning in your language, you could use a comparable expression from your language that has this meaning or state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [My heart sank] or [I felt great despair]

See: Idiom

Song of Songs 5:6 (#5)

בְּדַבְּרוֹ

“because he departed”

Here the word translated as **because he departed** could mean: (1) when he departed. If you choose this option, use the translation of the ULT. (2) “when he spoke.” Alternate translation: [when he spoke]

Song of Songs 5:6 (#3)

נַפְשִׁי יָצְאָה

“My soul went out”

Your language may say “gone” rather than **went** in a context such as this. Use whichever is more natural. Alternate translation: [My soul had gone out]

See: Go and Come

Song of Songs 5:7 (#1)

מְצָאַנִי הַשֹּׁמְרִים הַסֹּבְבִים בָּעִיר

“The guards going about in the city found me”

See how you translated the sentence **The guards going about in the city found me** in 3:3.

See: Translate Unknowns

Song of Songs 5:7 (#4)

אֶת־רְדִידִי

“my shawl”

The word translated as **shawl** could refer to: (1) a light article of clothing like a robe or cloak that was worn as an outer garment and wrapped around the body. Alternate translation: [my cloak]; (2) a large veil. Alternate translation: [my veil]

See: Translate Unknowns

Song of Songs 5:7 (#5)

שֹׁמְרֵי הַחֹמוֹת

“the guards of the walls”

The men called **the guards of the walls** are the same men as “The guards going about in the city” mentioned earlier in the verse. If it would be helpful to your readers, you could include this information. Alternate translation: [those guards who were going about in the city guarding the walls]

See: Assumed Knowledge and Implicit Information

Song of Songs 5:7 (#3)

הִכּוּנִי פְצָעוּנִי

“They beat me and wounded me”

The reason that the city watchmen **beat** and **wounded** the woman is because they thought she was a prostitute. You could include this information if it would be helpful to your readers.

See: Assumed Knowledge and Implicit Information

Song of Songs 5:7 (#2)

הִכּוּנִי פְצָעוּנִי נָשְׂאוּ אֶת־רְדִידִי מֵעָלַי שֹׁמְרֵי הַחֹמוֹת

“They beat me and wounded me; they lifted my shawl from me, the guards of the walls”

If it would be more natural in your language, you could change the order of these phrases. Alternate translation: [The guards of the walls beat me and wounded me; they lifted my shawl from me]

See: Information Structure

Song of Songs 5:8 (#3)

שֶׁחוֹלַת אַהֲבָה אָנִי

“Declare to him} that sick {with} love {am} I”

The woman is leaving out some of the words that a sentence would need in many languages to be com-

plete. If it would be helpful in your language, you could supply these words from the context.

See: Ellipsis

Song of Songs 5:8 (#2)

שֶׁחוֹלַ֥ת אַהֲבָ֖ה אָֽנִי

“Declare to him} that sick {with} love {am} I”

See how you translated the phrase **sick with love am I** in 2:5

See: Hyperbole

Song of Songs 5:8 (#1)

הִשְׁבַּ֙עְתִּי אֶתְכֶ֣ם בְּנ֔וֹת יְרוּשָׁלִָ֑ם

“I adjure you, daughters of Jerusalem”

See how you translated the phrase **I adjure you, daughters of Jerusalem** in 2:7.

See: Oath Formulas

Song of Songs 5:9 (#4)

הַיָּפָ֖ה בַּנָּשִֽׁים

“most beautiful among women”

See how you translated the phrase **most beautiful among women** in 1:8.

Song of Songs 5:9 (#1)

מַה־דּ֣וֹדֵ֔ךְ מִדּ֖וֹד הַיָּפָ֣ה בַּנָּשִׁ֑ים מַה־דּ֣וֹדֵ֔ךְ מִדּ֖וֹד שֶׁכָּ֥כָה הִשְׁבַּ֙עְתָּנוּ

“What {is} your beloved more than {another} beloved, most beautiful among women? What {is} your beloved more than {another} beloved, that thus you adjure us”

The phrase **What is your beloved more than another beloved** is repeated for emphasis. This is a common feature of Hebrew poetry, and you may want to begin a new line at the start of each parallel statement. However, if it would be helpful to your readers, you could combine them into one. Alternate translation: [What is your beloved more than another beloved, most beautiful among women, that thus you adjure us] or [Most beautiful among women, what is your beloved more than another beloved, that thus you adjure us]

See: Poetry

Song of Songs 5:9 (#6)

הִשְׁבַּ֙עְתָּנוּ

“you adjure us”

See how you translated the word **adjure** in the previous verse.

See: Oath Formulas

Song of Songs 5:9 (#3)

מַה־דּ֣וֹדֵ֔ךְ מִדּ֖וֹד הַיָּפָ֣ה בַּנָּשִׁ֑ים

“What {is} your beloved more than {another} beloved, most beautiful among women”

If it would be more natural in your language, you could change the order of these phrases. Alternate translation: [Most beautiful among women, what is your beloved more than another beloved]

See: Information Structure

Song of Songs 5:9 (#2)

מַה־דּ֣וֹדֵ֔ךְ מִדּ֖וֹד

“What {is} your beloved more than {another} beloved”

Alternate translation: [What makes the man you love better than other men] or [What is so special about the man you love]

Song of Songs 5:9 (#5)

שֶׁכָּ֥כָה הִשְׁבַּ֙עְתָּנוּ

“that thus you adjure us”

Alternate translation: [with the result that thus you adjure us] or [with the result that you request us to promise that we tell him that] or [that would make you want to thus adjure us]

Song of Songs 5:10 (#1)

דּוֹדִ֥י צַח֖וּ וְאָדֽוֹם

“My beloved {is} shimmering and red”

The words translated here as **shimmering** and **red** mean that the man’s skin had a healthy glow and was a reddish-brown color. These two words used together indicate that the man’s skin looked healthy and handsome. If it would be helpful to your readers, you could include this information. Alternate translation: [My beloved has radiant and healthy skin] or [My beloved’s skin glows and is a handsome reddish-brown]

See: Assumed Knowledge and Implicit Information

Song of Songs 5:10 (#2)

דָּגֽוּל מֵרְבָבָֽה

“distinguished among ten thousand”

In the Hebrew language **ten thousand** is the highest number that was used when making comparisons, so the woman uses this number to stand for an uncountable number of people. If you have a similar expression in your culture, you could use it, or if it would be helpful to your readers, you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [better than anyone else] or [and there is no one else like him] or [one in a million]

See: Metaphor

Song of Songs 5:11 (#1)

רֹאשׁוֹ כֶּתֶם פָּז

“His head {is} gold, refined gold”

Here the woman is speaking of the man’s **head** as if it were **gold**. Because she speaks of the appearance of the man’s hair in the following line, she probably intends in this line to refer to his face. The phrase **refined gold** indicates that the gold is very valuable. By saying that the man’s **head is gold, refined gold**, she is probably indicating that he is special and has great worth. If it would be helpful in your language, you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [His head is like gold that is refined] or [His face is beautiful and gleams like gold. He is precious and valuable like refined gold] or [His face gleams. He is precious and valuable]

See: Metaphor

Song of Songs 5:11 (#3)

קְוצוֹתָיו֙ תַּלְתַּלִּ֔ים שְׁחֹרוֹת֙ כָּעוֹרֵֽב

“his hairs {are} wavy, black like the raven”

The writer is stating that the color of the man’s hair is dark **black like the raven**. If it would be helpful in your language, you could state that explicitly. Alternate translation: [his hair is wavy and dark black]

See: Simile

Song of Songs 5:11 (#2)

שְׁחֹרוֹת֙ כָּעוֹרֵֽב

“black like the raven”

A **raven** is a large bird with dark black feathers. Ravens are as big as some hawks and are similar in color and appearance to crows but larger. If your readers would not be familiar with this type of bird, you could use the name of a similar bird in your area or you could use a more general term. Alternate translation: [black like a bird with dark black feathers] or [black like a dark black bird]

See: Translate Unknowns

Song of Songs 5:12 (#1)

עֵינָ֜יו כְּיוֹנִ֗ים עַל־אֲפִ֫יקֵי֥ מָ֑יִם רֹחֲצוֹת֙ בֶּֽחָלָ֔ב יֹשְׁבוֹת֙ עַל־מִלֵּֽאת

“His eyes {are} like doves beside stream beds of water, bathing in milk, sitting beside the pools”

In 1:15 the man said to the woman, “your eyes are doves.” Here the woman uses the word **like** and compares the man’s eyes to doves that are **bathing in milk**. The phrase **bathing in milk** refers to the color of the doves’ feathers and the man’s eyes. The two phrases **beside stream beds of water** and **sitting beside the pools** describe the doves as being by water. If it would be helpful to your readers, you could state that explicitly. Alternate translation: [His eyes are like doves beside stream beds of water that are bathing in milk and sitting beside the pools]

See: Simile

Song of Songs 5:12 (#2)

עֵינָ֜יו כְּיוֹנִ֗ים עַל־אֲפִ֫יקֵי֥ מָ֑יִם רֹחֲצוֹת֙ בֶּֽחָלָ֔ב יֹשְׁבוֹת֙ עַל־מִלֵּֽאת

“His eyes {are} like doves beside stream beds of water, bathing in milk, sitting beside the pools”

The phrases **beside stream beds of water** and **sitting beside the pools** mean basically the same thing. They both describe the doves as being by water. Hebrew poetry was based on this kind of repetition, and it would be good to show this to your readers by including both phrases in your translation rather than combining them. However, if it would be helpful to your readers, you could combine them. Alternate translation: [His eyes are like doves beside stream beds of water, bathing in milk] or [His eyes are like doves bathing in milk, sitting by the pools]

See: Parallelism

Song of Songs 5:13 (#1)

לְחָיָו֙ כַּֽעֲרוּגַ֣ת הַבֹּ֔שֶׂם מִגְדְּלוֹת֙ מֶֽרְקָחִ֔ים

“His cheeks {are} like a bed of spices, towers of herbal spices”

Here the writer says that the man’s **cheeks** are like a garden, or an area in a garden, used for planting spices because his cheeks smell **like a bed of spices** and are like **towers of herbal spices**. If it would be helpful to your readers, you could state that explicitly. Alternate

translation: [His cheeks smell like a bed of spices and like towers that contain herbal spices]

See: Simile

Song of Songs 5:13 (#5)

שִׂפְתוֹתָיו שֽׁוֹשַׁנִּים נֹטְפֹות מֹר עֹבֵר

“His lips {are} lilies, dripping {with} flowing myrrh”

Here the woman is speaking of the man’s **lips** as if they are **lilies** that are **dripping with flowing myrrh** because of the sweet smell of both lilies and myrrh, the beauty and softness of lilies, and because the man’s kisses are wet like flowing myrrh. If it would be helpful to your readers, you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [His lips are beautiful, fragrant, and soft. His kisses are sweet-smelling and moist]

See: Metaphor

Song of Songs 5:13 (#4)

מִגְדְּלֹות מֶרְקָחִֽים

“towers of herbal spices”

The woman is leaving out some of the words that a sentence would need in many languages to be complete. If it would be helpful to your readers, you could supply these words from the context. Alternate translation: [like towers of herbal spices] or [and they are like towers of herbal spices]

See: Ellipsis

Song of Songs 5:13 (#7)

מֹר עֹבֵר

“flowing myrrh”

See how you translated the phrase **flowing myrrh** in 5:5.

See: Assumed Knowledge and Implicit Information

Song of Songs 5:13 (#3)

מִגְדְּלֹות

“towers of”

See the Chapter 5 introduction for information regarding an alternate translation of the word that the ULT translates as **towers of**.

See: Textual Variants

Song of Songs 5:13 (#6)

שֽׁוֹשַׁנִּים

“lilies”

See how you translated **lilies** in 2:16.

See: Translate Unknowns

Song of Songs 5:13 (#2)

כַּעֲרוּגַת הַבֹּֽשֶׂם

“like a bed of spices”

Here the term translated as **bed** refers to an area in a garden used for planting. If it would be helpful to your readers, you could include this information. Alternate translation: [like an area for planting spices] or [like a garden bed of spices] or [like planters of spices]

See: Assumed Knowledge and Implicit Information

Song of Songs 5:14 (#4)

מֵעָיו עֶֽשֶׁת שֵׁ֔ן מְעֻלֶּ֖פֶת סַפִּירִֽים

“his belly {is} a plate of ivory covered {with} sapphires”

Here the woman is speaking of the man’s **belly** as if it was **a plate of ivory covered with sapphires**. By making this comparison, she is saying that the man’s belly looks especially attractive since ivory and sapphires were not only rare and costly but also quite beautiful. If it would be helpful to your readers, you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [his belly is beautiful and precious] or [his belly is handsome]

See: Metaphor

Song of Songs 5:14 (#3)

בַּתַּרְשִׁ֑ישׁ

“with topaz”

A **topaz** is a beautiful gemstone used in jewelry and also to decorate other things. Bible scholars are not certain exactly what stone **topaz** refers to. Many different stones have been proposed such as topaz, chrysolite, beryl and others. If your readers are familiar with these types of stone, you could use one of them, or you could use a more general term. Alternate translation: [with beautiful stones] or [with jewels]

See: Translate Unknowns

Song of Songs 5:14 (#6)

שֵׁ֔ן

“ivory”

The word **ivory** refers to the tusks of an elephant. Ivory is a white color and is very beautiful and costly. If your readers would not be familiar with ivory, you could explain this term in a footnote.

See: Translate Unknowns

Song of Songs 5:14 (#1)

יָדָיו֙ גְּלִילֵ֣י זָהָ֔ב מְמֻלָּאִ֖ים בַּתַּרְשִׁ֑ישׁ

“His arms {are} rods of gold mounted with topaz”

Here the woman is speaking of the man’s **arms** as if they were **rods of gold mounted with topaz** because rods of gold were powerful, had an attractive color and a finely rounded shape; and topaz would have made the rods of gold more beautiful. If it would be helpful in your language, you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [His arms are powerful, nicely rounded, and beautiful like rods of gold mounted with topaz]

See: Metaphor

Song of Songs 5:14 (#5)

מֵעָ֔יו

“his belly {is”

Alternate translation: [his stomach is]

Song of Songs 5:14 (#2)

יָדָיו֙

“His arms {are”

The word that the ULT translates as **arms** could: (1) refer to arms in which case you can use the ULT’s translation. (2) refer to “hands.” Alternate translation: [His hands are]

Song of Songs 5:14 (#7)

סַפִּירִ֖ים

“with} sapphires”

The word **sapphires** refers to beautiful blue gemstones. If your readers would not be familiar with this type of stone, you could use the name of something similar in your area, or you could use a more general term. Alternate translation: [with blue gemstones] or [with beautiful blue gemstones]

See: Translate Unknowns

Song of Songs 5:15 (#1)

שׁוֹקָ֔יו עַמּוּדֵ֥י שֵׁ֖שׁ מְיֻסָּדִ֑ים עַל־אַדְנֵי־פָ֣ז

“His thighs {are} pillars of alabaster set on bases of refined gold”

Here the woman is speaking of the man’s **thighs** as if they were **pillars of alabaster set on bases of refined gold** because the man’s legs are strong and majestic looking. If it would be helpful to your readers, you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [His thighs are strong and majestic like pillars of alabaster set on bases of gold]

See: Metaphor

Song of Songs 5:15 (#3)

שֵׁ֑שׁ

“alabaster”

The word translated as **alabaster** can refer to either alabaster or marble, types of strong stone that are nice looking and used to make large columns, statues, and other things. If your readers would not be familiar with alabaster or marble, you could use the name of something similar in your area, or you could use a more general term. Alternate translation: [marble] or [stone]

See: Translate Unknowns

Song of Songs 5:15 (#4)

מַרְאֵ֣הוּ֔ כַּלְּבָנ֖וֹן בָּח֥וּר כָּאֲרָזִֽים

“his appearance {is} like Lebanon, {as} choice as the cedars”

The woman is saying that the man’s **appearance is like Lebanon, as choice as the cedars** because he is tall, strong, and outstanding in comparison to other men, just as the cedars of Lebanon are better than all other trees. Lebanon was famous for its cedar trees which were considered to be superior. The word **choice** here means “excellent quality.” If it would be helpful in your language, you could state the meaning explicitly. Alternate translation: [His appearance is tall and strong and stately. He is outstanding among other men] or [His appearance is majestic. He is strong and tall and better than other men]

See: Simile

Song of Songs 5:15 (#2)

שׁוֹקָ֔יו

“His thighs {are”

The word the ULT translates as **thighs** most likely refers to the entirety of a person’s legs, so you could translate this term as “legs” as in the UST.

See: Assumed Knowledge and Implicit Information

Song of Songs 5:16 (#1)

חִכּוֹ֥ מַמְתַקִּ֖ים

“His mouth {is} most sweet”

Here, **mouth** could refer to: (1) the man’s kisses. Alternate translation: [His kisses are most sweet]; (2) the man’s words. Alternate translation: [His speech is most sweet] or [The words from his mouth are most sweet]

See: Metonymy

Song of Songs 5:16 (#3)

בְּנ֥וֹת יְרוּשָׁלָֽם

“daughters of Jerusalem”

See how you translated the phrase **daughters of Jerusalem** in 1:5.

See: Possession

Song of Songs 5:16 (#2)

וְכֻלּ֖וֹ מַחֲמַדִּ֑ים

“and all of him {is} most desirable”

Alternate translation: [and every part of him is very desirable]

Song of Songs - Chapter 6 Introduction

Religious and Cultural Concepts in This Chapter

Beauty

In 6:4–10 the man describes the woman he loves as the epitome of female beauty and attractiveness by using various comparisons.

Translation Issues in This Chapter

Metaphors

In the ancient Near East, it was acceptable to describe a woman using comparisons to animals. In many cultures today, this can be considered offensive. Different comparisons of beauty are used in different cultures. (See: Simile)

The meaning of 6:12

6:12 is very difficult to understand, and its meaning is uncertain. Therefore, Bible scholars have different opinions on the exact meaning of this verse, and of some of the words in context, and on how the words and phrases relate to each other. Published versions of the Bible differ significantly from one another in their rendering of it. The ULT seeks to offer a reasonable translation of this verse. If a translation of the Bible exists in your region, it may differ from the ULT in the way that it translates this verse. In that case, you may wish to use the rendering that it uses. If not, you may wish to follow the rendering of the ULT.

The meaning of the phrase “like the dance of two armies” in 6:13

The meaning of the phrase “like the dance of two armies” is uncertain and Bible scholars have different opinions on the exact meaning of this verse. The ULT offers one possible translation of this verse. If a translation of the Bible exists in your region, it may differ from the ULT in the way that it translates this verse. In that case, you may wish to use the translation that it uses. If not, you may wish to follow the reading of the ULT.

Song of Songs 6:1 (#1)

אָ֚נָה הָלַ֣ךְ דּוֹדֵ֔ךְ הַיָּפָ֖ה בַּנָּשִׁ֑ים אָ֚נָה פָּנָ֣ה דוֹדֵ֔ךְ וּנְבַקְשֶׁ֖נּוּ עִמָּֽךְ

“Where did he go, your beloved, most beautiful woman among women? Where did he turn, your beloved, and let us seek him with you”

The questions **Where did he go, your beloved** and **Where did he turn, your beloved** have basically the same meaning. This question is asked twice, in slightly different ways, for emphasis and poetic effect. This type of repetition is a common feature of Hebrew poetry, and it would be good to retain this repetition if possible. However, if it would be helpful to your readers, you could combine the phrases into one. Alternate translation: [Where did he go, your beloved, most beautiful woman among women? Let us seek him with you] or [Most beautiful woman among women, where did he turn your beloved? Let us seek him with you]

See: Parallelism

Song of Songs 6:1 (#4)

אָ֚נָה פָּנָ֣ה דוֹדֵ֔ךְ

“Where did he turn, your beloved”

Alternate translation: [Which way did your beloved go]

Song of Songs 6:1 (#3)

הַיָּפָ֖ה בַּנָּשִׁ֑ים

“most beautiful woman among women”

See how you translated the phrase **most beautiful woman among women** in 1:8.

Song of Songs 6:1 (#5)

וּנְבַקְשֶׁנּוּ עִמָּךְ

“and let us seek him with you”

The women of Jerusalem are leaving out some of the words that in many languages a sentence would need in order to be complete. You could supply these words from the context if it would be helpful to your readers. Alternate translation: [tell us, so that we can seek him with you] or [tell us, and let us seek him with you]

See: Ellipsis

Song of Songs 6:1 (#2)

אָנָה הָלַךְ דּוֹדֵךְ & אָנָה פָּנָה דּוֹדֵךְ

“Where did he go, your beloved & Where did he turn, your beloved”

Alternate translation: [Where did your beloved go ... Where did your beloved turn]

Song of Songs 6:2 (#5)

בַּגַּנִּים

“in the gardens”

Here the phrase **in the gardens** refers to the woman just like the phrase **his garden** does earlier in the verse. If it would be helpful to your readers, you could include this information. Alternate translation: [in his gardens] or [in his garden]

See: Assumed Knowledge and Implicit Information

Song of Songs 6:2 (#3)

יָרַד

“went down”

Your language may say “gone” rather than **went** in a context such as this. Use whichever is more natural. Alternate translation: [has gone down]

See: Go and Come

Song of Songs 6:2 (#4)

לַעֲרוּגֹת הַבֹּשֶׂם

“to the beds of spices”

See how you translated the similar phrase **bed of spices** in 5:13.

Song of Songs 6:2 (#1)

דּוֹדִי יָרַד לְגַנּוֹ לַעֲרוּגֹת הַבֹּשֶׂם לִרְעוֹת בַּגַּנִּים וְלִלְקֹט שֽׁוֹשַׁנִּים

“My beloved went down to his garden, to the beds of spices, in order to graze in the gardens and in order to glean lilies”

Here the woman resumes the “garden” metaphor that was used in 4:12–5:1 by again referring to her body as a **garden**. The phrase **graze in the gardens** and **glean lilies** are both metaphors for the man enjoying the woman’s body. If you used the word “like” to translate 4:12–5:1, you should continue to use it here, or if it would be helpful in your language, you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [My beloved went to me. I am like a garden where beds of spices grow. He came to me in order to enjoy my body like a gazelle enjoys grazing in gardens and like a person enjoys gleaning lilies]

See: Metaphor

Song of Songs 6:2 (#2)

דּוֹדִי יָרַד לְגַנּוֹ לַעֲרוּגֹת הַבֹּשֶׂם

“My beloved went down to his garden, to the beds of spices”

The phrase **to the beds of spices** explains where in the garden the man went down to. This phrase is not describing a separate location from the **garden** (woman). If it would be helpful to your readers, you could include this information. Alternate translation: [My beloved went down to the beds of spices in his garden] or [My beloved went to me who is like his spice garden]

See: Assumed Knowledge and Implicit Information

Song of Songs 6:3 (#2)

הָרֹעֶה בַּשּׁוֹשַׁנִּים

“he grazes among the lilies”

See how you translated the similar phrase “the man grazing among the lilies” in 2:16.

See: Metaphor

Song of Songs 6:3 (#1)

אֲנִי לְדוֹדִי וְדוֹדִי לִי

“I {belong} to my beloved, and my beloved {belongs} to me”

See how you translated the similar phrase “My beloved belongs to me and I belong to him” in 2:16.

See: First, Second or Third Person

Song of Songs 6:4 (#1)

יָפָה אַתְּ רַעְיָתִי כְּתִרְצָה נָאוָה כִּירוּשָׁלִָם

“You {are} beautiful, my darling, like Tirzah, lovely like Jerusalem”

The man is saying that the woman is **like** the city of **Tirzah** and **like** the city of **Jerusalem** because both of these cities were beautiful. These lines are parallel, and both mean basically the same thing. If it would be helpful in your language, you could state that explicitly. Alternately, you could combine the lines if it would be helpful to your readers. Alternate translation: [You are beautiful, my darling, like the beautiful city of Tirzah, lovely like the lovely city of Jerusalem] or [You are beautiful and lovely, my darling, like the cities of Tirzah and Jerusalem]

See: Simile

Song of Songs 6:4 (#2)

יָפָה אַתְּ רַעְיָתִי

“You {are} beautiful, my darling”

See how you translated the phrase “you are beautiful, my darling” in 1:15.

Song of Songs 6:4 (#4)

נָאוָה כִּירוּשָׁלִָם אֲיֻמָּה כַּנִּדְגָּלוֹת

“lovely like Jerusalem, awe-inspiring like bannered armies”

The man is leaving out some of the words that in many languages a sentence would need in order to be complete. You could supply these words from the context if it would be clearer in your language. Alternate translation: [you are lovely like Jerusalem; you are awe-inspiring like bannered armies]

See: Ellipsis

Song of Songs 6:4 (#5)

אֲיֻמָּה כַּנִּדְגָּלוֹת

“awe-inspiring like bannered armies”

The man is saying that the woman is **awe-inspiring like bannered armies** because looking at her causes the man to feel a sense of awe that is comparable to seeing an army with its banners above it. If it would be helpful in your language, you could state that explicitly. Alternate translation: [and the awe I feel when looking at you is like the awe I would feel if I were to see armies with their banners] or [and the awe I feel when looking at you is like the awe I feel when I see armies with their banners above them]

See: Simile

Song of Songs 6:4 (#3)

יָפָה אַתְּ רַעְיָתִי כְּתִרְצָה

“You {are} beautiful, my darling, like Tirzah”

If it would be more natural in your language, you could change the order of these phrases. Alternate translation: [My darling, you are beautiful like Tirzah]

See: Information Structure

Song of Songs 6:4 (#6)

כַּנִּדְגָּלוֹת

“like bannered armies”

See how you translated the term “banner” in 2:4.

See: Translate Unknowns

Song of Songs 6:5 (#1)

שַׂעְרֵךְ כְּעֵדֶר הָעִזִּים שֶׁגָּלְשׁוּ מִן־הַגִּלְעָד

“Your hair {is} like a flock of goats that hop down from Gilead”

See how you translated the similar sentence “Your hair is like a flock of goats that hop down from the slopes of Gilead” in 4:1.

See: Simile

Song of Songs 6:6 (#2)

הָרְחֵלִים

“ewes”

The term **ewes** refers to female sheep. If it would be helpful to your readers, you could include this information. Alternate translation: [female sheep]

See: Assumed Knowledge and Implicit Information

Song of Songs 6:6 (#1)

שִׁנַּיִךְ כְּעֵדֶר הָרְחֵלִים שֶׁעָלוּ מִן־הָרַחְצָה שֶׁכֻּלָּם מַתְאִימוֹת וְשַׁכֻּלָה אֵין בָּהֶם

“Your teeth {are} like a flock of ewes that have come up from the washing, all of which bear twins, and there is not among them one which is bereaved”

See how you translated the almost identical verse in 4:2. The only difference between this verse and 4:2 is that 4:2 has the phrase “shorn sheep” instead of **ewes**.

See: Simile

Song of Songs 6:7 (#1)

כְּפֶלַח הָרִמּוֹן רַקָּתֵךְ מִבַּעַד לְצַמָּתֵךְ

“Like a slice of a pomegranate {are} your cheeks from behind your veil”

See how you translated 4:3 which is identical to this verse.

See: Simile

Song of Songs 6:8 (#2)

שִׁשִּׁים הֵמָּה מְלָכוֹת וּשְׁמֹנִים פִּילַגְשִׁים

“Sixty {are} they, queens, and eighty concubines”

This is poetic language. The man is using the 3, 4 pattern that was commonly used at that time, and for emphasis he multiples the numbers 3 and 4 by the number 20. This gives the numbers **Sixty** and **eighty** that he uses to make his point. If your language has a way to indicate poetry, you could use it here. Alternate translation: [A large number of queens and a large number of concubines] or [Many queens and many concubines]

See: Poetry

Song of Songs 6:8 (#3)

וַעֲלָמוֹת

“and marriageable women”

See how you translated the phrase **marriageable women** in 1:3.

See: Translate Unknowns

Song of Songs 6:8 (#4)

וַעֲלָמוֹת אֵין מִסְפָּר

“and marriageable women without number”

Here, **without number** is an idiom that means “more than can be counted.” If this phrase does not have that meaning in your language, you could use a comparable expression from your language that does have that meaning, or you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [and too many marriageable women to count] or [and more marriageable women than can be counted]

See: Idiom

Song of Songs 6:8 (#1)

שִׁשִּׁים הֵמָּה מְלָכוֹת

“Sixty {are} they, queens”

If it would be more natural in your language, you could change the order of the words in the phrase **Sixty are they, queens**. Alternate translation: [They are sixty queens]

See: Information Structure

Song of Songs 6:8–9 (#1)

שִׁשִּׁים הֵמָּה מְלָכוֹת וּשְׁמֹנִים פִּילַגְשִׁים וַעֲלָמוֹת אֵין מִסְפָּר׃
אַחַת הִיא֙ יוֹנָתִ֣י תַמָּתִ֔י אַחַ֥ת הִיא֙ לְאִמָּ֣הּ בָּרָ֔ה הַרְאִיָ֥ה בָנ֖וֹת וַיְאַשְּׁרֻ֑הָ

“Sixty {are} they, queens, and eighty concubines, and marriageable women without number.One {is} she, my dove; my perfect one—one {is} she to her mother; pure {is} she to the woman who bore her”

This is a comparison that expresses that the woman is superior to women in a king’s royal court. If it would be helpful to your readers, you could add words that explicitly indicate that this is a comparison. Alternate translation: [When compared to sixty queens, eighty concubines, and marriageable women without number, none of them are as special as my dove; my perfect one who is special to her mother and pure to the woman who bore her] or [Even if compared to sixty queens, eighty concubines, and marriageable women without number, still none of them would be as special as my dove; my perfect one who is special to her mother and pure to the woman who bore her]

See: Metaphor

Song of Songs 6:9 (#5)

אַחַת הִיא֙ לְאִמָּ֣הּ בָּרָ֔ה הַרְאִיָ֥ה בָנ֖וֹת וַיְאַשְּׁרֻ֑הָ

“one {is} she to her mother; pure {is} she to the woman who bore her”

If you decided that **one** means “special” here and that **pure** means “favorite” then these two lines are parallel and mean basically the same thing. The second line emphasizes the meaning of the first by repeating the same idea with different words. Hebrew poetry was based on this kind of repetition. It would be good to show this to your readers by including both phrases in your translation rather than combining them. However, if it would be helpful to your readers, you could combine these two lines into one. Alternate translation: [her mother thinks that she is very special] or [she is very special to her mother]

See: Parallelism

Song of Songs 6:9 (#3)

אַחַת הִיא֙ לְאִמָּ֣הּ

“one {is} she to her mother”

The phrase **one is she to her mother** could mean: (1) that the woman the man loves is special to her mother (in contrast to the large numbers of other women described in the previous verse). Alternate translation: [she is special to her mother] or [her mother thinks she is special] or [her mother thinks she is unique]; (2) that the woman was the only child or the only daughter of her mother. Alternate translation: [she is the only child of her mother] or [her mother’s only daughter]

Song of Songs 6:9 (#1)

אַחַ֥ת הִ֖יא

“One {is} she”

Here the phrase **One is she** means “She is special” (the number **One** is used in contrast to the large numbers of other women described in the previous verse). If it would be helpful to your readers, you could include this information. Alternate translation: [She is special] or [She is unique] or [She is special in comparison to other women]

See: Assumed Knowledge and Implicit Information

Song of Songs 6:9 (#6)

בָּנ֣וֹת

“The daughters”

Here the word **daughters** could refer to: (1) the “marriageable women” in the previous verse. Alternate translation: [The marriageable women] or [The young women of the kings court]; (2) young women in general, possibly “the daughters of Jerusalem” mentioned several times earlier in the book. Alternate translation: [The young women]

See: Assumed Knowledge and Implicit Information

Song of Songs 6:9 (#4)

בָּרָ֣ה הִ֔יא לְיוֹלַדְתָּ֖הּ

“pure {is} she to the woman who bore her”

The phrase **pure is she to the woman who bore her** could mean: (1) that the woman was her mother’s favorite child or favorite daughter. Alternate translation: [the favorite child of the woman who bore her] or [the favorite daughter of the woman who bore her]; (2) that the woman was pure or flawless in some way. Alternate translation: [flawless is she to the woman who bore her]

Song of Songs 6:9 (#2)

יוֹנָתִ֥י תַמָּתִ֖י

“my dove; my perfect one”

See how you translated the phrases **my dove** and **my perfect one** in 5:2.

See: Metaphor

Song of Songs 6:10 (#1)

מִי־זֹ֣את הַנִּשְׁקָפָ֗ה כְּמוֹ־שָׁ֙חַר֙ יָפָ֣ה כַלְּבָנָ֔ה בָּרָ֖הּ כַּחַמָּ֑ה אֲיֻמָּ֖ה כַּנִּדְגָּלֽוֹת

“Who {is} that, the woman who looks down like {the} dawn, beautiful like the moon, pure like the sun, awe-inspiring like bannered armies”

The author does not say who is speaking here so you should not indicate explicitly who is speaking in the text of your translation. However, if you are using section headers, the speaker or speakers could be: (1) the man speaking to the woman he loves. You can follow the example of the UST and include this verse under the section heading for 6:4–10 that indicates the man is speaking. (2) the “daughters,” the “queens,” and the “concubines” mentioned in the previous verse. You can use a phrase for the section header such as “The daughters, the queens, and the concubines praise the woman” or “The other women praise the woman” or something comparable.

See: When to Keep Information Implicit

Song of Songs 6:10 (#2)

מִי־זֹ֣את הַנִּשְׁקָפָ֗ה כְּמוֹ־שָׁ֙חַר֙ יָפָ֣ה כַלְּבָנָ֔ה בָּרָ֖הּ כַּחַמָּ֑ה אֲיֻמָּ֖ה כַּנִּדְגָּלֽוֹת

“Who {is} that, the woman who looks down like {the} dawn, beautiful like the moon, pure like the sun, awe-inspiring like bannered armies”

The man is not asking for information but is using the question form for emphasis. If you would not use the question form for this purpose in your language, you could translate this as a statement or an exclamation and communicate the emphasis in another way. Alternate translation: [Look at this woman who looks down like the dawn, beautiful like the moon, pure like the sun, terrifying like the bannered army!]

See: Rhetorical Question

Song of Songs 6:10 (#3)

הַנִּשְׁקָפָ֗ה כְּמוֹ־שָׁ֙חַר֙

“the woman who looks down like {the} dawn”

Here the man speaks of the woman and compares her to the sun as it dawns in the morning. If it would be helpful in your language, you could express this meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [the woman who shines like the sun as it rises early in the morning and brightens the sky] or [the woman who shines like the sun as it rises early in the morning and shines down from the sky]

See: Simile

Song of Songs 6:10 (#4)

הַנִּשְׁקָפָה כְּמוֹ־שָׁשַׁחַר יָפָה כַלְּבָנָה בָּרָה֙ כַּחַמָּ֔ה

“the woman who looks down like {the} dawn, beautiful like the moon, pure like the sun”

Here the man first says that the woman is like the sun in the morning as it dawns. He then says that her beauty is like the beauty of **the moon**. He then compares the woman’s radiance to the radiance of **the sun**. If it would be helpful to your readers, you could state these comparisons explicitly.

See: Simile

Song of Songs 6:10 (#5)

אֲיֻמָּ֖ה כַּנִּדְגָּלֽוֹת

“awe-inspiring like bannered armies”

See how you translated the identical phrase **awe-inspiring like bannered armies** in 6:4.

See: Simile

Song of Songs 6:11 (#3)

יָרַ֙דְתִּי֙

“I went down”

Your language may say “gone” rather than **went** in a context such as this. Use whichever is more natural. Alternate translation: [I had gone down]

See: Go and Come

Song of Songs 6:11 (#1)

אֶל־גִּנַּ֣ת אֱגוֹז֔ יָרַ֙דְתִּי֙

“To the garden of {the} nut tree I went down”

The speaker is using the possessive form to describe an area where walnut trees grow. If your language would not use a possessive form for this, you could clarify the relationship for your readers. Alternate translation: [To the nut tree garden I went down] or [To the place where walnut trees grow, I went down]

See: Possession

Song of Songs 6:11 (#2)

אֶל־גִּנַּ֣ת אֱגוֹז֔ יָרַ֙דְתִּי֙

“To the garden of {the} nut tree I went down”

If it would be more natural in your language, you could reverse the order of these phrases. Alternate translation: [I went down to the garden of the nut tree]

See: Information Structure

Song of Songs 6:11–12 (#1)

אֶל־גִּנַּ֣ת אֱגוֹז֔ יָרַ֙דְתִּי֙ לִרְא֣וֹת בְּאִבֵּ֔י הַנָּחַ֖ל לִרְא֣וֹת֙ הֲפָרְחָ֣ה הַגֶּ֔פֶן הֵנֵ֥צוּ הָרִמֹּנִֽים׃ לֹ֥א יָדַ֖עְתִּי נַפְשִׁ֣י שָׂמַ֑תְנִי מַרְכְּבֹ֖ות עַמִּי־נָדִֽיב

“To the garden of {the} nut tree I went down, to look at the green shoots of the valley, to see—had the vine budded? Had the pomegranates bloomed?I did not know—my soul put me {among} the chariots of my people, a noble”

It is difficult to know who is speaking in these two verses, and Bible scholars have different opinions about who is speaking here. Because the author does not say, you should not indicate who is speaking in the text of your translation. However, if you are using section headers, the speaker could be: (1) the man in both verses. If you decide the man is speaking, you can include these two verses under the section heading for 6:4–11. (2) the woman in both verses. If you decide the woman is speaking, you can put a section header at the top of 6:11.

See: When to Keep Information Implicit

Song of Songs 6:12 (#2)

נַפְשִׁ֣י שָׂמַ֑תְנִי

“my soul put me”

The phrase **my soul put me** probably means that the man imagined what follows. If it would be helpful to your readers, you could include this information.

See: Assumed Knowledge and Implicit Information

Song of Songs 6:12 (#1)

לֹ֥א יָדַ֖עְתִּי

“I did not know”

Here the phrase **I did not know** means “Before I realized it” or “Before I was aware.” If it would be helpful to your readers, you could indicate that explicitly. Alternate translation: [Before I realized it] or [Before I was aware]

See: Assumed Knowledge and Implicit Information

Song of Songs 6:12 (#3)

מַרְכְּבוֹת עַמִּי־נָדִיב

“among} the chariots of my people, a noble”

There are many different views among Bible scholars regarding what this phrase means and what this entire verse means. The UST offers one possible interpretation for what this phrase means. See the section on 6:12 in the Chapter 6 introduction for more information about how to translate this difficult verse.

See: Assumed Knowledge and Implicit Information

Song of Songs 6:13 (#1)

שׁוּבִי שׁוּבִי הַשּׁוּלַמִּית שׁוּבִי שׁוּבִי וְנֶחֱזֶה־בָּךְ

“Return, return, Shulammite, return, return and let us look at you”

It is difficult to know with certainty who is saying this. Because the author does not say who is speaking here, you should not indicate a speaker in the text of your translation. However, if you are using section headers, the speaker could be: (1) the young women of Jerusalem. If you decide this is who is speaking, you can indicate that with a section header. (2) friends of the man and woman. If you decide that this is who is speaking, you can place a section header indicating that. (3) the man. If you decide that this is who is speaking here, you can use a section header to indicate that.

See: When to Keep Information Implicit

Song of Songs 6:13 (#3)

שׁוּבִי שׁוּבִי הַשּׁוּלַמִּית שׁוּבִי שׁוּבִי וְנֶחֱזֶה־בָּךְ

“Return, return, Shulammite, return, return and let us look at you”

The man is repeating the verb **return** for emphasis. If your language can repeat words for emphasis, it would be good to do that here. If not, your language may express the emphasis in another way. Alternate translation: [Return Shulammite, return and let us look at you] or [Please return Shulammite, and let us look at you]

See: Reduplication

Song of Songs 6:13 (#4)

מַה־תֶּחֱזוּ בַּשּׁוּלַמִּית כִּמְחֹלַת הַמַּחֲנָיִם

“Why do you look at the Shulammite like the dance of two armies”

It is difficult to know with certainty who is saying this. Because the author does not say who is speaking here, you should not indicate this in the text of your translation. However, if you are using section headers to indicate who is speaking, the speaker could be: (1) the man. If you decide that the man is speaking here, you can indicate this with a section header above this part of the verse. (2) the woman speaking of herself in the third person. If you decide that the woman is speaking here, you can place a section header indicating this.

See: First, Second or Third Person

Song of Songs 6:13 (#6)

כִּמְחֹלַת הַמַּחֲנָיִם

“like the dance of two armies”

This phrase could be translated as: (1) **like the dance of two armies** which refers to a dance that is performed as entertainment for armies. Alternate translation: [like a dance performed before armies]; (2) “like the dance of Mahanaim” (3) “like two rows of dancers” or “like two companies of dancers” and mean “as you like to watch two rows of people dancing.” See the section in the Chapter 6 introduction for more information about how to translate this phrase.

See: Simile

Song of Songs 6:13 (#5)

כִּמְחֹלַת הַמַּחֲנָיִם

“like the dance of two armies”

The speaker is leaving out some of the words that in many languages a sentence would need to be complete. You could supply these words from the context if it would be clearer in your language. Alternate translation: [like you look at the dance of two armies] or [like you would look at the dance of two armies]

See: Ellipsis

Song of Songs 6:13 (#2)

הַשּׁוּלַמִּית & בַּשּׁוּלַמִּית

“Shulammite & at the Shulammite”

The word translated as **Shulammite** refers to someone who is from the town of Shulam. If it would be helpful to your readers, you could include this information. Alternate translation: [woman from Shulam ... at the woman from Shulam]

See: Assumed Knowledge and Implicit Information

Song of Songs - Chapter 7 Introduction

Religious and Cultural Concepts in This Chapter

Beauty
In 7:1–7 the man describes the woman as the epitome of female beauty and attractiveness using various comparisons.

Translation Issues in This Chapter

Comparisons
There are many comparisons in this chapter. Their purpose is to describe the beauty of the woman and to describe romantic love between a man and a woman. (See: Simile) and (See: Metaphor)

An alternate translation possibility for the word the ULT translates as "love" in 7:6
In verse 6 the ULT follows the standard Hebrew text by saying "love." However, as a footnote indicates, many biblical scholars believe that the original reading was more likely "one who is loved." Consider using that reading in your translation. If "one who is loved" is used instead of "love," then the portion of 7:6 that the ULT translates as "love with delights!" would instead be translated as "one who is loved with all your delights!"

An alternate translation possibility for the words that the ULT translates as "the lips of those who sleep" in 7:9
In verse 9 the ULT follows the standard Hebrew text by saying "the lips of those who sleep." However, as a footnote indicates, many biblical scholars believe that the original reading was more likely "lips and teeth." The translators of the Septuagint (the ancient Greek translation of the Old Testament) thought so, and they translated this phrase as "my lips and my teeth." If a Bible translation exists in your region that translates this phrase with the word "teeth" instead of "those who sleep," consider using "lips and teeth" instead of "the lips of those who sleep" in your translation.

Song of Songs 7:1 (#5)

חֲמוּקֵי יְרֵכַיִךְ כְּמוֹ חֲלָאִים מַעֲשֵׂי יְדֵי אָמָן

"The curves of your thighs {are} like ornaments, the work of the hands of a craftsman"

The man is saying that the **curves** of the woman's thighs are like **ornaments** made by a skilled **craftsman** because she is very beautiful. If it would be helpful in your language, you could state that explicitly. Alternate translation: [The curves of your thighs have an attractive shape, like ornaments that are made by the hands of a craftsman] or [The curves of your thighs are beautiful, like the lovely curves of jewels made by a skilled craftsman]

See: Simile

Song of Songs 7:1 (#6)

מַעֲשֵׂי יְדֵי אָמָן

"the work of the hands of a craftsman"

The phrase **the work of the hands of a craftsman** further describes the **ornaments**. Hebrew poetry often used this kind of parallel statement, in which the second line gives additional information. If it would be helpful to your readers, you could connect these two parallel phrases with the words "which are" to show that this phrase is describing the **ornaments** and not introducing something new. Alternate translation: [which are the work of the hands of a craftsman]

See: Parallelism

Song of Songs 7:1 (#4)

בַּת־נָדִיב

"daughter of a noble"

This phrase could: (1) be translated as **daughter of a noble** and refer to the daughter of a nobleman (a man of high social status). Alternate translation: [daughter of a nobleman]; (2) be translated as "noble daughter" and mean that she had noble character. Alternate translation: [noble daughter] or [woman of noble character]

See: Assumed Knowledge and Implicit Information

Song of Songs 7:1 (#1)

מַה־יָּפוּ פְעָמַיִךְ בַּנְּעָלִים בַּת־נָדִיב חַמּוּקֵי יְרֵכַיִךְ כְּמוֹ חֲלָאִים מַעֲשֵׂי יְדֵי אָמָן

"How your feet are beautiful in sandals, daughter of a noble! The curves of your thighs {are} like ornaments, the work of the hands of a craftsman"

If you are using section headers to indicate who is speaking, and you decided in the previous verse that the woman said the words "Why do you look at the Shulammite like the dance of two armies," you will need to place a section header above this verse indicating that the man is now speaking. The man begins speaking directly to the woman in this verse and continues speaking to her until part way through 7:9.

See: When to Keep Information Implicit

Song of Songs 7:1 (#3)

מַה־יָּפוּ פְעָמַיִךְ בַּנְּעָלִים בַּת־נָדִיב

“How your feet are beautiful in sandals, daughter of a noble”

If it would be more natural in your language, you could reverse the order of these phrases. Alternate translation: [Daughter of a noble, how your feet are beautiful in sandals]

See: Information Structure

Song of Songs 7:1 (#7)

מַעֲשֵׂי יְדֵי אָמָּן

“the work of the hands of a craftsman”

The man is using **the hands** to represent all of the **craftsman** in the act of making ornaments. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use an equivalent expression from your culture or state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [the work of a craftsman] or [which a craftsman has made]

See: Synecdoche

Song of Songs 7:1 (#2)

מַה

“How”

How is an exclamation that is emphasizing how **beautiful** the woman’s **feet** are in **sandals**. Use an exclamation that would communicate this meaning in your language.

See: Exclamations

Song of Songs 7:2 (#1)

שָׁרְרֵךְ אַגַּן הַסַּהַר אַל־יֶחְסַר הַמָּזֶג

“Your navel {is} the rounded bowl—that never lacks spiced wine”

The man is speaking of the woman’s shapely **navel** as if it were a **rounded bowl** used for serving wine. The phrase **that never lacks spiced wine** describes what is inside the rounded bowl. It probably means that, as **spiced wine** excites the man and gives him joy, so her navel excites him and gives him joy. If it would be helpful to your readers, you could explain the comparison. Alternate translation: [Your navel is beautifully rounded and causes me to feel excited] or [Your navel is beautifully rounded like a wine bowl, and it causes me to feel excited like drinking spiced wine] or [Your navel is beautifully rounded like a bowl and gives me joy and excitement like when I drink spiced wine]

See: Biblical Imagery — Extended Metaphors

Song of Songs 7:2 (#4)

בִּטְנֵךְ עֲרֵמַת חִטִּים סוּגָה בַּשּׁוֹשַׁנִּים

“Your belly {is} a heap of wheat encircled with the lilies”

The man continues to draw an extended comparison. He compares her **belly** to **a heap of wheat**, a food that satisfies hunger just as the woman satisfies him. The comparison extends to her shape which is soft and curved just like a heap of wheat. He also compares the color of her belly to wheat since a **heap of wheat** is a golden beige or tan color. The phrase **encircled with the lilies** describes the heap of wheat and probably means that, just as **a heap of wheat encircled with the lilies** looks beautiful, so her belly is beautiful. If it would be helpful in your language, you could explain these comparisons. Alternate translation: [Your belly is as beautiful as a heap of wheat that is encircled with lilies, and it satisfies me] or [The shape and color of your belly is beautiful] or [Your belly is beautiful and satisfying]

See: Biblical Imagery — Extended Metaphors

Song of Songs 7:2 (#2)

אַל־יֶחְסַר הַמָּזֶג

“never lacks spiced wine”

The phrase that the ULT translates as **never lacks** could be: (1) an assertion and be translated as modeled by the ULT. (2) a strong wish. Alternate translation: [I hope never lacks spiced wine] or [I hope may never lack spiced wine]

Song of Songs 7:2 (#5)

סוּגָה בַּשּׁוֹשַׁנִּים

“encircled with the lilies”

Alternate translation: [which has lilies all around it]

Song of Songs 7:2 (#3)

הַמָּזֶג

“spiced wine”

The phrase **spiced wine** refers to wine that is mixed with spices. If your readers would not be familiar with this type of wine, you could use the name of something similar in your area, or you could use a more general term. Alternate translation: [wine that people have added spices to]

See: Translate Unknowns

Song of Songs 7:3 (#1)

שְׁנֵי שָׁדַיִךְ כִּשְׁנֵי עֳפָרִים תְּאֲמֵי צְבִיָּה

“Your two breasts {are} like two fawns, twins of a gazelle”

See how you translated the almost identical statement in 4:5.

See: Simile

Song of Songs 7:4 (#1)

צַוָּארֵךְ כְּמִגְדַּל הַשֵּׁשׁ

“Your neck {is} like a tower of ivory”

The man is saying that the woman’s **neck** is like a **tower** that is adorned with **ivory** (not made of ivory) because the woman’s neck is beautiful, tall, and slender. If it would be helpful in your language, you could state that explicitly. Alternate translation: [Your neck is beautiful and slender] or [Your neck is beautiful and tall like a tower that people have adorned with ivory] or [Your neck is lovely and tall like a tower decorated with ivory]

See: Simile

Song of Songs 7:4 (#3)

עֵינַיִךְ בְּרֵכוֹת בְּחֶשְׁבּוֹן עַל־שַׁעַר בַּת־רַבִּים

“Your eyes {are} pools in Heshbon by the gate of Bath Rabbim”

The man is speaking of the woman’s **eyes** as if they were clear **pools** of water in the city of **Heshbon**. The man does not say how the woman’s eyes are like **pools in Heshbon**. It may be that the woman’s eyes sparkle or shine in the light like when light shines on water, that her eyes look mysterious and deep (and possibly dark) like a deep pool of water, or that her eyes reflect light like a pool of water. If it would be helpful in your language, you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [Your eyes shine like the sun reflecting off the pools in Heshbon by the gate of Bath Rabbim] or [Your eyes are deep and mysterious like the pools in Heshbon by the gate of Bath Rabbim]

See: Metaphor

Song of Songs 7:4 (#4)

בְּחֶשְׁבּוֹן

“in Heshbon”

The word **Heshbon** is the name of a city.

See: How to Translate Names

Song of Songs 7:4 (#6)

אַפֵּךְ כְּמִגְדַּל הַלְּבָנוֹן צוֹפֶיָה פְּנֵי דַמָּשֶׂק

“Your nose {is} like the tower of Lebanon, looking {to the} face of Damascus”

The man is saying that the woman’s **nose** is like **the tower of Lebanon** that faces toward the city of **Damascus** because the woman’s nose was high and/or long (attractive in that culture) and beautiful and made her look dignified and impressive like **the tower of Lebanon**. This tower was high and was used as a military watch tower. If it would be helpful to your readers, you could state the meaning explicitly. Alternate translation: [Your nose is beautiful and makes you look dignified] or [Your nose is long and beautiful like the tower in Lebanon that faces Damascus] or [Your nose is high and beautiful like the tower in Lebanon that faces Damascus]

See: Simile

Song of Songs 7:4 (#2)

הַשֵּׁשׁ

“ivory”

See how you translated the term **ivory** in 5:14.

See: Translate Unknowns

Song of Songs 7:4 (#5)

עַל־שַׁעַר בַּת־רַבִּים

“by the gate of Bath Rabbim”

Bath Rabbim is the name of this gate. Alternate translation: [by the gate called Bath Rabbim] or [by the gate that people call Bath Rabbim]

See: How to Translate Names

Song of Songs 7:5 (#2)

כַּכַּרְמֶל

“like Carmel”

Carmel refers to the mountain called Mount Carmel. You could include this information if it would be helpful to your readers.

See: Assumed Knowledge and Implicit Information

Song of Songs 7:5 (#6)

מֶלֶךְ אָסוּר בָּרְהָטִים

“a king is held captive in the tresses”

If your language does not use the passive form in this way, you could express the idea in active form or in another way that is natural in your language. If you must state who did the action, the context implies that the woman's **tresses** did it. Alternate translation: [the tresses hold the king captive] or [your tresses hold the king captive]

See: Active or Passive

Song of Songs 7:5 (#1)

רֹאשֵׁךְ עָלַיִךְ כַּכַּרְמֶל

"Your head on you {is} like Carmel"

The man is saying that the woman's head is beautiful and majestic like Mount **Carmel** and it increases the beauty of the rest of her body. Mount Carmel is a beautiful and majestic looking mountain and adds beauty to what is below it. If it would be helpful to your readers, you could state that explicitly. Alternate translation: [Your head is beautiful and majestic like Mount Carmel]

See: Simile

Song of Songs 7:5 (#5)

מֶלֶךְ אָסוּר

"a king is held captive"

The implication is that the man speaking here is the **king**. You could include this information if it would be helpful to your readers. Alternate translation: [your king is held captive] or [I, your king, am held captive]

See: Assumed Knowledge and Implicit Information

Song of Songs 7:5 (#7)

בָּרְהָטִים

"in the tresses"

Here the writer assumes his readers will understand that **tresses** refers to the woman's hair which hangs down from her head. If it would be helpful to your readers, you could include this information. Alternate translation: [in the long locks of your hair] or [in the flowing locks of your hair]

See: Assumed Knowledge and Implicit Information

Song of Songs 7:5 (#3)

וְדַלַּת רֹאשֵׁךְ כְּאַרְגָּמָן

"and the loose hair of your head {is} like purple"

Here the word **purple** refers to wool cloth that was dyed a purple-red color. The phrase **the loose hair of your head is like purple** could mean: (1) that the woman's hair was a shiny black that reflected a black-purplish color in sunlight. Alternate translation: [and the loose hair of your head is shiny and black] or [and the loose hair of your head looks shiny purplish black as the sun shines on it]; (2) that the woman's hair made her look like a queen (purple was associated with royalty). Alternate translation: [and the loose hair of your head is like royal cloth]

See: Simile

Song of Songs 7:5 (#4)

מֶלֶךְ אָסוּר בָּרְהָטִים

"a king is held captive in the tresses"

The man is speaking of the beauty of the **tresses** of the woman's hair as if they could capture **a king** because the woman's tresses are so beautiful that they captivate his attention. If it would be helpful in your language, you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [Your tresses are so beautiful that a king is not able to stop admiring them] or [Your hair is so beautiful that a king is not able to stop admiring it] or [the king is captivated by your tresses]

See: Metaphor

Song of Songs 7:6 (#2)

מַה־יָּפִית וּמַה־נָּעַמְתְּ

"How you are beautiful and how you are lovely"

This is an exclamation that is emphasizing the beauty and loveliness of the woman. Use an exclamation that would communicate that meaning in your language.

See: Exclamations

Song of Songs 7:6 (#3)

אַהֲבָה

"love"

See the introduction to this chapter for information regarding an alternate translation of the word **love**.

Song of Songs 7:6 (#5)

אַהֲבָה בַּתַּעֲנוּגִים

"love with delights"

If your language does not use an abstract noun for the idea of **love**, you could express the same idea in another way.

See: Abstract Nouns

Song of Songs 7:6 (#1)

מַה־יָּפִית

“How you are beautiful”

See how you translated the similar phrase “You are beautiful” in 6:4.

See: Exclamations

Song of Songs 7:6 (#4)

אַהֲבָה בַּתַּעֲנוּגִים

“love with delights”

The man is praising the delightfulness of romantic love. If it would be helpful to your readers, you could include this information. Alternate translation: [romantic love has many delights] or [how delightful romantic love is] or [romantic love is very delightful]

See: Assumed Knowledge and Implicit Information

Song of Songs 7:7 (#1)

זֹאת קוֹמָתֵךְ דָּמְתָה לְתָמָר

“This is your height—it is like a palm tree”

The man is saying that the woman is tall like a **palm tree**. If it would be helpful in your language, you could state that explicitly. Alternate translation: [You are tall]

See: Simile

Song of Songs 7:7 (#2)

לְתָמָר & לְאַשְׁכֹּלוֹת

“a palm tree & like its} clusters”

A **palm tree** refers to a date palm, which is tall, thin, and produces small fruits called dates. The term **clusters** refers to bunches of dates that grow on the date palm. If your readers would not be familiar with this type of tree or its fruit, you could use the name of something similar in your area, or you could use a more general term. Alternate translation: [a tall and slender fruit tree ... its clusters of fruit] or [a tall fruit tree ... like its clusters of delicious fruit]

See: Translate Unknowns

Song of Songs 7:7 (#3)

וְשָׁדַיִךְ לְאַשְׁכֹּלוֹת

“and your breasts {like its} clusters”

The man is saying that the woman’s **breasts** are like the **clusters** of plump dates that grow on date palms. If it would be helpful in your language, you could state that explicitly. Alternate translation: [and your breasts are plump and round] or [and your breasts are plump and round like its clusters]

See: Simile

Song of Songs 7:8 (#2)

אָמַרְתִּי

“I said”

Here the phrase **I said** means that the man said or thought to himself, **I will go up the palm tree; I will grab hold of its fruit stalks**. You could include this information if it would be helpful to your readers. Alternate translation: [I thought to myself]

See: Assumed Knowledge and Implicit Information

Song of Songs 7:8 (#3)

בְתָמָר

“the} palm tree”

See how you translated **palm tree** in the previous verse.

See: Translate Unknowns

Song of Songs 7:8 (#5)

אֶעֱלֶה

“I will go up”

Your language may say “come” rather than **go** in a context such as this. Alternate translation: [I will come up]

See: Go and Come

Song of Songs 7:8 (#6)

וְיִהְיוּ־נָא שָׁדַיִךְ כְּאֶשְׁכְּלוֹת הַגֶּפֶן וְרֵיחַ אַפֵּךְ כַּתַּפּוּחִים

“And, please, let your breasts be like the clusters of the vine, and {let the} smell of your nose {be} like apples”

The phrases **let your breasts be like the clusters of the vine** and **let the smell of your nose be like apples** are both comparisons. If it would be helpful in your language, you could state that explicitly. Alternate translation: [And, please, let your breasts be sweet and enjoyable like the clusters of the vine, and let the smell of your breath be pleasant like the pleasant smell of apples]

See: Simile

Song of Songs 7:8 (#7)

וְיִהְיוּ־נָ֨א שָׁדַ֜יִךְ & וְרֵ֣יחַ

“And, please, let your breasts be & and {let the} smell of”

The man is expressing a wish or desire. You could include this information if it would be helpful to your readers. Alternate translation: [And, please, may your breasts be … and may the smell of]

See: Assumed Knowledge and Implicit Information

Song of Songs 7:8 (#10)

וְרֵ֣יחַ

“and {let the} smell of”

The man is leaving out some of the words that in many languages a sentence would need to be complete. You could supply the words “let the” if it would be clearer in your language.

See: Ellipsis

Song of Songs 7:8 (#8)

כְּאֶ֥שְׁכֹּל֖וֹת הַגֶּֽפֶן

“like the clusters of the vine”

The phrase **like the clusters of the vine** refers to clusters of grapes that grow on grapevines. If it would be helpful to your readers, you could include this information. Alternate translation: [like the clusters of the grapevine]

See: Assumed Knowledge and Implicit Information

Song of Songs 7:8 (#11)

כַּתַּפּוּחִ֑ים

“be} like apples”

An apple is a round hard fruit that has a sweet taste and a pleasant smell. If your readers would not be familiar with this type of fruit, you could use the name of something similar in your area, or you could use a more general term. Alternate translation: [be like sweet fruit] or [be like fragrant fruit] or [be like fruit]

See: Translate Unknowns

Song of Songs 7:8 (#4)

אֶֽעֱלֶ֣ה בְתָמָ֔ר אֹֽחֲזָ֖ה בְּסַנְסִנָּ֑יו

“I will go up {the} palm tree; I will grab hold of its fruit stalks”

The man is using a future statement to indicate his intent or desire to do something. If it would be helpful in your language, you could translate these words using a command or instruction form. Alternate translation: [I want to go up the palm tree; I want to grab hold of its fruit stalks] or [I have determined to go up the palm tree and grab hold of its fruit stalks]

See: Statements — Other Uses

Song of Songs 7:8 (#9)

וְרֵ֣יחַ אַפֵּ֔ךְ כַּתַּפּוּחִ֑ים

“and {let the} smell of your nose {be} like apples”

Here, **nose** represents breath. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use an equivalent expression from your language or state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [and let the smell of your breath be like apples] or [and let the smell of the breath coming from your nose be like apples]

See: Metonymy

Song of Songs 7:8 (#1)

אָמַ֣רְתִּי֮ אֶֽעֱלֶ֣ה בְתָמָ֔ר אֹֽחֲזָ֖ה בְּסַנְסִנָּ֑יו

“I said, “I will go up {the} palm tree; I will grab hold of its fruit stalks”

Here the man is speaking of the woman as if she were **the palm tree** and her breasts as if they were **fruit stalks**. The man speaks of his desire to caress and be intimate with her by saying **I will grab hold of its fruit stalks**. If it would be helpful in your language, you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [I will go to the woman I love and caress her breasts and enjoy being intimate with her] or [I will go to the woman I love and enjoy touching her breasts and being close to her]

See: Metaphor

Song of Songs 7:9 (#1)

וְחִכֵּ֖ךְ כְּיֵ֣ין הַטּ֑וֹב הוֹלֵ֤ךְ לְדוֹדִי֙ לְמֵישָׁרִ֔ים דּוֹבֵ֖ב שִׂפְתֵ֥י יְשֵׁנִֽים

“and {let} your mouth {be} like the best wine. Going down for my beloved smoothly, gliding over the lips of those who sleep”

The man is saying that the woman’s kisses (**mouth**) are like **wine** because both are pleasant tasting and have a powerful effect on the body. The woman continues this comparison. If it would be helpful in your language, you could state that explicitly. Alternate translation: [and let your mouth be pleasant tasting and intoxicating like the best wine. May my mouth be

like pleasant and intoxicating wine which goes down to my beloved smoothly, gliding over the lips of those who sleep]

See: Simile

Song of Songs 7:9 (#2)

וְחִכֵּךָ֖

“and {let} your mouth {be”

The man is expressing a wish or desire. If it would be helpful to your readers, you could include this information. Alternate translation: [and may your mouth be]

See: Statements — Other Uses

Song of Songs 7:9 (#5)

הוֹלֵ֣ךְ לְדוֹדִ֔י לְמֵישָׁרִ֑ים

“Going down for my beloved smoothly”

Your language may say “Coming” rather than **Going** in a context such as this. Alternate translation: [Coming down for my beloved smoothly]

See: Go and Come

Song of Songs 7:9 (#8)

שִׂפְתֵ֥י יְשֵׁנִֽים

“the lips of those who sleep”

See the Chapter 7 introduction for information regarding an alternate translation of the words that the ULT translates as **the lips of those who sleep**.

Song of Songs 7:9 (#7)

לְמֵישָׁרִ֑ים דּוֹבֵ֖ב

“smoothly, gliding over”

Here the word **smoothly** means “freely” and refers to freely flowing wine. The word **gliding** here means “flowing.” If it would be helpful to your readers, you could include this information. Alternate translation: [freely, flowing over]

See: Assumed Knowledge and Implicit Information

Song of Songs 7:9 (#6)

הוֹלֵ֣ךְ לְדוֹדִ֔י לְמֵישָׁרִ֑ים דּוֹבֵ֖ב שִׂפְתֵ֥י יְשֵׁנִֽים

“Going down for my beloved smoothly, gliding over the lips of those who sleep”

Going down and **gliding** both refer to the wine mentioned earlier in the verse. If it would be helpful to your readers, you could include this information. Alternate translation: [Wine, which is going down to my beloved smoothly, gliding over the lips of those who sleep] or [Wine, which is going down to my beloved smoothly; wine, which is gliding over the lips of those who sleep]

See: Assumed Knowledge and Implicit Information

Song of Songs 7:9 (#4)

הוֹלֵ֣ךְ לְדוֹדִ֔י לְמֵישָׁרִ֑ים דּוֹבֵ֖ב שִׂפְתֵ֥י יְשֵׁנִֽים

“Going down for my beloved smoothly, gliding over the lips of those who sleep”

Some Bible scholars think the speaker in this part of the verse: (1) is the woman. Because the author does not say who is speaking here, you should not indicate the speaker explicitly in the text. However, if you are using section headers, you can indicate that the woman is now speaking. (2) continues to be the man. If you decide that the man is still speaking, you do not need a header above this portion, but if you are using headers, you will need a header above the next verse indicating that the woman is speaking (since Bible scholars agree that the speaker is the woman beginning in 7:10 and continuing through at least 8:3).

See: When to Keep Information Implicit

Song of Songs 7:9 (#3)

וְחִכֵּךָ֖

“and {let} your mouth {be”

Here, **mouth** represents the kisses which come from the woman’s mouth. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use an equivalent expression from your language or state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [and let your kisses be]

See: Metonymy

Song of Songs 7:10 (#1)

אֲנִ֥י לְדוֹדִ֖י

“I {belong} to my beloved”

See how you translated the identical phrase in Song of Songs 6:3.

Song of Songs 7:11 (#1)

לְכָ֥ה

“Come”

Your language may say “Go” rather than **Come** in a context such as this. Alternate translation: [Go]

See: Go and Come

Song of Songs 7:11 (#4)

בַּכְּפָרִים

“in the villages”

The word which the ULT translates as **in the villages** has two possible meanings in the original language. Here it could mean: (1) **in the villages** as in the ULT. (2) “among the henna bushes” (which produce flowers). If you choose this option, see how you translated the phrase “henna blossoms” in 1:14. Alternate translation: [among the henna bushes] or [among the wildflowers] or [among the henna blossoms]

See: Translate Unknowns

Song of Songs 7:11 (#3)

נָלִינָה בַּכְּפָרִים

“let us spend the night in the villages”

Alternate translation: [and let us stay overnight in a village somewhere]

Song of Songs 7:11 (#2)

לְכָה דוֹדִי

“Come, my beloved”

If it would be more natural in your language, you could change the order of these phrases. Alternate translation: [My beloved, come]

See: Information Structure

Song of Songs 7:12 (#2)

נַשְׁכִּימָה

“Let us go early”

Your language may say “come” rather than **go** in a context such as this. Alternate translation: [Let us come early]

See: Go and Come

Song of Songs 7:12 (#5)

אֶתֵּן אֶת־דֹּדַי לָךְ

“I will give my love to you”

If your language does not use an abstract noun for the idea of **love**, you could express the same idea in another way as modeled by the UST.

See: Abstract Nouns

Song of Songs 7:12 (#1)

נַשְׁכִּימָה

“Let us go early”

Alternate translation: [Let us wake up early and go] or [Let us get up early and go]

Song of Songs 7:12 (#3)

פָּרְחָה הַגֶּפֶן

“the vine has budded”

See how you translated the similar phrase “had the vine budded” in 6:11.

Song of Songs 7:12 (#4)

הֵנֵצוּ הָרִמּוֹנִים

“if} the pomegranates have bloomed”

See how you translated the similar phrase “Had the pomegranates bloomed” in 6:11.

Song of Songs 7:13 (#1)

הַדּוּדָאִים נָתְנוּ־רֵיחַ

“The mandrakes give off a scent”

The **mandrakes** are plants which produce pleasant-smelling flowers. People in that culture thought that smelling or eating fruit from the mandrake plant would arouse a person’s sexual desire and would help women to conceive children. If your readers would not be familiar with this type of plant, you could use the name of a similar plant in your area, or you could use a more general term. Alternate translation: [The love flowers give off their scent] or [The scent of the love flowers is in the air]

See: Translate Unknowns

Song of Songs 7:13 (#2)

וְעַל־פְּתָחֵינוּ כָּל־מְגָדִים חֲדָשִׁים גַּם־יְשָׁנִים דּוֹדִי צָפַנְתִּי לָךְ

“and over our doors {are} all choice fruits, new ones and also old ones. My beloved, I have stored {these} up for you”

Here the woman is speaking of her love for the man as if it were **all choice fruits** that she has **stored up** (reserved) for him. She also speaks of the pleasure they will enjoy together when they express their love as **all choice fruits** stored **over our doors**. (In that culture fruit was often kept on a shelf above doors). If it would be helpful in your language, you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [and we are surrounded by delightful pleasures, new ones and old ones, pleasures that I have been saving to give to you, my beloved]

See: Metaphor

Song of Songs 7:13 (#4)

חֲדָשִׁים גַּם־יְשָׁנִים

“new ones and also old ones”

Here, **new ones and also old ones** is an idiom which means “all kinds of fruit.” **New ones** refers to fruit which is not yet ripe and **old ones** refers to ripe fruit. If this phrase does not have that meaning in your language, you could use a comparable expression from your language that does have that meaning or state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [fruit that is not yet ripe and also sweet ripe fruit] or [all kinds of fruit]

See: Idiom

Song of Songs 7:13 (#3)

וְעַל־פְּתָחֵינוּ כָּל־מְגָדִים

“and over our doors {are} all choice fruits”

Alternate translation: [and above the entrance of our house are every one of the best fruits]

Song of Songs 7:13 (#5)

דּוֹדִי צָפַנְתִּי לָךְ

“My beloved, I have stored {these} up for you”

Alternate translation: [My beloved, I have saved these so that I can give them to you] or [My beloved, I have saved my love so that I can give it to you]

Song of Songs - Chapter 8 Introduction

Religious and Cultural Concepts in This Chapter

Strong feelings of love and commitment between a man and woman who love each other romantically
8:6–7 describe the strong feelings of love, commitment, and emotional attachment that exist between a man and woman who love each other romantically.

Translation Issues in This Chapter

The meaning of 8:12
The three possible meanings of 8:12 are: (1) that the woman is speaking of herself as a vineyard and saying that her vineyard is hers alone. She is comparing herself to Solomon’s vineyard (discussed in 8:11) and saying that Solomon and his vineyard keepers can keep the profits from that vineyard. (2) that the woman is speaking of herself as a vineyard but saying that she chooses to give herself freely to the man whom she loves and calls Solomon. (3) that the man is speaking of the woman he loves as a vineyard and is comparing his vineyard to Solomon’s vineyard. He feels wealthier than Solomon because he has the woman he loves as his vineyard, and so Solomon and Solomon’s keepers can keep their portion of the profits from that vineyard.

Song of Songs 8:1 (#2)

מִמַּי יִתֶּנְךָ כְּאָח לִי יוֹנֵק שְׁדֵי אִמִּי

“Who will give you like a brother to me, who nursed at the breasts of my mother”

The woman is referring implicitly to cultural norms which prohibited a display of public affection toward a spouse and/or a romantic partner but allowed siblings to show affection in public. If it would be helpful in your language, you could include this information in a footnote.

See: Assumed Knowledge and Implicit Information

Song of Songs 8:1 (#1)

מִמַּי יִתֶּנְךָ כְּאָח לִי יוֹנֵק שְׁדֵי אִמִּי

“Who will give you like a brother to me, who nursed at the breasts of my mother”

Here the woman is using the Hebrew idiom **Who will give you** to express her wish that the man she loves be **like a brother** to her (so that she could publicly kiss him). If this phrase does not have that meaning in your language, you could use a comparable expression from your language that does have that meaning, or you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [How I wish that you were like a brother to me, who nursed at the breasts of my mother] or [How I desire that you were like a brother to me, who nursed at the breasts of my mother]

See: Idiom

Song of Songs 8:1 (#4)

גַּם

“Yes”

Here the word **Yes** is used to strongly affirm what follows it in this sentence. Use a natural form that would communicate that meaning in your language.

See: Assumed Knowledge and Implicit Information

Song of Songs 8:1 (#3)

מִמַּי יִתֶּנְךָ כְּאָח לִי יוֹנֵק שְׁדֵי אִמִּי

“Who will give you like a brother to me, who nursed at the breasts of my mother”

The phrase **who nursed at the breasts of my mother** describes the word **brother** and has a similar meaning. This is poetic language. Saying the same thing in slightly different ways is a common feature of Hebrew poetry. If your language has a way to indicate poetry, you could use it here. Alternate translation: [Who will give you like a brother to me]

See: Poetry

Song of Songs 8:1 (#5)

לֹא־יָבֻזוּ לִי

“they would not despise me”

The woman is saying that if the man she loved were **like a brother** and she found him **outside** and kissed him, the result is that **they would not despise me**. Use a natural form in your language for expressing a statement like this. Alternate translation: [then they would not despise me]

See: Connect — Reason-and-Result Relationship

Song of Songs 8:1–2 (#1)

אֶמְצָאֲךָ בַחוּץ אֶשָּׁקְךָ גַּם לֹא־יָבֻזוּ לִי: אֱנָהֲגְךָ אֲבִיאֲךָ אֶל־בֵּית אִמִּי תְלַמְּדֵנִי אַשְׁקְךָ מִיַּיִן הָרֶקַח מֵעֲסִיס רִמֹּנִי

“If I found you outside, I would kiss you. Yes, they would not despise me.I would lead you; I would bring you to the house of my mother, she {who} taught me. I would make you drink from the wine of spice, from the juice of my pomegranate”

The woman is using a hypothetical situation (the situation of the man being **like a brother** and her finding him **outside**) to express what she would do if the man she loved were like a brother to her. Alternate translation: [If you were like a brother to me and if I found you outside, then I would kiss you. Yes, if you were like a brother to me, they would not despise me. If you were like a brother to me, then I would lead you; I would bring you to the house of my mother who taught me, and I would make you drink from the wine of spice, from the juice of my pomegranate]

See: Connect — Hypothetical Conditions

Song of Songs 8:2 (#1)

אֲבִיאֲךָ אֶל־בֵּית אִמִּי

“I would bring you to the house of my mother”

See how you translated the similar phrase **I had brought him to the house of my mother** in 3:4. Alternate translation: [I would take you to the house of my mother]

See: Go and Come

Song of Songs 8:2 (#6)

מֵעֲסִיס רִמֹּנִי

“from the juice of my pomegranate”

Here the term the ULT translates as **juice** refers to fresh new wine that is sweet. If it would be helpful to your readers, you could include this information. Alternate translation: [from my fresh pomegranate wine] or [from my sweet pomegranate wine]

See: Assumed Knowledge and Implicit Information

Song of Songs 8:2 (#2)

אֲבִיאֲךָ אֶל־בֵּית אִמִּי תְלַמְּדֵנִי

“I would bring you to the house of my mother, she {who} taught me”

Alternate translation: [I would bring you to the house of my mother who taught me]

Song of Songs 8:2 (#3)

אַשְׁקְךָ מִיַּיִן הָרֶקַח

“I would make you drink from the wine of spice”

The phrase **I would make you drink from the wine of spice** means “I would cause you to drink (by giving you) spiced wine.” If it would be helpful to your readers, you could include that information. Alternate translation: [I would cause you to drink spiced wine] or [I would give you spiced wine to drink]

See: Assumed Knowledge and Implicit Information

Song of Songs 8:2 (#5)

אַשְׁקְךָ מִיַּיִן הָרֶקַח מֵעֲסִיס רִמֹּנִי

“I would make you drink from the wine of spice, from the juice of my pomegranate”

The woman is politely and poetically referring to giving herself sexually to the man by using the phrase **I would make you drink from the wine of spice** and drink **from the juice of my pomegranate**. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use a polite way of referring to this in your language, or you could state this plainly. Alternate translation: [I will give myself to you as if I were making you drink from the wine of spice and pomegranate juice] or [I will give myself to you as if I were giving you spiced wine to drink and giving you pomegranate juice to enjoy]

See: Euphemism

Song of Songs 8:2 (#4)

מִיַּ֣יִן הָרֶ֔קַח

“from the wine of spice”

See how you translated the similar phrase “spiced wine” in 7:2.

See: Translate Unknowns

Song of Songs 8:3 (#1)

שְׂמֹאלוֹ֙ תַּ֣חַת רֹאשִׁ֔י וִֽימִינ֖וֹ תְּחַבְּקֵֽנִי

“His left hand {is} under my head and his right hand embraces me”

This verse is identical to Song of Songs 2:6. Translate this verse exactly as you translated 2:6.

See: Assumed Knowledge and Implicit Information

Song of Songs 8:4 (#1)

הִשְׁבַּ֙עְתִּי֙ אֶתְכֶ֣ם בְּנ֣וֹת יְרוּשָׁלִַ֔ם מַה־תָּעִ֥ירוּ ׀ וּמַה־תְּעֹרְרָ֖ו אֶת־הָאַהֲבָ֑ה עַ֥ד שֶׁתֶּחְפָּֽץ

“I adjure you, daughters of Jerusalem, do not awaken and do not stir love until it desires”

You should translate this verse in a similar way to how you translated Song of Songs 2:7, but because this verse does not have the phrase “by the female gazelles or the does of the field,” you should not include that phrase in this verse.

See: Oath Formulas

Song of Songs 8:5 (#2)

מִ֣י זֹ֔את עֹלָ֖ה מִן־הַמִּדְבָּ֑ר מִתְרַפֶּ֖קֶת עַל־דּוֹדָֽהּ

“Who {is} that coming up from the wilderness, leaning against her beloved”

The writer is using the question form, **Who is that**, to create a sense of expectation and interest. If you would not use the question form for this purpose in your language, you could translate these words as a statement or an exclamation.

See: Rhetorical Question

Song of Songs 8:5 (#3)

עֹלָ֖ה

“coming up”

The writer assumes that his readers understand that the group of people **coming up from the wilderness** to Jerusalem must travel upward because the wilderness is low in the Jordan valley and Jerusalem is built on hills. You could include this information if it would be helpful to your readers. Alternate translation: [moving upward] or [arising]

See: Assumed Knowledge and Implicit Information

Song of Songs 8:5 (#6)

חִבְּלַ֥תְךָ

“was in labor {with} you”

The phrase the ULT translates as **was in labor with you** could: (1) refer to the process of a mother being in labor and be translated as the ULT models. (2) refer to the act of conception. Alternate translation: [conceived you]

Song of Songs 8:5 (#5)

הַתַּפּ֑וּחַ

“the apple tree”

See how you translated the phrase **apple tree** in 2:3.

See: Translate Unknowns

Song of Songs 8:5 (#4)

עֹלָ֖ה

“coming up”

Your language may say “going” rather than **coming** in a context such as this. Use whichever is more natural. Alternate translation: [going up]

See: Go and Come

Song of Songs 8:5 (#1)

מִ֣י זֹ֔את עֹלָ֖ה מִן־הַמִּדְבָּ֑ר מִתְרַפֶּ֖קֶת עַל־דּוֹדָֽהּ

“Who {is} that coming up from the wilderness, leaning against her beloved”

The author does not say who is speaking here so you should not indicate who you think is speaking explicitly in the text of your translation. However, if you are using section headers to indicate who is speaking, the speakers here are most likely the “daughters of Jerusalem” who spoke several times earlier in the book and who were addressed in the previous verse.

See: When to Keep Information Implicit

Song of Songs 8:5–7 (#1)

תַּ֣חַת הַתַּפּ֔וּחַ עוֹרַרְתִּ֖יךָ שָׁ֣שָׁה חִבְּלַ֑תְךָ אִמֶּ֥ךָ שָׁ֖שָׁמָּה חִבְּלָ֥ה יְלָדַֽתְךָ׃ שִׂימֵ֨נִי֙ כַּחוֹתָ֣ם עַל־לִבֶּ֔ךָ כַּחוֹתָ֖ם עַל־זְרוֹעֶ֑ךָ כִּֽי־עַזָּ֤ה

כַּמָּוֶת֙ אַהֲבָ֔ה קָשָׁ֖ה כִּשְׁאוֹל֙ קִנְאָ֔ה רְשָׁפֶ֖יהָ רִשְׁפֵּ֣י אֵ֑שׁ שַׁלְהֶ֖בֶתְיָֽהּ׃ מַ֣יִם רַבִּ֗ים לֹ֤א יוּכְלוּ֙ לְכַבּ֣וֹת אֶת־הָאַהֲבָ֔ה וּנְהָר֖וֹת לֹ֣א יִשְׁטְפ֑וּהָ אִם־יִתֵּ֨ן אִ֤ישׁ אֶת־כֹּל־הׇ֙וֹן֙ בֵּיתֹ֔ו בָּאַהֲבָ֖ה בּ֥וֹז יָבֻ֖וזּוּ לֽוֹ׃

“Under the apple tree I awakened you; there your mother was in labor {with} you; there she was in labor; she gave birth {to} you.Place me like the seal on your heart, like the seal on your arm, because strong like death {is} love; unyielding like Sheol {is} zeal. Its flashes {are} flashes of fire, the flame of Yah.Many waters are not able to quench {this} love and rivers will not drown it. If a man would give all {the} wealth of his house in exchange for love, they would utterly despise it”

The author does not say who is speaking here so you should not indicate who you think is speaking in the text of your translation. However, if you are using section headers to indicate who is speaking, you can place a header above this section indicating who the speaker is. Here the speaker could be: (1) the woman. (2) The man.

See: When to Keep Information Implicit

Song of Songs 8:6 (#1)

שִׂימֵ֨נִי כַחוֹתָ֜ם עַל־לִבֶּ֗ךָ

“Place me like the seal on your heart”

Here, **heart** could represent: (1) the chest of a person. Alternate translation: [Place me like a seal that is hung by a cord around your neck and hangs down onto your chest]; (2) the emotions and thoughts of a person. Alternate translation: [Always love and think about me] or [Always love and think about me as if I were stamped onto your heart] If it would be helpful in your language, you could use an equivalent expression from your language, or you could state the meaning plainly.

See: Metonymy

Song of Songs 8:6 (#2)

שִׂימֵ֨נִי כַחוֹתָ֜ם עַל־לִבֶּ֗ךָ כַּחוֹתָ֙ם֙ עַל־זְרוֹעֶ֔ךָ

“Place me like the seal on your heart, like the seal on your arm”

The woman is saying that she wants the man she loves to be close to her **like the seal** hanging from a cord around his neck down over his **heart** (chest) and like a **seal** that is worn on his **arm**. If it would be helpful in your language, you could state that explicitly. Alternate translation: [Please keep me very near to you]

See: Simile

Song of Songs 8:6 (#5)

עַזָּ֥ה כַמָּ֖וֶת אַהֲבָ֑ה קָשָׁ֥ה כִשְׁאוֹל֙ קִנְאָ֔ה

“strong like death {is} love; unyielding like Sheol {is} zeal”

The phrases **strong like death is love** and **unyielding like Sheol is zeal** are comparisons because romantic **love** and **death** are both very strong and overcome a person in a powerful and irresistible way, while **Sheol** and the **zeal** of romantic love are both **unyielding**. If it would be helpful in your language, you could state that explicitly.

See: Simile

Song of Songs 8:6 (#6)

כִּֽי־עַזָּ֥ה כַמָּ֖וֶת אַהֲבָ֑ה

“because strong like death {is} love”

If your language does not use an abstract noun for the idea of **love**, you could express the same idea in another way that is natural in your language.

See: Abstract Nouns

Song of Songs 8:6 (#8)

קָשָׁ֥ה כִשְׁאוֹל֙ קִנְאָ֔ה

“unyielding like Sheol {is} zeal”

If your language does not use an abstract noun for the idea of **zeal**, you could express the same idea in another way. Alternate translation: [lovers zealously love each other in a way that is unyielding like Sheol] or [lovers passionately love each other in a way that is unyielding like Sheol]

See: Abstract Nouns

Song of Songs 8:6 (#11)

שַׁלְהֶ֖בֶתְיָֽהּ

“the flame of Yah”

Here, **the flame of Yah** is an expression that means “lightning.” If this phrase does not have that meaning in your language, you could use a comparable expression from your language that does have that meaning or state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [the lightning of Yah] or [the flashes of lightning]

See: Idiom

Song of Songs 8:6 (#7)

קָשָׁ֥ה כִשְׁאוֹל֙ קִנְאָ֔ה

“unyielding like Sheol {is} zeal”

Here the word the ULT translates as **zeal** could: (1) have the positive meaning of the romantic fervor that lovers have for one another. Alternate translation: [unyielding like Sheol is the zeal lovers have for each other] or [the passionate feelings lovers have for one another is unyielding like Sheol]; (2) refer to the negative feelings of lovers who are jealous for the affection, love, and attention of the other. Alternate translation: [unyielding like Sheol is jealousy] or [the jealousy lovers have for the love of one another is unyielding like Sheol]

Song of Songs 8:6 (#3)

כָּחוֹתָם֙ עַל־זְרוֹעֶ֔ךָ

“like the seal on your arm”

The word which the ULT translates as **arm** can refer to any part of the arm, including the wrist and hand. The phrase **the seal on your arm** refers to a seal that is worn on a bracelet on the wrist. If it would be helpful to your readers, you could include this information. Alternate translation: [like a seal worn on your wrist] or [like a seal worn on a bracelet on your wrist]

See: Assumed Knowledge and Implicit Information

Song of Songs 8:6 (#10)

רִשְׁפֶּ֥יהָ רִשְׁפֵּי־אֵ֖שׁ שַׁלְהֶ֥בֶתְיָֽהּ

“Its flashes {are} flashes of fire, the flame of Yah”

Here the woman is speaking of the zeal of romantic love as if it were **flashes of fire** and **the flame of Yah**. If it would be helpful in your language, you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [The zeal of lovers is like flashes of fire and like the flame of Yahweh] or [The passion of lovers is like flashes of fire and like the flame of Yahweh]

See: Metaphor

Song of Songs 8:6 (#9)

כִּשְׁאוֹל֙

“like Sheol”

Here, **Sheol** represents **death**. This line is parallel in meaning to the preceding line. The woman is again referring to **death** by association with **Sheol**, which is where dead people were thought to go in that culture. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use an equivalent expression from your language or state the meaning plainly.

See: Metonymy

Song of Songs 8:6 (#4)

כָּחוֹתָם֙ עַל־זְרוֹעֶ֔ךָ

“like the seal on your arm”

The speaker is leaving out some of the words that in many languages a sentence would need in order to be complete. If it would be clearer in your language, you could supply these words from earlier in the sentence. Alternate translation: [place me like the seal on your arm]

See: Ellipsis

Song of Songs 8:7 (#3)

אֶת־הָאַהֲבָ֔ה & בָּאַהֲבָ֖ה

“this} love & in exchange for love”

If your language does not use an abstract noun for the idea of **love**, you could express the same idea in some other way that is natural in your language.

See: Abstract Nouns

Song of Songs 8:7 (#4)

אִם־יִתֵּ֨ן אִ֤ישׁ אֶת־כָּל־הׇ֙ון בֵּיתוֹ֙ בָּאַהֲבָ֔ה בּ֥וֹז יָבֻ֖זוּ לֽוֹ

“If a man would give all {the} wealth of his house in exchange for love, they would utterly despise it”

The woman speaks as if this were a hypothetical situation, but she means that it must be true. If your language does not state something as a condition if it is certain or true, and if your readers might think that what the woman is saying is uncertain, then you could translate her words as an affirmative statement. Alternate translation: [Even though a man tries to give all the wealth of his house in exchange for love, his offer will be utterly despised]

See: Connect — Factual Conditions

Song of Songs 8:7 (#5)

בָּאַהֲבָ֔ה

“in exchange for love”

Alternate translation: [in order to get love] or [in order to buy love]

Song of Songs 8:7 (#2)

מַ֣יִם רַבִּ֗ים לֹ֤א יוּכְלוּ֙ לְכַבּ֣וֹת אֶת־הָאַהֲבָ֔ה וּנְהָר֖וֹת לֹ֣א יִשְׁטְפֻ֑והָ

“Many waters are not able to quench {this} love and rivers will not drown it”

Alternate translation: [Nothing can extinguish our love for each other, not even a flood]

Song of Songs 8:7 (#1)

מַ֣יִם רַבִּ֗ים לֹ֤א יוּכְלוּ֙ לְכַבּ֣וֹת אֶת־הָאַהֲבָ֔ה וּנְהָר֖וֹת לֹ֣א יִשְׁטְפ֑וּהָ

“Many waters are not able to quench {this} love and rivers will not drown it”

Here the writer is speaking of **love** as if it is a strongly burning fire which **Many waters** cannot **quench** and which **rivers** cannot **drown**. If it would be helpful in your language, you could state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [Love is so strong that it is like a strong fire that great amounts of water cannot quench and which rivers full of water cannot put out] or [The feelings of love which a man and a woman who are lovers have for each other is very strong] or [Nothing can stop romantic love]

See: Metaphor

Song of Songs 8:7 (#6)

לוֹ

“it”

The word the ULT translates as **it** could: (1) refer to **all the wealth of his house**. Alternate translation: [it]; (2) refer to the **man** who is offering **all the wealth of his house in exchange for love**. Alternate translation: [him]

See: Assumed Knowledge and Implicit Information

Song of Songs 8:8 (#3)

בַּיּ֖וֹם

“on the day”

Here, **on the day** is an expression that means “at the time.” If this phrase does not have that meaning in your language, you could use a comparable expression that does have that meaning or state the meaning plainly.

See: Idiom

Song of Songs 8:8 (#4)

בַּיּ֖וֹם שֶׁיְּדֻבַּר־בָּֽהּ

“on the day when it is spoken for her”

The phrase **on the day when it is spoken for her** means “at the time when she is betrothed to be married.” If it would be helpful to your readers, you could include this information. Alternate translation: [on the day when she is pledged to be married] or [on the day when she is spoken for in marriage]

See: Assumed Knowledge and Implicit Information

Song of Songs 8:8 (#5)

שֶׁיְּדֻבַּר־בָּֽהּ

“when it is spoken for her”

If your language does not use the passive form in this way, you can express the idea in active form or in another way that is natural in your language. If you must state who did the action, the context implies that the brothers are the ones who will do it. Alternate translation: [when we speak for her by promising a man that he can marry her]

See: Active or Passive

Song of Songs 8:8 (#1)

קְטַנָּ֔ה

“a little one”

Here the phrase **a little one** means “a young one” or “a younger one.” If it would be helpful to your readers, you could include this information. Alternate translation: [a young one] or [a younger one]

See: Assumed Knowledge and Implicit Information

Song of Songs 8:8 (#2)

וְשָׁדַ֖יִם אֵ֥ין לָ֑הּ

“and breasts there are not for her”

The phrase **and breasts there are not for her** is an expression that means the woman’s brothers think she has not reached full physical maturity and is therefore not yet ready for marriage. If this phrase does not have that meaning in your language, you could use a comparable expression that does have that meaning or state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [and she is not yet fully grown] or [and her breasts are still small] or [and she is not yet ready for marriage]

See: Idiom

Song of Songs 8:8–9 (#1)

אָחֹ֣ות לָ֔נוּ קְטַנָּ֖ה וְשָׁדַ֣יִם אֵ֑ין לָ֔הּ מַה־נַּעֲשֶׂ֥ה לַאֲחֹתֵ֖נוּ בַּיּ֥וֹם שֶׁיְּדֻבַּר־בָּֽהּ: אִם־חֹומָ֣ה הִ֔יא נִבְנֶ֥ה עָלֶ֖יהָ טִירַ֣ת כָּ֑סֶף וְאִם־דֶּ֣לֶת הִ֔יא נָצ֥וּר עָלֶ֖יהָ לְוּחַ־אָֽרֶז

“A sister {belongs} to us—a little one— and breasts there are not for her. What will we do for our sister on the day when it is spoken for her?If she {is} a wall, we will build on her a battlement of silver. And if she {is} a door, we will enclose over her boards of cedar”

Since the author does not say who is speaking here, you should not indicate who you think is speaking

explicitly in the text of your translation. However, the majority of Bible scholars think that the woman's brothers are speaking. Because of this and because the phrases **A sister belongs to us** and **What will we do for our sister** in 8:8 seem to indicate that the woman's brothers are speaking, you can place a header above 8:8–9 indicating that the woman's brothers are speaking.

See: When to Keep Information Implicit

Song of Songs 8:9 (#1)

אִם־חוֹמָ֣ה הִ֔יא נִבְנֶ֥ה עָלֶ֖יהָ טִירַ֣ת כָּ֑סֶף

"If she {is} a wall, we will build on her a battlement of silver"

Here the woman's brothers are speaking of their sister as if she were **a wall** that they would protect by building **a battlement of silver** on it. The meaning could be: (1) that they would protect her virginity by guarding her, like a wall that has a battlement can be guarded. Alternate translation: [We will protect her virginity like we would protect a wall by building a battlement of silver on it]; (2) that her chest was flat because her breasts were not fully formed, and they would try to make her attractive for the man she was going to marry by adorning her with silver jewels. Alternate translation: [If her chest is flat like a wall, we will decorate it by putting silver jewels that are like towers on it]

See: Metaphor

Song of Songs 8:9 (#2)

וְאִם־דֶּ֣לֶת הִ֔יא נָצ֥וּר עָלֶ֖יהָ לַ֣וּחַ אָֽרֶז

"And if she {is} a door, we will enclose over her boards of cedar"

Here the woman's brothers are speaking of their sister as if she were **a door** that they would **enclose** with **boards of cedar**. The meaning could be: (1) that they would make an effort to protect her virginity. Alternate translation: [We will protect her virginity like we would enclose a door with boards of cedar]; (2) that her chest was flat because her breasts were not fully formed, and so they would try to make her more attractive for the man she was going to marry by adorning her the way they would decorate a door with cedar wood. (The word the ULT translates as **enclose** is identical in form to another word which means "decorate" so "decorate" could be the intended meaning here.) Alternate translation: [And if she is flat like a door, we will decorate her like we would decorate a door with planks of cedar wood]

See: Metaphor

Song of Songs 8:10 (#4)

וְשָׁדַ֖י כַּמִּגְדָּלֽוֹת

"and my breasts {are} like towers"

The woman is saying that her breasts are large **like towers**. If it would be helpful in your language, you could state that explicitly. Alternate translation: [and now my breasts are large] or [and now my breasts are fully grown]

See: Simile

Song of Songs 8:10 (#6)

הָיִ֖יתִי בְּעֵינָֽיו

"I was, in his eyes"

Here, **his eyes** represent his evaluation or estimation. If it would be helpful in your language, you could use an equivalent expression or state the meaning plainly. Alternate translation: [I am, in his judgment] or [he thinks of me] or [I was, in his opinion]

See: Metonymy

Song of Songs 8:10 (#7)

כְּמוֹצְאֵ֥ת

"like a person who finds"

The word the ULT translates as **finds** could mean: (1) "finds." If you choose this option, translate this word in a similar way to the ULT. (2) "brings." Alternate translation: [like a person who brings]

Song of Songs 8:10 (#5)

אָ֣ז

"then"

The word translated as **then** indicates that what follows is a result of what came before. Use a connector in your language that makes it clear that what follows is a result of what came before. Alternate translation: [this is why] or [as a result]

See: Connect — Reason-and-Result Relationship

Song of Songs 8:10 (#3)

וְשָׁדַ֖י

"and my breasts {are"

Alternate translation: [but now my breasts are]

Song of Songs 8:10 (#1)

אֲנִ֤י חוֹמָה֙ וְשָׁדַ֣י כַּמִּגְדָּלֹ֔ות אָ֖ז הָיִ֣יתִי בְעֵינָ֑יו כְּמֹוצְאֵ֖את שָׁלֹֽום

“I {was} a wall and my breasts {are} like towers; then I was, in his eyes, like a person who finds peace”

The author does not say who is speaking here so you should not indicate who you think is speaking in the text of your translation. However, if you are using section headers to indicate who is speaking, you can place a header above 8:10 indicating that the speaker is the woman.

See: When to Keep Information Implicit

Song of Songs 8:10 (#2)

אֲנִ֤י חוֹמָה֙

“I {was} a wall”

Here the woman continues the metaphor that her brothers began in the preceding verse by referring to herself as **a wall**. She could: (1) be indicating that she had remained a virgin. Alternate translation: [I was like a wall and remained a virgin]; (2) be referring to her chest by saying that in the past her breasts were not fully formed. Alternate translation: [My chest was previously flat like a wall]

See: Biblical Imagery — Extended Metaphors

Song of Songs 8:10 (#8)

הָיִ֣יתִי בְעֵינָ֑יו כְּמֹוצְאֵ֖את שָׁלֹֽום

“I was, in his eyes, like a person who finds peace”

Here the word **peace** refers to “favor.” If it would be helpful to your readers, you could include this information. Alternate translation: [I found favor in his eyes]

See: Assumed Knowledge and Implicit Information

Song of Songs 8:11 (#1)

בְּבַ֣עַל הָמ֔וֹן

“in Baal Hamon”

Baal Hamon is the name of a place. The name **Baal Hamon** means “master of wealth, wealthy master, possessor of abundance.” Because the meaning of the name has significance here, you could include a footnote indicating that.

See: How to Translate Names

Song of Songs 8:11 (#3)

נָתַ֤ן אֶת־הַכֶּ֙רֶם֙ לַנֹּטְרִ֔ים

“He gave the vineyard to keepers”

Alternate translation: [He rented the vineyard to keepers] or [He leased the vineyard to keepers] or [He agreed to let keepers pay him so they could grow grapes in the vineyard]

Song of Songs 8:11 (#4)

אִ֣ישׁ יָבִ֗א בְּפִרְיֹו֙ אֶ֣לֶף כָּ֔סֶף

“Each person brought in exchange for its fruit a thousand {pieces of} silver”

Here the phrase **its fruit** refers to the fruit of **the vineyard**, and the phrase **Each person** refers to each of the **keepers**. If it would be helpful to your readers, you could include this information. Alternate translation: [Each keeper brought in exchange for the fruit of the vineyard a thousand pieces of silver] or [Each keeper brought Solomon a thousand pieces of silver as payment for the fruit of the vineyard]

See: Assumed Knowledge and Implicit Information

Song of Songs 8:11 (#2)

לַנֹּטְרִ֔ים

“to keepers”

Here, **keepers** are farmers who rent land from an owner and farm it. The **keepers** paid Solomon **a thousand pieces of silver** to farm his land. If your readers would not be familiar with this type of farmer, you could use the name of something similar in your area, or you could use a more general term. Alternate translation: [to people who would pay him to let them farm it] or [to men who would pay him so that they could farm it]

See: Translate Unknowns

Song of Songs 8:11 (#5)

אֶ֣לֶף כָּֽסֶף

“a thousand {pieces of} silver”

Alternate translation: [a thousand silver coins]

See: Biblical Money

Song of Songs 8:11–12 (#1)

כֶּ֚רֶם הָיָ֣ה לִשְׁלֹמֹ֔ה בְּבַ֥עַל הָמ֖וֹן נָתַ֣ן אֶת־הַכֶּ֑רֶם לַנֹּטְרִ֗ים אִ֣ישׁ יָבִ֗א בְּפִרְיֹו֙ אֶ֣לֶף כָּ֔סֶף׃ כַּרְמִ֥י שֶׁלִּ֖י לְפָנָ֑י הָאֶ֣לֶף לְךָ֤ שְׁלֹמֹה֙ וּמָאתַ֣יִם לְנֹטְרִ֔ים אֶת־פִּרְיֹֽו׃

“There} was a vineyard for Solomon in Baal Hamon. He gave the vineyard to keepers. Each person brought in exchange for its fruit a thousand {pieces of} silver.My vineyard that {belongs} to me {is} to my face. The thousand {belong} to you, Solomon, and the two hundred {belong} to the people who {are} keepers of its fruit”

Because the author does not say who is speaking, you should not indicate who is speaking in the text. If you are using section headers to indicate who is speaking, the speaker could be: (1) the woman in both 8:11 and 8:12. If you decide that the woman is speaking, you can include both verses under the section heading for 8:10 indicating that. (2) the man in both these verses. If you decide the man is speaking, you can put a section header at the top of 8:11 indicating that.

See: When to Keep Information Implicit

Song of Songs 8:12 (#4)

הָאֶלֶף לְךָ שְׁלֹמֹה

“The thousand {belong} to you, Solomon”

Here the woman could be: (1) speaking as if **Solomon** is present with her even though he is not, in order to use him as an example. If it would be helpful in your language, you could translate these words as if the woman is speaking about Solomon and not to him. Alternate translation: [The thousand belong to Solomon]; (2) calling the man she loves **Solomon** (even though he is not Solomon) as a term of endearment, similar to how she called the man she loved “The king” in 1:4. Alternate translation: [The thousand belong to you, the man I love, you who are like king Solomon] or [The thousand belong to you, the man I love, you whom I call Solomon]

See: Apostrophe

Song of Songs 8:12 (#2)

לְפָנָי

“is} to my face”

The phrase **is to my face** means “is mine to give.” If it would be helpful in your language, you could use an equivalent expression or plain language. Alternate translation: [is at my disposal] or [is mine to do with as I desire] or [is mine to give to whom I choose]

See: Idiom

Song of Songs 8:12 (#3)

הָאֶלֶף לְךָ שְׁלֹמֹה וּמָאתַיִם לִנֹטְרִים אֶת־פִּרְיוֹ

“The thousand {belong} to you, Solomon, and the two hundred {belong} to the people who {are} keepers of its fruit”

Here the word **thousand** refers to the “thousand pieces of silver” in the previous verse. The phrase **the two hundred** refers to the two hundred pieces of silver that Solomon would have paid to **the people who are keepers** of the vineyard’s fruit. If it would be helpful to your readers, you could include this information. Alternate translation: [The thousand pieces of silver belong to you, Solomon, and the two hundred pieces of silver belong to the people whom you pay to be keepers of the vineyard’s fruit]

See: Assumed Knowledge and Implicit Information

Song of Songs 8:12 (#1)

כַּרְמִי

“My vineyard”

Here the phrase **My vineyard** is a metaphor (see the section on 8:12 in the chapter introduction for the meaning of this entire verse). It could be: (1) the woman referring to herself as a vineyard, as she did in 1:6. Alternate translation: [I am like a vineyard] or [My body is like a vineyard]; (2) the man referring to the woman he loves as if she were his vineyard. Alternate translation: [The woman whom I love is like my vineyard] or [The woman whom I love is like a vineyard]

See: Metaphor

Song of Songs 8:13 (#2)

חֲבֵרִים

“companions are”

Here the term **companions** is masculine in form in the original language and most likely refers to the man’s friends who were shepherds and were mentioned in 1:7. See how you translated the term **companions** in 1:7.

See: When Masculine Words Include Women

Song of Songs 8:13 (#3)

לְקוֹלֵךְ

“for your voice”

Here the word **voice** could: (1) represent the woman’s words. Alternate translation: [to hear you speak]; (2) refer to the sound of the woman’s voice. Alternate translation: [to hear your voice]

See: Metonymy

Song of Songs 8:13 (#1)

הַיּוֹשֶׁבֶת בַּגַּנִּים חֲבֵרִים מַקְשִׁיבִים לְקוֹלֵךְ הַשְׁמִיעֵנִי

“You} who reside in the gardens; companions are listening intently for your voice— let me hear it”

The author does not say who is speaking in this verse so you should not indicate who you think is speaking in the text. However, if you are using section headers to indicate who is speaking, you could place a header above this section indicating that the man is speaking.

See: When to Keep Information Implicit

Song of Songs 8:14 (#4)

עַל הָרֵי בְשָׂמִים

“on the mountains of spices”

Here the woman is speaking of herself as if she is the **mountains of spices** and she wants the man she loves to come to her and enjoy her body. If it would be helpful in your language, you could state the meaning plainly.

See: Metaphor

Song of Songs 8:14 (#1)

בְּרַח ׀ דּוֹדִי וּדְמֵה־לְךָ לִצְבִי אוֹ לְעֹפֶר הָאַיָּלִים עַל הָרֵי בְשָׂמִים

“Flee, my beloved, and resemble a gazelle or a young stag on the mountains of spices”

The author does not say who is speaking in this verse so you should not indicate who you think is speaking in the text. However, if you are using section headers to indicate who is speaking, you could place a header above this section indicating that the woman is speaking.

See: When to Keep Information Implicit

Song of Songs 8:14 (#3)

דּוֹדִי וּדְמֵה־לְךָ לִצְבִי אוֹ לְעֹפֶר הָאַיָּלִים

“my beloved, and resemble a gazelle or a young stag”

See how you translated the similar expression, “My beloved is resembling a gazelle or a young stag” in 2:9.

See: Simile

Song of Songs 8:14 (#2)

בְּרַח

“Flee”

Here the word **Flee** means “come quickly.” If it would be helpful to your readers, you could include this information. Alternate translation: [Come quickly] or [Hurry]

See: Assumed Knowledge and Implicit Information